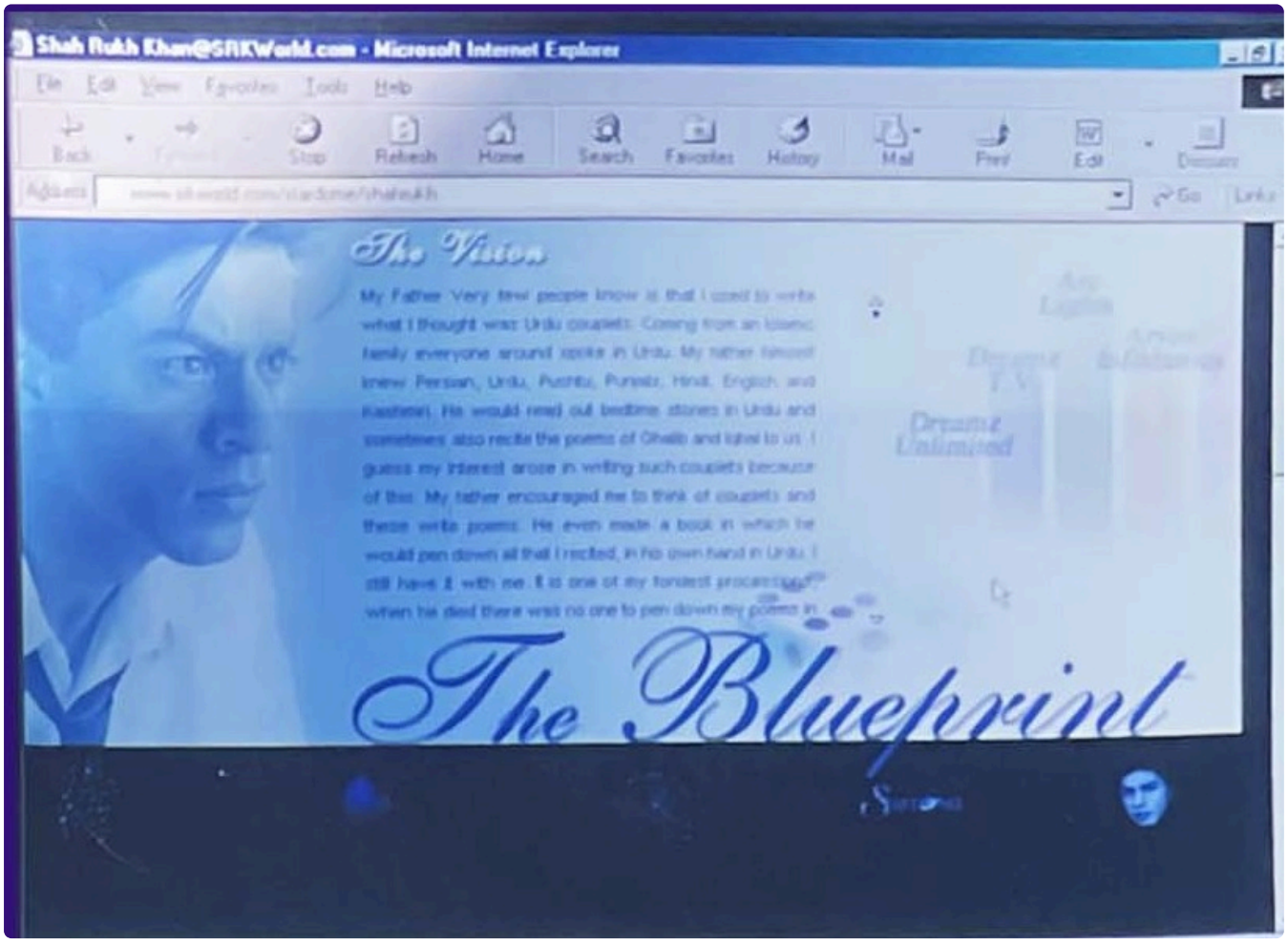
SRK: The Man, The Myth, The King

Oct 12, 2026 · @Shah Rock Jaan

The first 360-degree thesis on Shah Rukh Khan: the man, the myth his fans now write themselves, and the King he became. Working manuscript; chapters are added daily.

The Blueprint



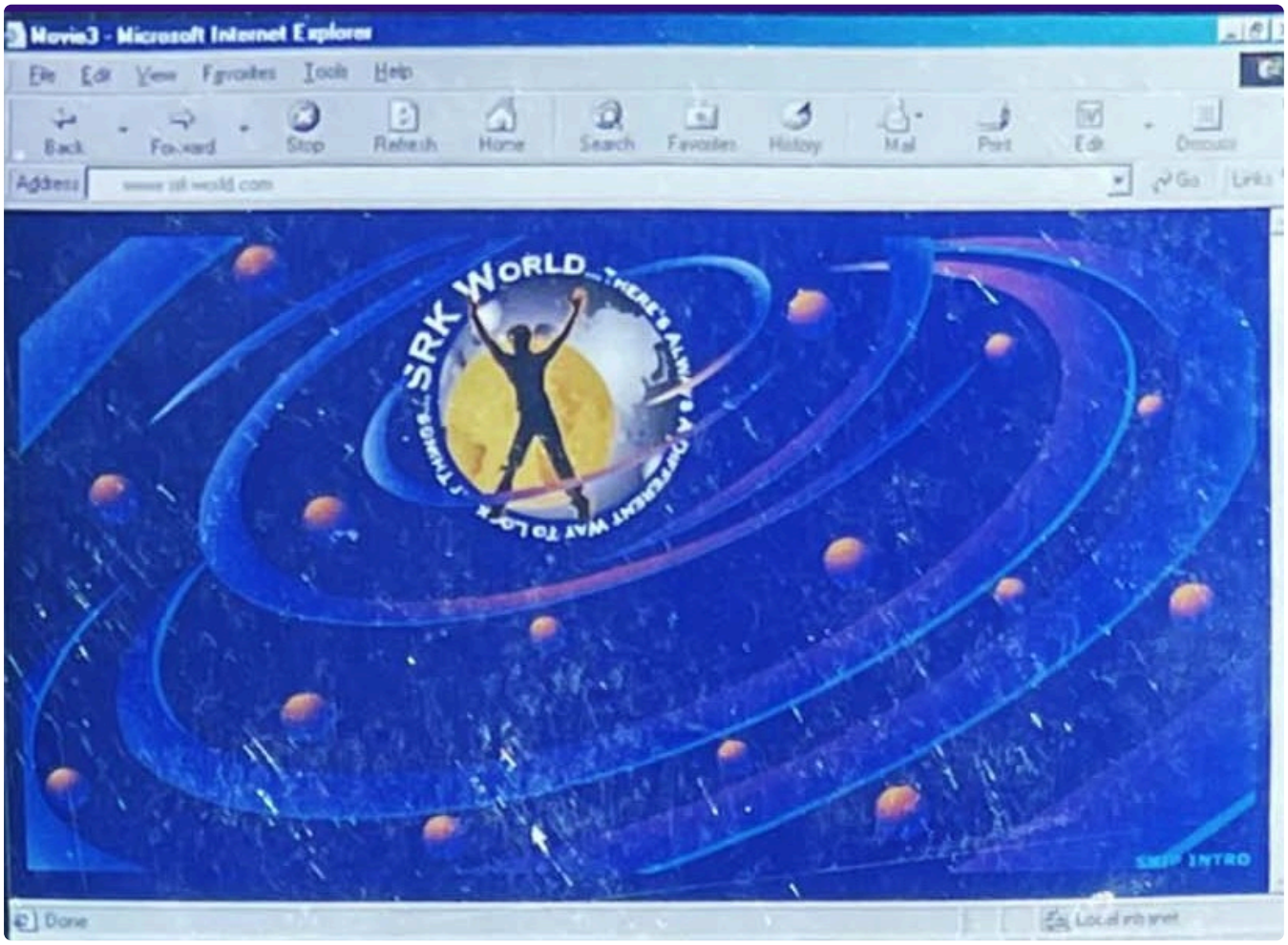
SRKWorld.com, 2000: "The Blueprint", the page where he mapped his own life. (Archive: the author's collection; designed by the author with Shah Rukh Khan)

In 2000 Shah Rukh Khan mapped his own life. On SRKWorld.com, the website he and the author built together, he divided himself into rooms: *Diaper Days*, *From School To Cool*, *Campus Cackle*, *TV Cereal*, *The Wall*, *Going Digital*, *Opening Office*, *ArclightZ*, *Advantage*, *Tall Tales*, *Just Like That*, *Ram To Krishna* and *The Galleria*. *(Eyewitness account; Archive: SRKWorld screen photographs, 2000)*

This book walks through that map. Its chapters carry the names he chose in 2000, in the order his life happened. Where the story runs past 2000, into years his website never saw, the new chapters take new names in the same voice: *Mute Button*, *Encore*, *KING Size*, *Fan*

Mail and *Log Out*. Between the Parts sit the rooms that are not about a year but about a side of him: how he sells, what he says, how he balances home and work. *(Interpretation)*

It is also raw material. It gathers, checks and orders the public record of a life, so that when the man writes his own story, the facts are already in one place. *(Interpretation)*



SRKWorld.com, 2000: the home page, a galaxy of rooms. (Archive: the author's collection)

How to read this thesis

Three voices run through every chapter, and they are never mixed.

- **Fact**: from the public record, with its source.
- **Eyewitness account**: what the author saw from inside the campaigns and the years around them. The author, Shailja Gupta, co-founded SRKWorld with Shah Rukh Khan in 2000 and led the digital strategy for Ra.One and Chennai Express.
- **Interpretation**: the author's reading of the evidence, marked as such.

A fourth kind of evidence appears where it applies: **Archive**, photographs and documents from the author's own collection, reproduced in the chapter with their dates.

A claim marked **[Unverified]** happened, but its exact figure, date or source is still being confirmed. It stays on the page so the reader sees what is known and what is still being checked.

The arc in one page

This book follows one relationship, between a star and his audience, through six Parts, in the order things happened.

- **Part One · The Man · Rise, 1946 to 2009.** A boy from Delhi reaches the whole country through a single television channel, becomes the face of a new India, and in 2000 tries to build his own digital line to his fans, years before the industry knew what the internet was for.
- **Part Two · One Before Zero · The Marketing Express, 2010 to 2013.** He turns that line into a system: a film taken to NASDAQ, a superhero who lived online before he lived on screen, a train that ran on its audience.
- **Part Three · Asoka to Boo-Da · Mute Button, 2014 to 2022.** The founder steps back from the story. The films still sell but stop travelling, Zero falls, and in October 2021 the man loved by a billion people stands alone at his own gate. He goes silent.
- **Part Four · Encore · The return, 2023 to 2026.** He comes back without asking to be seen: three films in one year, two past ₹1,000 crore, almost no interviews, and an empire built in the quiet.
- **Part Five · KING Size · 2026.** Before the studio has shown a frame, the fans are making KING themselves, with AI, and asking who owns his face.
- **Part Six · Log Out · What the arc means.** Zero to One: the codes of the career, the lessons, and the model it leaves behind.

One thread runs through all six: the direct line. Doordarshan in 1989. SRKWorld in 2000. Twitter, Google+ and a train between 2010 and 2013. Silence, while the fans kept the line open. And in 2026, a line the fans build themselves. *(Interpretation)*

Prologue · If not for Shah Rukh Khan

Behind closed doors, everyone says the same thing.

> *"If not for Shah Rukh Khan, then for whom will the largest democracy in the world stand behind?"*

This is a country that won its independence in 1947 through the grit and tenacity of non-cooperation. Millions of ordinary people stood in streets, refused, marched and waited, until the most powerful empire on earth had to listen. Standing together in silence is

something India invented.

In October 2021 that tradition failed him. When his son was taken into custody, the road outside his house was empty. *(Eyewitness account; told in full in Part Three, Chapter 13)*

This thesis does not argue the case. The courts did that. It asks a different question, the one nobody asked out loud.

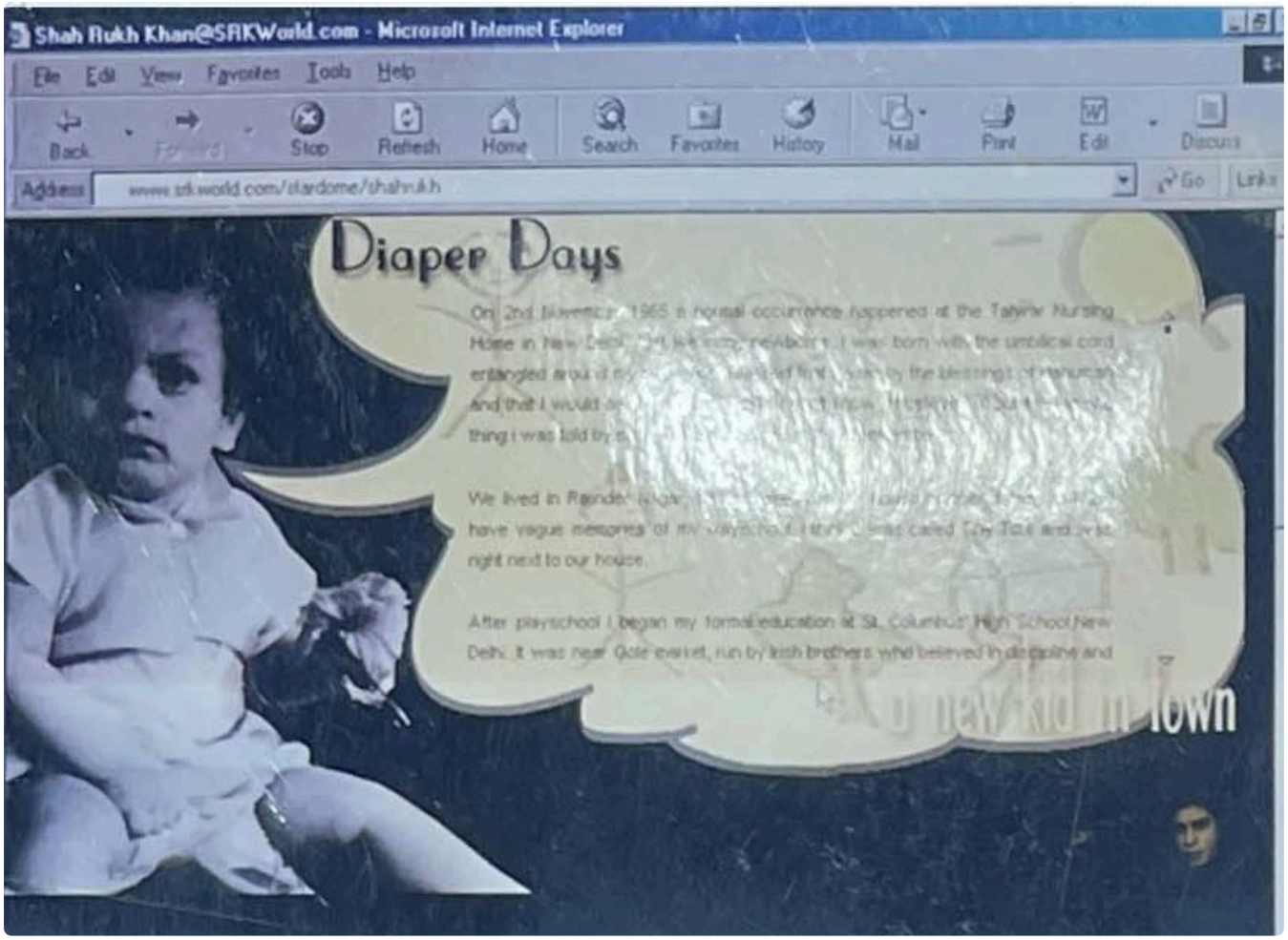
What does it mean to be loved by a billion people, and to stand alone at your own gate?

To answer it, we have to go back to the beginning. To a boy from Delhi who built the most powerful relationship between a star and his audience that Indian cinema has seen. To a man who turned that relationship into a digital kingdom before the industry knew what the internet was for. To the silence, the resurrection, and the film he calls KING. *(Interpretation)*

Part One · The Man · Rise, 1946 to 2009

1946 to 2009. How an outsider from Delhi became the most recognisable face in Indian cinema, tried to build a digital kingdom before the internet was ready, and became an institution. Facts in this book are from Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan unless another source is named.

Chapter 1 · Diaper Days · Childhood, 1946 to 1975



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Diaper Days". (Archive: the author's collection)

The story starts before him. In 1946 Mir Taj Mohammed Khan, a young activist from Peshawar, came to Delhi to study law. He had campaigned with the Khudai Khidmatgar, the non-violent movement of Abdul Ghaffar Khan, the "Frontier Gandhi", and was affiliated with the Indian National Congress. Partition came the next year. He stayed in Delhi and did not see Peshawar again for many years. *(Fact)*

His son was born in New Delhi on 2 November 1965 and spent his first five years in Mangalore. The family lived a middle-class life in rented flats in Rajendra Nagar. *(Fact)*

Two families. His mother, Lateef Fatima, was a magistrate and the daughter of a senior government engineer; she and Mir Taj Mohammed Khan married in 1959. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* Her father, Iftikhar Ahmed, was chief engineer of the port at Mangalore in the 1960s, which is why the boy born in Delhi spent his first five years on the Karnataka coast. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* He had one sibling, an elder sister, Shahnaz Lalarukh, born in 1960. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

Many Indias in one boy. He has said his paternal grandfather was a Pashtun from Afghanistan. His father's cousins in Peshawar have said the family speaks Hindko and came originally from Kashmir. In 2010 he described himself as Hyderabadi on his mother's

side, half Pathan on his father's, and partly Kashmiri through his grandmother. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The accounts do not fully agree, and this book records them side by side rather than choosing one. *(Interpretation)* What they share is the shape of the man: a north-western father, a southern mother, a Delhi childhood and a Mumbai career, a Muslim who would marry into a Hindu family and raise children in both faiths. He would later sell that shape to the whole country as an idea of India. *(Interpretation)*

The father. The young lawyer from Peshawar did not practise for long. He ran several businesses, including a restaurant, and the family lived in rented flats in Rajendra Nagar. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* A 2026 report names the restaurant as Khatir and says Mir Taj Mohammed Khan also ran the mess at the National School of Drama. *(Fact. The Siasat Daily, 22 June 2026)* [Unverified: the restaurant's name and the NSD contract need a primary source, such as an NSD record or a family statement.] It is widely reported that he once stood for Parliament. [Unverified: the constituency, the year and the result need an Election Commission record before this book states them.]

The boy in the wings. In a 2014 interview he said he went to the National School of Drama every day after school while waiting for his sister, and spent much of his childhood among its actors. *(Fact. Times of India interview, 2014, as reported by The Siasat Daily, 22 June 2026)* The actor Pankaj Kapur, then a student at NSD in the mid-1970s, has recalled that a boy of about ten supplied the samosas at the interval, and that the boy was Shah Rukh Khan. *(Eyewitness account, Pankaj Kapur, on Kindle Cast, as reported by The Siasat Daily)* Kapur was unsure whether the boy's father or an uncle ran the canteen. [Unverified: which family member held the NSD canteen.]

Before he saw a film set, he grew up at the back of India's national drama school, carrying food to actors between acts. *(Interpretation)* The boy who served in the interval became the man whom crowds wait for outside his gate. Chapter 3 returns to the stage; Chapter 18 returns to the crowd. *(Interpretation)*

The father's dates. A photograph of his gravestone, published online in 2021, gives Mir Taj Mohammed Khan's birth as 27 October 1927, in Peshawar. *(Fact. Alt News, 29 Oct 2021, citing the photograph)* The date fits his son's tweet of 27 October 2014, which said his father would have been 87 that day. *(Fact. Alt News, citing the tweet)* The same check records that he was arrested during the Quit India movement of 1942, was in and out of jail for the next two years, and reached Delhi in 1946 to study law at Delhi University. *(Fact. Alt News, citing the biographies* King of Bollywood *and* Shahrukh Khan: The Story of the Man*)* It rated as false a viral claim that he was six years old in 1942. *(Fact. Alt News)* The young man who arrived in Delhi in 1946 was about nineteen and had already been to jail for his politics. *(Interpretation)*

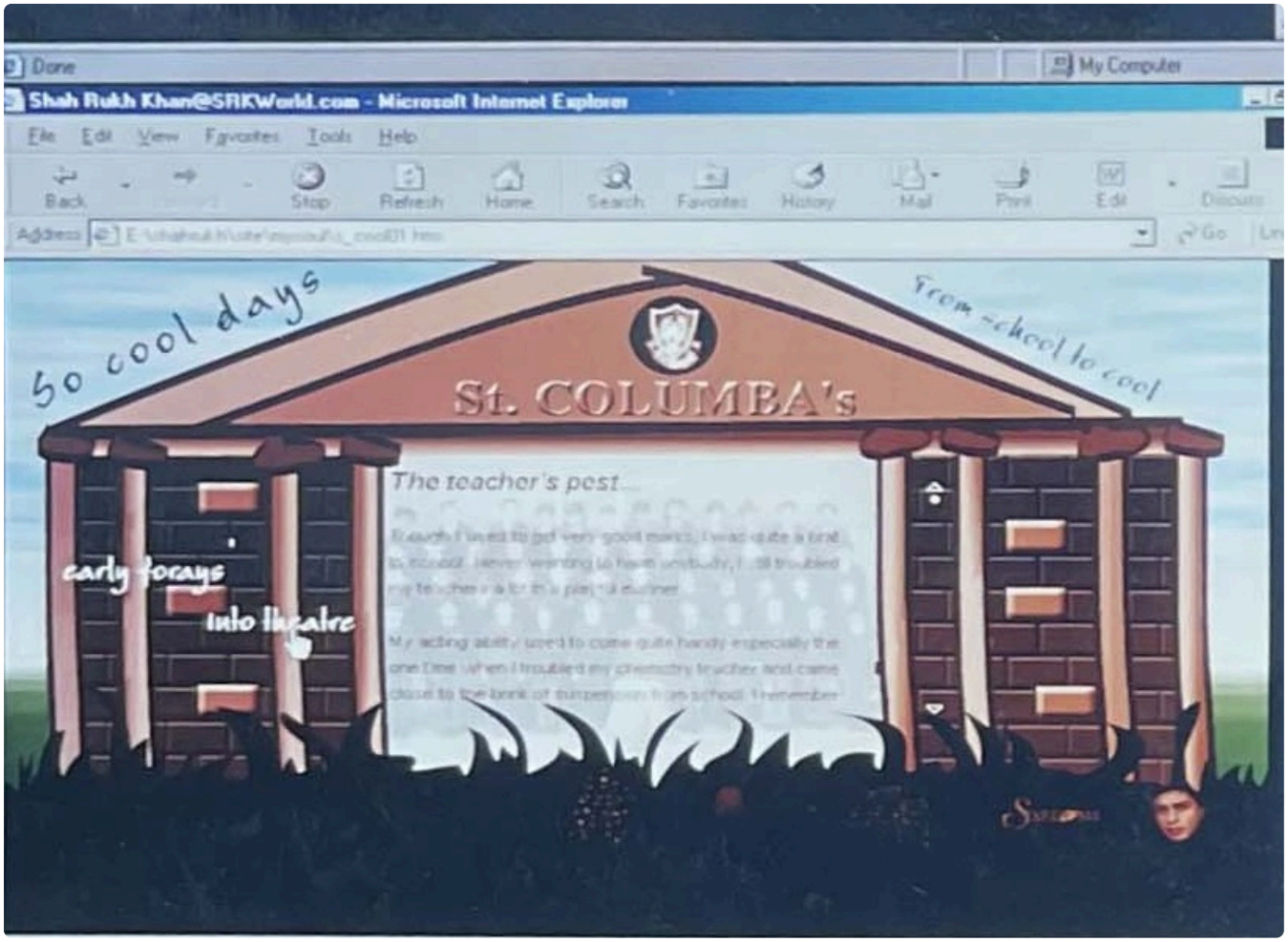
The ballot of 1957. The election archive IndiaVotes lists three candidates for the Gurgaon seat in the 1957 Lok Sabha election: Maulana Abul Kalam Azad of the Congress, who won with 191,221 votes (66.68%); Mool Chand of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, with 95,553; and an independent named Taj Mohammad, for whom it records no votes. Azad's margin was 95,668. *(Fact. IndiaVotes: Gurgaon, 1957)* Several reports identify that independent as Shah Rukh Khan's father. *(Fact. NewsBytes; BollywoodShaadis)* [Unverified: that the Taj Mohammad on the 1957 Gurgaon ballot is Mir Taj Mohammed Khan, and his real vote count; the Election Commission's statistical report for 1957 would settle both.] If the reports are right, a Peshawar-born lawyer of about thirty, with no party behind him, put his name on the same ballot as India's first education minister. *(Interpretation)*

Born between two wars. He was born six weeks after the ceasefire of 23 September 1965 that ended India's second war with Pakistan, the country that now held his father's birthplace. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Indo-Pakistani war of 1965)* He was nine when the Emergency was declared on 25 June 1975, the year this chapter closes. *(Fact. Wikipedia: The Emergency)* This book records the dates and draws no conclusion about what a child made of them. *(Method note)*

What the website said. In 2000 he gave his childhood its own room on his website and called it *Diaper Days*: a baby photograph and a first-person account of a Delhi birth. *(Archive: the author's collection, the screen above)* No other Indian star of the time put his own childhood online in his own words. [Unverified: a survey of Indian celebrity websites in 2000 would confirm or correct this.] The section title is his joke, not this book's. *(Eyewitness account, the author)*

What this chapter carries forward. A father who believed in non-violent resistance and lost his homeland to Partition; a mother who sat in judgement as a magistrate; a sister he would later look after; a childhood spent watching actors from the wings. *(Interpretation)* Every one of these returns: the father in Chapter 13, the sister in Room · Ram To Krishna, the wings in Chapter 3. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 2 · From School To Cool · School, 1970 to 1985



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "From School To Cool", set at St. Columba's. (Archive: the author's collection)

At St. Columba's School he was good at everything: studies, hockey, football. He won the Sword of Honour, the school's highest award. A shoulder injury ended any hope of a career in sport. *(Fact)*

His father died of cancer in 1981. He was fifteen. *(Fact)*

The school. St. Columba's is a Christian Brothers' school in central Delhi. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* One of its teachers, Brother Eric D'Souza, became the first mentor of his life. On the television show *Jeena Isi Ka Naam Hai*, hosted by Farooq Sheikh, he called D'Souza the one person he looked up to after his parents, and the guiding light of his life. *(Fact. The Week, 14 October 2024)* He said the Brother kept his boys out of trouble by channelling their energy into football, hockey, the guitar and music. *(Fact. The Week)* Brother Eric D'Souza died in Goa on 13 October 2024, aged 74. *(Fact. The Week)*

The first stage. At school he acted in plays and was praised for his impressions of Dilip Kumar, Amitabh Bachchan and the actress Mumtaz. His childhood friend and acting partner was Amrita Singh, who became a film star before him. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Sixteen years later his website still carried the memory: the musings page *Just Like That* had tabs

named *In School* and *Mumtaz*. *(Archive: the author's collection; see Room · Just Like That)* An impressionist learns stars from the outside before he becomes one; he studies the walk, the voice and the pause. *(Interpretation)*

The award and the injury. The Sword of Honour is St. Columba's highest award, given to an all-rounder. He won it. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* [Unverified: the year of the award, from the school's records.] A shoulder injury ended his hopes of a career in sport. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The body he had trained for the hockey field went, a few years later, into an army uniform on television (Chapter 4). *(Interpretation)*

1981. His father died of cancer in 1981, when the son was fifteen. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The mother kept the family going. *(Fact. The Siasat Daily, 22 June 2026)* [Unverified: what she ran after 1981 and for how long; the Siasat report says she continued the business, without detail.]

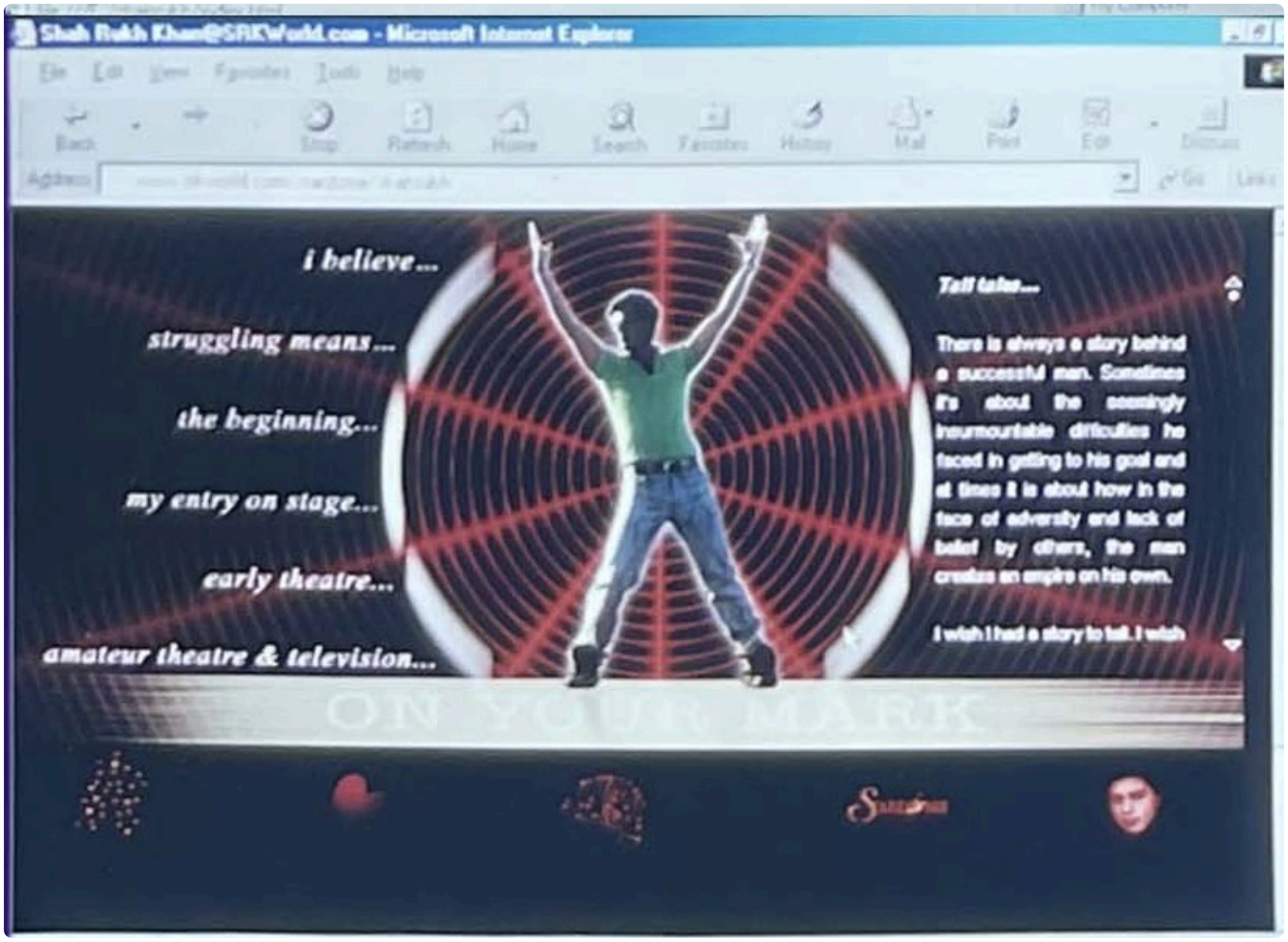
1984. In 1984, in Delhi, he met Gauri Chhibber. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)* She was a Punjabi Hindu; he was a Muslim with no film career and no father. Seven years later they married (Chapter 4). *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan; Interpretation)*

The marks. In December 2025 an image went viral that appears to be his admission form for Hansraj College, listing his Class XII marks: 92 in his elective paper, 78 in mathematics, 78 in physics and 51 in English. *(Fact. WION, 2 Dec 2025)* WION said it could not verify the image. [Unverified: the form's authenticity and the exam year, from Hansraj College's admission records.] If the form is genuine, the boy who would later win the country with words scored his lowest mark in English and two of his highest in mathematics and physics: the economics student came before the actor. *(Interpretation)*

The college he chose. He studied for a bachelor's degree in economics at Hansraj College from 1985 to 1988, and when the college later honoured its alumni with shields at its fiftieth anniversary, he was among them. *(Fact. Millennium Post, 6 May 2013)* [Unverified: the year of the anniversary ceremony.]

From school to cool. The title is his, from the 2000 website. *(Archive: the author's collection)* It names the turn this chapter covers: the head boy with a sword and a hockey stick becomes the college student who lives in a rehearsal room. *(Interpretation)* He left school in 1985 for Hansraj College. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

Chapter 3 · Campus Cackle · College and theatre, 1985 to 1988



SRKWorld.com, 2000: the page on his struggle and early theatre. (Archive: the author's collection)

From 1985 to 1988 he studied economics at Hansraj College, but spent most of his time at the Theatre Action Group, learning to act from the director Barry John. He began a master's in mass communication at Jamia Millia Islamia, and left it to act. *(Fact)*

The son of a man who believed in non-violent resistance. Remember that when you reach 4 October 2021. *(Interpretation)*

The rehearsal room. The Theatre Action Group was founded in Delhi in 1973 by Barry John, a British director who had arrived in India in 1968 and stayed. *(Fact. Outlook, 6 February 2022)* John has staged more than 100 productions in Hindi and English, and the actors who trained with him in the TAG years include Raghuvir Yadav and Manoj Bajpayee as well as Shah Rukh Khan. *(Fact. Outlook)* [Unverified: the TAG plays he acted in, with years and roles, from Barry John or the group's programmes.]

What theatre gave him. Delhi theatre in the 1980s was poor, serious and collective: no stars, no close-ups, and a live audience that could walk out. *(Interpretation)* The Bombay film industry of the time trained its heroes in the mirror and the gym; he arrived trained in

the rehearsal room. *(Interpretation)* Critics later compared his television work to Dilip Kumar's. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The exam he passed and the degree he did not finish. After graduating he cleared the entrance examination for the Indian Institutes of Technology, because his mother insisted. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* [Unverified: the year and the exam's name.] He joined the master's programme at Jamia Millia Islamia's Mass Communication Research Centre, and could not sit the final-year examination because his attendance was short. *(Fact. The Tribune, 22 February 2019)* The film director Kabir Khan was his junior there and studied from his notes. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* He is also recorded as having attended the National School of Drama. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* [Unverified: in what capacity; he is not listed as an NSD graduate.]

In 2018 Jamia asked the government's education ministry for permission to give its former student an honorary doctorate. The ministry declined, reportedly because he already held one from the Maulana Azad National Urdu University (2016). *(Fact. The Tribune, 22 February 2019)*

Mass communication. The subject he left unfinished became the work of his life. *(Interpretation)* Twelve years later he built the first personal website of an Indian film star (Chapter 6); in 2011 he ran the most connected digital campaign Indian cinema had seen (Chapter 9). *(Interpretation; see those chapters for the sources)* The classroom taught him the theory; Delhi's theatres taught him the audience. *(Interpretation)*

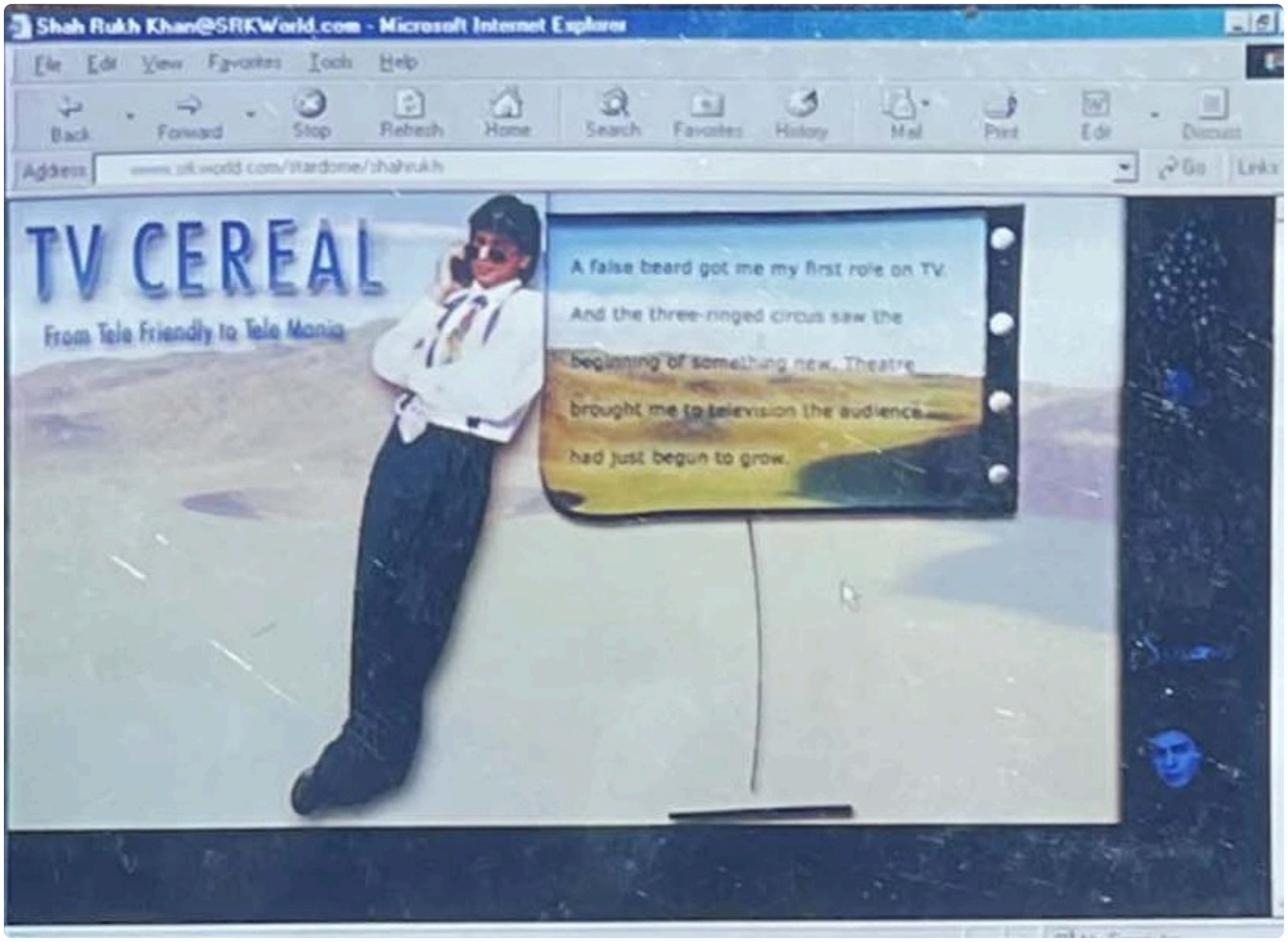
The teacher. Barry John, born in 1944, ran the Theatre Action Group from 1973 to 1999. He received the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award for theatre direction in 1993, and in 1997 opened the Imago acting school in Delhi, which moved to Mumbai in March 2007. *(Fact. Millennium Post, 6 May 2013)* Asked about his most famous student around Teacher's Day 2013, John said the young Khan "was destined to be a somebody", and named the reasons: talent, perseverance, self-belief, a refusal to give up, and some luck. He added: "Nobody can make anybody." *(Fact. DNA, September 2013, as reproduced on India Forums, 6 Sept 2013)* [Unverified: the original DNA article's date and link.] He also called him one of the most intelligent people he had met. *(Fact. same source)*

The company he kept. Manoj Bajpayee trained in the same Delhi group. He has recalled that money was so short the young actors passed one cigarette around rather than smoke one each, and that Khan stayed with the group only briefly before moving to Mumbai, while Bajpayee stayed on until Shekhar Kapur cast him in *Bandit Queen*. *(Eyewitness account, Manoj Bajpayee, Bollywood Hungama, last updated 17 Dec 2024)* Years later Bajpayee appeared in *Veer-Zaara* (2004). *(Fact. same source)* One poor rehearsal room in Delhi produced two of the most admired screen actors of the next thirty years, by two opposite routes: one left fast for the mass audience, the other stayed for the craft and reached the mass audience later. *(Interpretation)*

A school without a school. Delhi in the mid-1980s gave a young actor three free classrooms: the National School of Drama, where he had watched rehearsals as a boy (Chapter 1); Barry John's group, where he learned to work on a stage; and Doordarshan, which was about to need new faces (Chapter 4). *(Interpretation; facts as cited in those chapters)* He used all three before he was twenty-four, and none of them gave him a certificate. *(Interpretation)*

Campus Cackle. The title is from his 2000 website, where this period sat under a page about struggle and early theatre. *(Archive: the author's collection)* By 1988 the student actor had his first lead role on television, in a series that would be delayed for so long that another show reached the screen first (Chapter 4). *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

Chapter 4 · TV Cereal · Television, 1988 to 1991



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "TV Cereal". (Archive: the author's collection)

He was meant to debut in a serial called *Dil Dariya*, but it was delayed, so the country first met him in 1989 as Abhimanyu Rai, the lead of *Fauji*. He followed it with *Circus* (1989 to 1990), directed by Aziz Mirza, and parts in *Umeed*, *Wagle Ki Duniya* and the English-language television film *In Which Annie Gives It Those Ones*. *(Fact)*

Fauji premiered on DD National on 18 January 1989: thirteen episodes about army recruits training to become commandos, directed by Lt. Col. Raj Kumar Kapoor. He was cast as a second lead. Kapoor said the camera "loved him so much" that the script was rewritten to make him the lead. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Fauji; Scroll, 7 Dec 2015)* Three years later he told *India Today*: "In six-and-a-half hours I became the nation's heartthrob." *(Fact. quoted in The Hollywood Reporter India, Nov 2024)*

The show's success brought work with the production company Iskra: *Umeed*, *Wagle Ki Duniya* and *Circus*. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* *Circus* ran for nineteen episodes on DD National in 1989 and 1990, directed by Aziz Mirza and Kundan Shah, with him as Shekharan Rai. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Circus)* Aziz Mirza went on to direct *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman* (1992), and in 1999 he, Juhi Chawla and Shah Rukh Khan founded Dreamz Unlimited, the company that later became Red Chillies. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* The circus tent of 1989 is where the business partnership of 1999 began. *(Interpretation)*

In Which Annie Gives It Those Ones (1989), Arundhati Roy's first screenplay, directed by Pradip Krishen, gave him a small early part. It aired once on Doordarshan and then all but disappeared. Restored in 4K from the original negative, it was selected for the Berlinale Classics in 2026. *(Fact. The Statesman, 22 Jan 2026)*

How he got Fauji. The part was first meant for the director's own son. Raj Kumar Kapoor wanted a new face instead, and his son-in-law, a property dealer who had met the young Khan while showing houses, put his name forward. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India, 28 November 2024)* The audition was a run of a mile and a half at dawn, followed by boxing. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* Other actors gave the director trouble; Khan did not, and the storyline and screen time moved to Lieutenant Abhimanyu Rai. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* The sportsman who lost his sport to a shoulder injury (Chapter 2) won his first role by running and boxing. *(Interpretation)*

Iskra: the first mentors. Iskra was a Bombay production house run by Kundan Shah, Aziz Mirza and Saeed Mirza. After *Fauji* they cast him in *Umeed*, *Wagle Ki Duniya* and *Circus*, and mentored him. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* All three men recur in this book. Kundan Shah directed him again in *Kabhi Haan Kabhi Naa* (Chapter 5). Aziz Mirza became his business partner in Dreamz Unlimited (Room · ArclightZ). A Mumbai dealer with a link to Saeed Mirza arranged his first meeting with Hyundai in 1998 (Room · Advantage). *(Fact. as cited in those sections)* The people he met in his first year on television built the next decade of his career with him. *(Interpretation)*

Idiot. Saeed Mirza also suggested him to Mani Kaul, who cast him as Pawan Raghurajan in an adaptation of Dostoevsky's *The Idiot*. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India; Wikipedia: Idiot (1992 film))* The film opened at the New York Film Festival in October 1992 and was shown in Mumbai in October 2016 as *Ahamaq*. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The sources disagree on

television: Wikipedia records a four-part Doordarshan miniseries in 1991, while The Hollywood Reporter India says it never aired. [Unverified: the Doordarshan broadcast, from the channel's records.] In the same years, the boy from the Delhi theatre worked with the art cinema of Mani Kaul and Arundhati Roy and with the mass television of *Fauji*. *(Interpretation)*

Television in 1989. India had one national channel, Doordarshan. Every *Fauji* episode reached the whole television audience at once; there was no other channel to watch. *(Interpretation)* [Unverified: the number of television households in India in 1989, from Doordarshan or the census.] Six and a half hours of air time, thirteen half-hour episodes, were enough to make him known across the country. *(Fact. 13 episodes, The Hollywood Reporter India; his 1992 line, as above)*

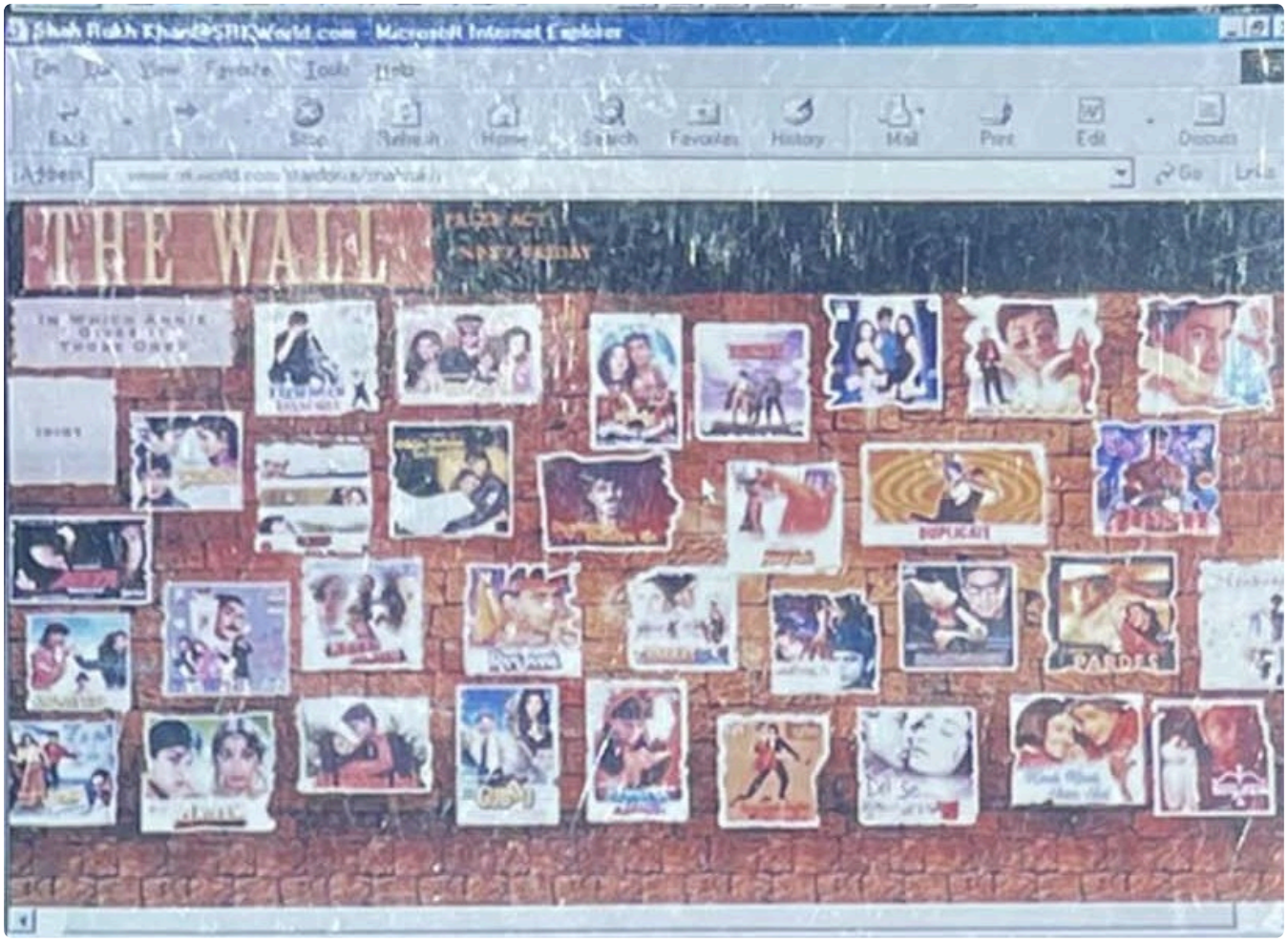
In 1991 his mother died. In April that year he decided to act in films and moved from Delhi to Mumbai, taking on the care of his older sister, Shahnaz. On 25 October 1991 he married Gauri. *(Fact. Marriage: Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)*

The first film he signed, that same year, was Hema Malini's *Dil Aashna Hai*. By the time it released, on 25 December 1992, *Deewana* had already made him a film star. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Dil Aashna Hai)*

Television was his first direct line into people's homes. A single national channel, one evening a week, and a whole country watching the same face. It was a mass medium with no middleman, and he would spend the next thirty-five years looking for its successor: his own website in 2000, Twitter, Google+, and in 2026 the fans' own AI. *(Interpretation)* The beginning keeps coming back: Doordarshan re-ran *Circus* during the 2020 lockdown and *Fauji* in 2024. *(Fact. ETV Bharat, 28 Mar 2020; The Hollywood Reporter India)*

He arrived with no film family, no godfather and no money, a television face in an industry of dynasties. Everything he built after that, he built in public. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 5 · The Wall · Films, 1992 to 1998: the villain who became the lover



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "The Wall", his films as posters on a brick wall. (Archive: the author's collection)

A country opening up. He arrived in Bombay in the year India changed course. In July 1991 the government began dismantling the licence raj and opened the economy. On 2 October 1992 Zee TV went on air as the country's first private Hindi satellite channel, and Doordarshan's monopoly on the evening was over. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Zee TV; WION)* A new middle class was about to discover brands, satellite channels and itself. It needed a new kind of hero, one who looked like it: urban, quick, self-made, a little dangerous. *(Interpretation)*

1992: four films in one year. The first film he signed was Hema Malini's *Dil Aashna Hai*; he was shooting it by June 1991. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* But the first to reach cinemas was *Deewana*, released in June 1992, in which he was the second male lead to Rishi Kapoor, opposite Divya Bharti. It was a hit and won him the Filmfare Award for Best Male Debut. *(Fact)* *Chamatkar*, *Dil Aashna Hai* and *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman* followed the same year, his first films as the lead. *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman*, directed by Aziz Mirza from the *Circus* days, began a long screen partnership with Juhi Chawla. *(Fact)* On television he was still working too: Mani Kaul's *Idiot* aired in 1992. *(Fact)*

Critics noticed the energy before the craft. One later described the early Khan "sliding down stairs on a slab of ice, cartwheeling, somersaulting". *(Fact. Arnab Ray, DNA, quoted in Wikipedia)* He was not the most polished actor in the room. He was the one you could not stop watching. *(Interpretation)*

1993: the anti-hero. Then he did what no aspiring romantic hero did. He played villains. In *Baazigar*, directed by Abbas-Mustan, he was a murderer and an ambiguous avenger. It was a hit, his first film with Kajol, and it won him his first Filmfare Award for Best Actor. In *Darr*, his first film with Yash Chopra and Yash Raj Films, he was an obsessive lover stalking Juhi Chawla, and the stammered "I love you, K-k-k-Kiran" passed into everyday speech. *Darr* was also a hit, and earned him a nomination for Best Performance in a Negative Role. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* In the same year *Maya Memsaab* ran into the censors over a nude scene; he avoided such scenes afterwards. *(Fact)*

The convention of the time was simple: the hero is good, the villain is someone else. Khan collapsed the two. Audiences who should have recoiled from the stalker and the killer cheered for them, because he played them as wounded men rather than monsters. *(Interpretation)*

1994: the actor's actor. *Anjaam*, opposite Madhuri Dixit, gave him another obsessive role and the Filmfare Award for Best Performance in a Negative Role. *Kabhi Haan Kabhi Naa*, Kundan Shah's small film about a lovable loser, won him the Filmfare Critics Award for Best Performance. He has called it his favourite role. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Kundan Shah had co-directed *Circus*. Once again, the people who backed him on television were the ones who gave him his best early work. *(Interpretation)* The director Mukul S. Anand called him "the new face of the industry". *(Fact. quoted in Wikipedia)*

1995: the year that never ended. He had seven releases in 1995. *Karan Arjun*, directed by Rakesh Roshan, with Salman Khan and Kajol, was the second-highest-grossing film of the year in India. *(Fact)* The highest was *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*, Aditya Chopra's debut as a director, released on 20 October 1995. *(Fact. Wikipedia: DDLJ)*

DDLJ was made on a budget of about ₹4 crore. It grossed about ₹102.5 crore worldwide according to one estimate, ₹89 crore of it in India; another source puts its worldwide total near ₹200 crore by 1996. *(Fact. Wikipedia: DDLJ, citing Times Now, 20 Oct 2022, and other sources; the figures differ by source and date)* It won ten Filmfare Awards, a record at the time, including his second for Best Actor, and the National Film Award for Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment. *(Fact)*

It was the first Hindi blockbuster with non-resident Indians as its main characters. It helped turn the diaspora into a market studios could bank on, ran for more than a year in the United Kingdom, and started a trend of films shot abroad for audiences abroad. *(Fact.*

Wikipedia: DDLJ) Raj, the NRI boy who would not elope but waited for the father's blessing, gave a generation living between two countries a hero who belonged to both. *(Interpretation)*

At Mumbai's Maratha Mandir it has screened daily since 20 October 1995. It overtook *Sholay* as the longest-running film in Indian cinema in 2001 and reached 1,000 weeks in December 2014. *(Fact. Wikipedia: DDLJ; CNN, 2015)* When the cinema announced in February 2015 that the run would end after 1,009 weeks, fans protested and the run was reinstated. It had reached 1,251 weeks by March 2020, paused for the lockdown, and resumed in November 2020. *(Fact. Wikipedia: DDLJ)* No marketing department kept that film alive. Its audience did. *(Interpretation)*

1996: the fall. All four of his releases in 1996 failed, critically and commercially. *(Fact)* The rise had not been a straight line, and the industry that had crowned him a year earlier began to ask whether the moment had passed. *(Interpretation)*

1997: the comeback, and the first son. *Yes Boss*, again with Aziz Mirza and Juhi Chawla, earned a Best Actor nomination. *Pardes*, directed by Subhash Ghai, cast him as Arjun, a musician, and was among the first major Hindi films to succeed in the United States. *Dil To Pagal Hai*, his second film with Yash Chopra, won him his third Filmfare Award for Best Actor. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* That year he also performed on stage abroad, in Asha Bhosle's *Moments in Time* concert in Malaysia. *(Fact)*

On 13 November 1997 his first child, Aryan, was born. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Aryan Khan)* Three years later he named his first technology company after him. *(Eyewitness account; see Chapter 6)*

1998: Dil Se and Kuch Kuch. *Duplicate*, a double role for Mahesh Bhatt and his first film with Dharma Productions, was poorly received. *(Fact) Dil Se..*, directed by Mani Ratnam and released on 21 August 1998, cast him as an All India Radio correspondent drawn to a woman who turns out to be a suicide bomber. Its song "Chaiyya Chaiyya" was shot on the roof of a moving train on the Nilgiri line. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Dil Se..)* At home it was only an average grosser, about ₹28.4 crore on a ₹11.5 crore budget. Abroad it became the first Indian film to enter the UK top 10, earned about $975,000 in the United States, and won the NETPAC Award at the Berlin International Film Festival. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Dil Se..)*

Two months later, on 16 October 1998, came Karan Johar's debut, *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*. It was the highest-grossing Hindi film of 1998 in India: about ₹80 crore at home and about $6.3 million abroad, roughly ₹107 crore worldwide on a ₹10 crore budget. *(Fact. Box Office India, via Wikipedia: Kuch Kuch Hota Hai)* It became the second Bollywood film in the UK top 10, after *Dil Se..*, won eight Filmfare Awards and the National Award for Best Popular Film, and won him the Filmfare Best Actor award for the second year running. *(Fact)* The same year he toured the UK, Canada and the US with Juhi Chawla, Akshay Kumar and Kajol in *The Awesome Foursome*. *(Fact)*

By the end of 1998 the pattern was set. The films travelled, and he went with them, on stage, in person, to the audiences who had found him first on video cassettes and satellite channels. The diaspora was not an afterthought to his career. It was half of it. *(Interpretation)*

The three films that built the wall, in numbers

Measure	Baazigar (1993)	Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge (1995)	Kuch Kuch Hota Hai (1998)
Released	12 November 1993, Diwali	20 October 1995	16 October 1998, Diwali
Director	Abbas–Mustan	Aditya Chopra	Karan Johar
Reported budget	₹3 crore	₹4 crore	₹10 crore
Gross	₹32 crore in India	₹102.5 crore worldwide (about ₹1,115 crore at today's prices, as estimated)	about ₹106.7 crore worldwide (₹80.12 crore India, ₹26.61 crore overseas)
Filmfare awards won	4, including his first Best Actor	10, then a record for one film	8, including Best Film, Director, Actor and Actress
What it proved	A villain could be the hero	The diaspora was a market	The overseas market could be counted in millions of dollars

(Fact. Wikipedia: Baazigar; Wikipedia: Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge; Wikipedia: Kuch Kuch Hota Hai, October 2026; the last row is Interpretation)

Gross against budget. Baazigar returned about ten times its budget in India alone; DDLJ about 25 times worldwide; Kuch Kuch Hota Hai about 10 times. *(Fact, this book's arithmetic from the table; gross is not profit)* Kuch Kuch Hota Hai was the first Bollywood film to pass US$5 million overseas, and the second, after his own *Dil Se..* earlier that year, to enter Britain's box-office top ten. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kuch Kuch Hota Hai)* Both of the first two Hindi films in the UK top ten were his. *(Fact, as above)*

The longest run. DDLJ overtook *Sholay* as the longest-running film in Indian cinema in 2001, passed 1,000 weeks at Mumbai's Maratha Mandir in December 2014, survived an announced end in February 2015 after fans protested, and had reached 1,251 weeks by March 2020. *(Fact. Wikipedia: DDLJ)* [Unverified: whether it is still showing in October

2026, and the current week count, from the cinema.] It was a fan campaign before the word existed: the audience kept a film alive for a quarter of a century. *(Interpretation; see Chapter 21)*

The brands followed him, and so did their risks. In 1998 Hyundai, a carmaker almost unknown in India, launched the Santro with him as its face. He was hesitant to lend his name to a brand few had heard of. The partnership became one of the longest in Indian advertising, about 26 years by 2024, and Hyundai became the country's second-largest carmaker. *(Fact. Storyboard18)*

Open arms on a mustard field. The *sur*, the note everyone hummed. The myth that KING now plays against was written in these six years. *(Interpretation)*

Room · Ram To Krishna · Home and work

A room, not a year: how a man who works without stopping keeps a home. Marriage to Gauri Khan in 1991, the children, Mannat, and the balance beam between the domestic and the professional that he named on his own website. *(Interpretation)*

This room has no SRKWorld screen: none survives in the archive photographs. *(Archive: the author's collection)* What follows is from the public record. The private life of the family is not this book's subject; where they chose to go public, it is. *(Interpretation)*

Two losses, one move. His father died in 1981 and his mother in 1991, of complications of diabetes. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* A 2026 report gives 1990 for her death. [Unverified: the year of Lateef Fatima's death, 1990 or 1991, from a primary record.] In April 1991 he decided to act in films, partly as a way of coping with her death, and moved to Mumbai. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* His elder sister, Shahnaz Lalarukh, fell into depression after their parents died. He took on her care, and she still lives with his family. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The marriage. He married Gauri Chhibber on 25 October 1991, seven years after they met. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)* There were three ceremonies on one day: civil, Hindu and the nikah. *(Fact. Business Today, 11 July 2026)* He follows Islam and respects his wife's Hindu faith; their children are raised in both, and at home the Qur'an sits beside Hindu deities. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)* The couple began married life in a house in Panchsheel Park, Delhi. In July 2026 it was reported that he had bought its remaining floors, for about ₹37 crore, and now owned the whole building. *(Fact. Business Today, 11 July 2026, citing Moneycontrol)*

The children.

Child	Born	Public work	Source
Aryan Khan	1997	Voiced a role beside his father in the Hindi dub of *The Incredibles* (2004). BFA in film and television production, USC School of Cinematic Arts. Co-founded SLAB Ventures and the luxury label D'YAVOL (2022). Created and directed *The Ba***ds of Bollywood*, seven episodes, Netflix, 18 September 2025, produced by Red Chillies.	Khaleej Times, 2 November 2025; Wikipedia
Suhana Khan	2000	Trained at NYU's Tisch School of the Arts. Short film *The Grey Part of Blue* (2019). Feature debut as Veronica Lodge in Zoya Akhtar's *The Archies* (Netflix, 2023). Reported co-star of *KING* (Chapter 16).	Khaleej Times, 2 November 2025
AbRam Khan	2013, through a surrogate mother	No professional work; seen with his father at cricket matches and fan events.	Wikipedia: Gauri Khan; Khaleej Times

The family's hardest public year, 2021, is in Chapter 13, from the public record only. *(Interpretation)*

Mannat. In 2001 he bought Villa Vienna, a sea-facing bungalow on Bandstand in Bandra West, from the Bai Khorshed Bhanu Sanjana Trust, for a reported ₹13 crore to ₹13.32 crore. *(Fact. Boldsky, 15 July 2026)* It already carried heritage status (Grade III). Reports say he first named it Jannat, "paradise", then Mannat, "a prayer granted". *(Fact. Boldsky)* [Unverified: the date of the renaming.] Gauri Khan designed the interiors herself, and her interest in interior design began there; it became Gauri Khan Designs. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)* Its reported value in 2026 was ₹250 crore to ₹300 crore. *(Fact. Boldsky)* [Unverified: a valuation by a named valuer.]

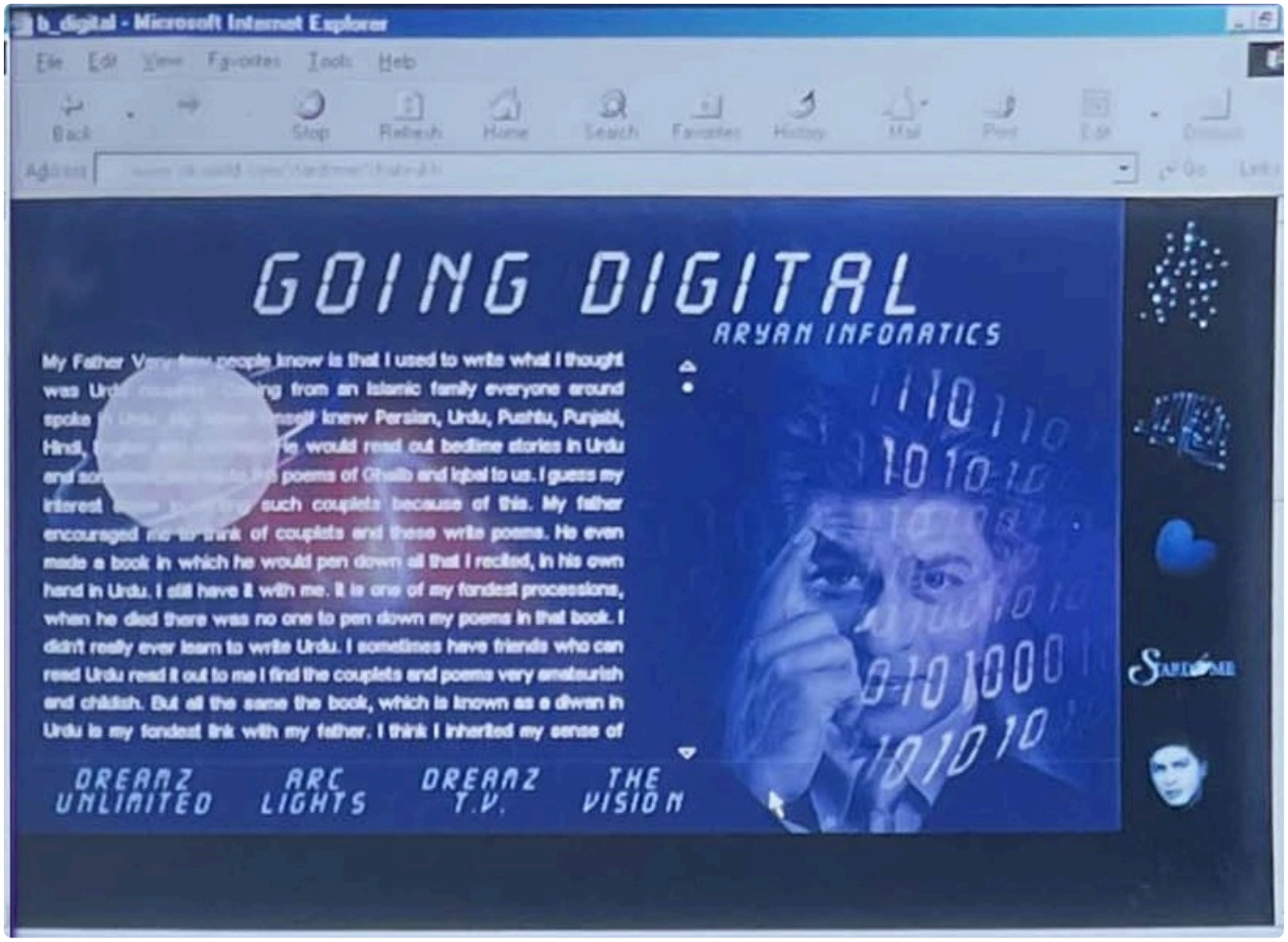
The year he bought Mannat was the year SRKWorld closed and *Asoka* failed at the box office (Chapter 6). *(Interpretation)* The home was bought in the worst year of the business.

The gate. On his birthday, 2 November, and on Eid, fans gather outside Mannat and he waves to them from a raised balcony. *(Fact. Boldsky; Deccan Herald, 2 November 2025)* On his 60th birthday, 2 November 2025, the authorities advised him not to step out because of crowd safety and the renovation, and he posted on X: "I will miss seeing you more than you will." *(Fact. Deccan Herald)* The house is often called the third most photographed place in India, after the Taj Mahal and the Gateway of India. [Unverified: no measurement behind this claim has been found.] No other film star's front gate is a pilgrimage site. The street outside is where the fan franchise of Chapter 21 begins. *(Interpretation)*

The renovation. In February 2025 the family was reported to be moving out of Mannat for a renovation of up to two years. Red Chillies leased four floors of Puja Casa in Pali Hill from Vashu Bhagnani's family, on a three-year leave and licence agreement, at a reported ₹24 lakh a month. *(Fact. Business Today, 26 February 2025)* The plan adds two floors to the annexe. It received coastal-zone clearance, and on 14 July 2026 the Supreme Court dismissed a petition challenging that clearance. *(Fact. Boldsky, 15 July 2026)*

Where home and work meet. The family business is also the film business. Gauri Khan co-founded Red Chillies and produces its films (Room · ArclightZ); Aryan's first series was a Red Chillies production; Suhana is reported to act with her father in *KING*. *(Fact, as sourced above; Interpretation)* Ram to Krishna: he named this page himself on the 2000 website. *(Archive: the author's collection)* [Unverified: his own explanation of the title; the author's recollection is to be added.] The epic hero of duty, and the god of play and love: the title holds both halves of the man this book describes. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 6 · Going Digital · The producer, the website and the fall, 1999 to 2003



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Going Digital", under the Aryan Infomatics name. (Archive: the author's collection)

The myth was written. In 1999 he set out to own a share of it. *(Interpretation)*

1999: the star becomes a producer. He had one release that year, *Baadshah*, a comic caper opposite Twinkle Khanna. It underperformed at the box office but earned him a Filmfare nomination for Best Performance in a Comic Role. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* The bigger move of the year happened off screen. In 1999 he became a producer, as a founding partner of Dreamz Unlimited with Juhi Chawla and Aziz Mirza, the director who had given him *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman* in 1992. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; Juhi Chawla's own Wikipedia entry dates the company to 2000: Wikipedia: Juhi Chawla)* Between 1999 and 2003 the partnership produced three films. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

Baadshah, by the trade's numbers. *Baadshah* was released on 27 August 1999, directed by Abbas–Mustan and produced by Ganesh Jain with Bhawar and Girish Jain. Made for ₹11 crore, it grossed ₹31.60 crore worldwide, and Box Office India rated it "Average". *(Fact.*

Wikipedia: Baadshah (1999 film)) The two pages read the same result differently: "underperformed" on his own page, "Average" in the trade verdict on the film's. *(Fact; the two sources differ in wording)*

The partners were the same three people who had made his first comedy hit. A star who had been hired for ten years now wanted to choose the story, cast it and keep a share of what it earned. *(Interpretation)*

The audience was changing its address too. In August 1999 B4U Movies launched in the United Kingdom on Sky Digital, and within six months it was on television platforms in the United States, Canada, Europe and the Middle East. One of its founders was Kishore Lulla. *(Fact. Wikipedia: B4U (network))* The diaspora that had found him on video cassettes in the 1990s could now watch Hindi films on a dedicated channel. A year later Lulla's name would appear again, on the list of promoters of his website. *(Fact. exchange4media, 15 Nov 2000; see below)*

January 2000: the first production. *Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani*, directed by Aziz Mirza, opened on Friday 21 January 2000 across 240 screens. It was the debut production of Dreamz Unlimited, made on a budget of ₹13 crore. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani)* He and Juhi Chawla played rival television reporters in a satire on the news channels' race for ratings. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani)*

It opened a week after *Kaho Naa... Pyaar Hai*, the debut of Hrithik Roshan, and failed. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* It grossed about ₹25.46 crore worldwide, ₹18.20 crore of it in India, and Box Office India declared it a flop. Khan later called it the biggest failure for Juhi, Aziz and himself. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani)* The music did well, and the film's special effects won an IIFA award. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani)*

Two reporters, two channels. He played Ajay Bakshi of KTV; Juhi Chawla played Ria Banerjee of Galaxy TV. Jatin–Lalit composed the songs and Javed Akhtar wrote all the lyrics. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani)*

The first film he owned was about the media. Its target was television news chasing ratings. Its subject was the question that would run through his career: who controls the picture the audience sees. *(Interpretation)*

The rest of 2000 kept him in front of the camera. In February he made his Tamil debut in Kamal Haasan's bilingual *Hey Ram*, in a supporting role he played free of charge. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* He played a Goan gang leader in *Josh* and made special appearances in *Har Dil Jo Pyar Karega* and *Gaja Gamini*. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography)*

Hey Ram and Josh, by the numbers. *Hey Ram* opened on 18 February 2000, in Tamil and Hindi at once. He played Amjad Ali Khan, a Pathan friend of Kamal Haasan's hero, and dubbed his own lines. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Hey Ram)* The film cost ₹11 crore, excluding Haasan's salary, and failed commercially; the Hindi version grossed ₹8.91 crore in India and $550,000 overseas. It was India's entry for the Academy Awards and was not nominated. *(Fact. same source)*

Josh, directed by Mansoor Khan, followed on 9 June 2000, with him as Max Dias, twin brother of Aishwarya Rai's Shirley. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Josh (2000 film))* Made for ₹16 crore, it grossed ₹35.06 crore worldwide, ₹30.05 crore of it in India, and Box Office India rated it "Average". *(Fact. same source)* It was also his debut as a singer, on "Apun Bola" with Hema Sardesai; the album sold about 1.8 million units, the year's ninth-best seller. *(Fact. same source)*

Venus, twice. *Josh* was produced by Ganesh, Ratan and Champak Jain under the Venus Films banner, and *Baadshah* by Ganesh Jain with Bhawar and Girish Jain. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Josh (2000 film); Wikipedia: Baadshah (1999 film))* In November 2000 a music company named Venus joined SRKWorld's film-music library (see below). *(Fact. Bollywood Hungama, Nov 2000)* **[Unverified: whether Venus Films and the Venus music label named at the SRKWorld launch are the same Jain family business]** If they are, the producers of two of his three releases with a full role outside his own company in 1999 and 2000 were also partners in his portal. *(Interpretation)*

2000: the internet year. The internet had arrived in India only five years earlier. On 15 August 1995 the state-owned VSNL launched the first public service, at 9.6 kbit/s, priced at ₹5,200 for 250 hours. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Internet in India)* For the next decade most Indian users stayed on narrow-band connections below 56 kbit/s. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Internet in India)*

The connection gap, 1999 to 2004.

Year	Internet users per 100 people (World Bank, calendar year)	Internet subscriptions, end of March (TRAI)	Mobile subscriptions, end of March (TRAI)	Fixed telephone lines, end of March (TRAI)
1999	0.27	N/A (TRAI series starts March 2000)	N/A (TRAI series starts March 2000)	N/A (TRAI series starts March 2000)
2000	0.53	0.95 million	1.90 million	26.65 million
2001	0.66	3.04 million	3.58 million	32.71 million

Year	Internet users per 100 people (World Bank, calendar year)	Internet subscriptions, end of March (TRAI)	Mobile subscriptions, end of March (TRAI)	Fixed telephone lines, end of March (TRAI)
2002	1.54	3.42 million	6.54 million	38.33 million (38.43 million in another TRAI table)
2003	1.69	3.64 million	13.00 million	41.49 million
2004	1.98	4.55 million	33.69 million	42.84 million

(Fact. World Bank, World Development Indicators, via FRED series ITNETUSERP2IND; TRAI, Performance Indicators for FY 2003-04, July 2004. The two series measure different things: people using the internet in a calendar year, and paid connections at the end of a financial year. TRAI's mobile totals include limited-mobility WLL, and it marks the data provisional.)

When srkworld.com went live, the World Bank figure for 2000 meant about one Indian in 190 used the internet at all. *(Interpretation, arithmetic on the table)* Over the four years of this chapter, mobile subscriptions grew almost eighteen times, from 1.90 million to 33.69 million, while internet subscriptions stayed under five million. *(Interpretation, arithmetic on the table)* The device that would one day carry his audience was arriving; the connection his site needed was not. *(Interpretation)*

The law for a website. The Information Technology Act, 2000, which gave electronic records and digital signatures legal recognition and defined offences such as hacking, was notified on 17 October 2000, four weeks before srkworld.com went live. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Information Technology Act, 2000)* The same page gives two dates for presidential assent, 9 May and 9 June 2000. *(Fact. same source; the page is inconsistent)*

The money, though, believed in it. Satyam Infoway listed on NASDAQ in October 1999. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Sify)* On 14 June 2000 Rediff.com followed, raising $55.2 million at $12 a share and closing its first day at 19-5/16. *(Fact. CNN Money, 14 June 2000)* Satyam paid ₹325.4 crore on 30 June 2000 for the rest of the portal IndiaWorld. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Sify)* By then the bubble had already peaked: NASDAQ reached 5,048 on 10 March 2000. *(Fact. Goldman Sachs: the 2000 dot-com bubble)*

Television moved faster. On 3 July 2000 *Kaun Banega Crorepati* premiered on Star Plus with Amitabh Bachchan as host, took the channel to number one for the first time and reinvented his career. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kaun Banega Crorepati)* The older star went back to the medium that had made the younger one. The younger one went looking for the next medium. *(Interpretation)*

Aryan Infomatics: building the line. With Dreamz Unlimited came something no Indian star had tried: a website of his own, srkworld.com. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* It was launched through a technology company called Aryan Infomatics, named after his first son, Aryan. The author co-founded it with him and co-led it as co-CEO. The two of them designed the site's interface themselves, in Photoshop, Illustrator and Dreamweaver. *(Eyewitness account)* The company's registered name appears in the trade press of the time as Aryan Informatics (I) Pvt. Ltd. *(Fact. Bollywood Hungama, Nov 2000)*

The platform's technology was built by a second company, TechShastra India Pvt Ltd, which the author co-led as co-CEO with Nishith Shah, with Khan as its silent partner. *(Eyewitness account)* **[Unverified: TechShastra's registration papers or incorporation date]**

This was the first direct line since Doordarshan. In 1989 a state channel had carried him into every home that had a set. In 2000 he tried to build the channel himself, with his own name on the address. *(Interpretation)*

The archive shows what they built. The site's pages, photographed on Internet Explorer screens in 2000, carry its sections: "Going Digital" under the Aryan Infomatics banner, an "Opening Office" linking Aryan Infomatics, Arc Lights, Dreamz TV and The Vision, "Stardome" with pages for Juhi Chawla, Anil Kapoor, Johny Lever and Sushmita Sen, "The Wall" of film posters, "TV Cereal", "Ad-vantage" for his brand work, "Karma Cola", "Travel Bug", "The Galleria", his school days at St. Columba's, and a news page, "The Third Eye", dated 11 November 2000. The tagline ran around a globe: "There's always a different way to look at things." *(Archive: screen photographs, 2000)* Arclightz Films was the company that co-produced *Asoka* with Dreamz Unlimited the following year. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)* **[Unverified: whether "Arc Lights" on the site is the same company as Arclightz Films]**



October 2000: the teacher and the rebel. Two weeks before the website went live, the cinema gave him the year's biggest hit. Aditya Chopra's *Mohabbatein* was released on 27 October 2000 and set him, as a music teacher who believes in love, against Amitabh Bachchan as the headmaster who forbids it. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Mohabbatein)* It was the highest-grossing Indian film of the year. The worldwide figure is given as about ₹90 crore by Box Office India and as ₹76.01 crore in the film's own infobox. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Mohabbatein; the two figures disagree)* It won four Filmfare Awards, among them Best Supporting Actor for Bachchan and the Critics Award for Best Actor for Khan, his second. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Mohabbatein; Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

The same month the film business was given a new legal footing. In October 2000 the government gave films industry status under the IDBI Act of 1964, so that producers could borrow from banks. *(Fact. ICMR case study: Film insurance and financing in India)* Bank finance was slow to follow. *(Fact. ICMR, same page)*

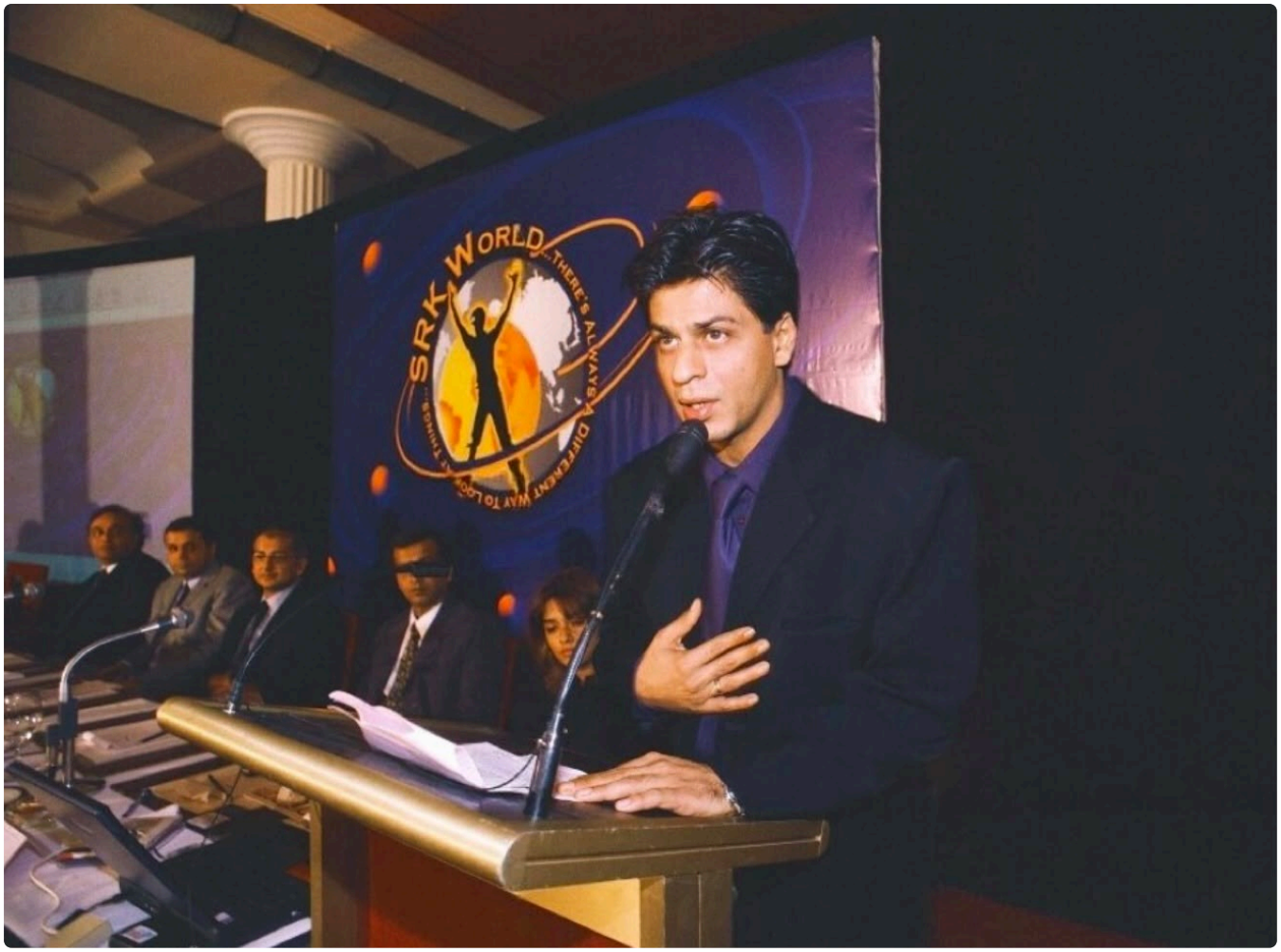
14 November 2000: srkworld.com goes live. On 14 November 2000 he presented SRKWorld himself, at a press conference in front of the SRKWorld backdrop. A preview for the press was held the day before, on 13 November. *(Archive: press conference photographs, 13 and 14 November 2000)* The launch was held at The Taj in Mumbai. *(Fact. Bollywood Hungama, Nov 2000)*

The trade press reported it the next morning. On 15 November 2000 exchange4media wrote that "film star Shah Rukh Khan has launched an entertainment portal srkworld.com", with an initial investment of $1 million. It named the promoters as the producer Bharat Shah, Kishore Lulla, the industrialist Jay Mehta and the actress Juhi Chawla, with B4U to provide software and content for broadband. *(Fact. exchange4media, 15 Nov 2000)*

Bollywood Hungama gave more detail. The company behind the portal was promoted by Khan and Juhi Chawla with Bharat Shah and Kishore Lulla "of B4U", and its board included Jay Mehta and Gauri Khan. Microsoft and Compaq were named as technical associates, and the music companies Venus and Tips joined for a film music library. *(Fact. Bollywood Hungama, Nov 2000; the page carries a wrong date, 1 June 2000, but describes the 14 November launch)* The two reports differ on B4U: exchange4media lists Bharat Shah and Kishore Lulla as promoters in their own names, while Bollywood Hungama places both at B4U, a network whose own history names Lakshmi Mittal and Kishore Lulla as founders. *(Fact. exchange4media; Bollywood Hungama; Wikipedia: B4U (network))*

The site had about 14 sections. Its main attraction was "Stardome", with official pages for Khan and Juhi Chawla, and Anil Kapoor, Sushmita Sen, Rani Mukerji, Namrata Shirodkar, Johny Lever and Santosh Sivan named as joining. It promised family photographs, stills from every film he had made, concert videos, animated films, and broadband content and live shows online. *(Fact. Bollywood Hungama, Nov 2000)* The plan was a star's portal that would also be a studio, a music library and a broadcaster, on a network where most homes still dialled in. *(Interpretation)*

The launch was widely covered at the time. By the author's count there were about 500 articles in November and December 2000, an Outlook cover with Khan and Juhi Chawla and a centre-spread story, and a live interview on CNBC. *(Eyewitness account)* **[Unverified: clippings to be added]** Much of that coverage can no longer be found online, which is why Khan asked her to put the photographs and the video below on public record. *(Eyewitness account)*



Seated at the table, left to right: Bharat Shah, Sunil Lulla (Kishore Lulla's brother), Jay Mehta, Nishith V. Shah and Shailja Gupta, the author. Shah Rukh Khan stands at the podium, presenting to the press. (Eyewitness account; Archive photograph, 14 November 2000)

The site also gave him a second self. Together, the author and he created the character ShahRocK and Bubbles, later Shah Rock Jaan. *(Eyewitness account)* **[Unverified: the year the character was first drawn, and its first appearance]** A star who had become a myth on screen now had a cartoon of himself made for the screen of a computer. *(Interpretation)*

2001: the sword and the crash. The money that had believed in the internet left as fast as it had come. NASDAQ, 5,048 at its peak in March 2000, fell to 1,139.90 by 4 October 2002, a loss of 77%. *(Fact. Goldman Sachs: the 2000 dot-com bubble)* In India the infrastructure for what srkworld.com promised did not yet exist: the government only defined broadband, as an always-on connection of at least 256 kbit/s, in its 2004 policy. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Internet in India)*

His first release of 2001, *One 2 Ka 4*, a police thriller opposite Juhi Chawla, came and went. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography)* **[Unverified: box office figure for One 2 Ka 4]** Dreamz Unlimited's second production was meant to be its comeback. *(Fact.*

Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)

One 2 Ka 4, by the numbers. It was released on 30 March 2001, directed by Shashilal K. Nair and produced by Nazir Ahmed, with Jackie Shroff in the cast and music by A. R. Rahman. Made for ₹12 crore, it grossed ₹13.82 crore worldwide, and Box Office India declared it a "disaster". *(Fact. Wikipedia: One 2 Ka 4)* Taran Adarsh gave it one star of five, calling it "handicapped by a weak script". *(Fact. same source)* The open item above stays until a trade record confirms these figures. *(Method note)*

Santosh Sivan had first approached him about *Asoka* on the set of *Dil Se..*, while Khan was dancing on the roof of a train for "Chaiyya Chaiyya". "I was hooked," Khan recalled. *(Fact. quoted in Wikipedia: Asoka)* The film, in which he played the emperor who gave up his sword, was made for about ₹12.5 crore by Dreamz Unlimited and Arclightz Films and released on 26 October 2001 across 235 screens. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)*

It was selected for the Venice and Toronto film festivals, where it was well reviewed. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)* At home it was a box-office failure: ₹11.54 crore net in India, the 13th-highest earner of the year, against $1.8 million overseas, the fourth-highest Indian film abroad that year. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)* It won Best Cinematography for Santosh Sivan at the Filmfare and IIFA awards. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)*

Critics abroad were kinder than the box office at home. In London, Peter Bradshaw of The Guardian called it "a big, brash and deeply enjoyable Bollywood epic", and all ten reviews counted by Rotten Tomatoes were positive. *(Fact. quoted in Wikipedia: Asoka)* In India his emperor divided reviewers; one called the performance "all bluster and mannerism". *(Fact. quoted in Wikipedia: Asoka)* He won Best Actor for it at the Sansui Awards. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)*

The pattern was now plain. The audience abroad followed him into new forms; the audience at home wanted him in the form it knew. *(Interpretation)* *Asoka* is also the first word of the essay that gives Part Three its name, Asoka to Boo-Da: the emperor who lays down his sword returns in Part Three as a man who goes silent. *(Interpretation)*

As the losses mounted, srkworld.com was closed. *(Fact)* Wikipedia dates the closure to 2001 and gives the losses of Dreamz Unlimited as the reason. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* **[Unverified: the exact month the site went offline]** Broadband barely existed in India, and smartphones were years away. The idea closed. The ambition did not. *(Interpretation)* Eleven years later, on a stage in Mumbai, he would describe that company to an audience as the one with which the two of them had lost everything (see Chapter 9). *(Archive: video of the event, 2011)*

The family film arrived seven weeks after *Asoka*. Karan Johar's *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham*, released on 14 December 2001 and distributed in more than 100 countries, grossed about ₹1.36 billion worldwide and $8.9 million overseas. It was the highest-grossing Indian film

overseas at the time, a record it held until *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna* in 2006. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham)* Its budget is given as ₹30 crore to ₹40 crore. *(Fact. same source)*

In London, Johar recalled, an exhibitor told him the film was third at the UK box office, behind the first Harry Potter and the first Lord of the Rings: "There are queues in the cold to see this film." *(Fact. quoted in Bollywood Hungama, 16 Oct 2023)* *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham* he calls a turning point. *(Fact)* **[Unverified: source and exact words of his "turning point" remark]**

Johar also remembered a London audience standing to applaud a scene about belonging, and what it taught him: there was "some kind of a connection" between his film and the diaspora. *(Fact. quoted in Bollywood Hungama, 16 Oct 2023)* At the 47th Filmfare Awards the film won five, including Best Actress for Kajol and Best Supporting Actress for Jaya Bachchan. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham)* The audience that had queued for *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* in 1995 was now the biggest overseas market any Indian film had found. *(Interpretation)*

The year ended in pain. In December 2001 he injured his spine during an action sequence for a special appearance in *Shakti: The Power*, and was diagnosed with a prolapsed disc. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* Alternative treatments brought no lasting relief, and the pain followed him onto several sets. *(Fact. same source)*

2002: Cannes. He worked through the injury. *Hum Tumhare Hain Sanam* came out in May 2002, and he made special appearances in *Shakti: The Power* and *Saathiya* later that year. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography)*

The delayed film. *Hum Tumhare Hain Sanam* opened on 24 May 2002, the day after *Devdas* premiered at Cannes. K. S. Adhiyaman directed it, with Salman Khan and Madhuri Dixit, after production problems had delayed it for six years. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Hum Tumhare Hain Sanam; Cannes date below)* Made for ₹12 crore, it grossed ₹34.76 crore worldwide; most critics were negative. *(Fact. same source)* A film shot across six years reached cinemas in the week his costliest film reached Cannes. *(Interpretation)*

The film of the year was Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Devdas*. It premiered out of competition at the Cannes Film Festival on 23 May 2002, the first big commercial Bollywood film to walk that red carpet, and opened worldwide on 12 July. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Devdas; Eastern Eye, 7 July 2022)* It cost about ₹50 crore, then the most expensive Bollywood film made. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; Wikipedia: List of accolades received by Devdas)*

The sources disagree on what it earned. Khan's own Wikipedia entry gives about ₹1.68 billion worldwide; the list of the film's accolades gives ₹998.8 million and calls it the highest-grossing Indian film of the year. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; Wikipedia: List of accolades received by Devdas)* *Devdas* became India's Oscar entry and was nominated

for the BAFTA for Best Film Not in the English Language. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Devdas; Wikipedia: List of accolades received by Devdas)* It won five National Film Awards. *(Fact. same source)*

At the 48th Filmfare Awards he won Best Actor for it. The film's total is given as 10 Filmfare Awards in his Wikipedia entry and as 11 of 17 nominations in the list of its accolades. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; Wikipedia: List of accolades received by Devdas)* He also hosted that ceremony, broadcast as a television special in 2003. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography)*

He took the stage abroad as well. In 2002 he headlined *From India With Love* with Amitabh Bachchan, Aamir Khan, Preity Zinta and Aishwarya Rai, at Old Trafford in Manchester and Hyde Park in London; more than 100,000 people attended. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* The direct line had gone offline. The live one, star and audience in the same field, was bigger than ever. *(Interpretation)*

The brand grew with the films. From 1999 his work in television advertising increased significantly, with the Hyundai Santro partnership of 1998 running through the whole period (see Chapter 5). *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan in the media; Storyboard18)* Box Office India, which had ranked him the top actor in 1995 and 1998, put him first again in 2002 and every year to 2008. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan in the media)* **[Unverified: list of brands he endorsed in 2000 to 2003, with years]** The company he co-owned had failed; the name it was built on had never been worth more. *(Interpretation)*

2003: the neck and the split. The body paid. Early in 2003 he had anterior cervical discectomy and fusion surgery at Wellington Hospital in London. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* He returned to work in June with a reduced load. *(Fact. same source)*

The third and last Dreamz Unlimited production, *Chalte Chalte*, directed by Aziz Mirza and made in association with UTV Motion Pictures, was released on 13 June 2003; Variety put its budget at $5 million. *(Fact. Variety, 13 June 2003)* It was a success. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* That year the Dreamz Unlimited partnership ended, after a dispute over casting Juhi Chawla in *Chalte Chalte*; the partners parted ways despite the film's success. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

Chalte Chalte, by the numbers. Wikipedia puts its budget at ₹11 crore, against Variety's $5 million above. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chalte Chalte (2003 film); Variety, 13 June 2003)* It grossed ₹43.28 crore worldwide, ₹30.15 crore in India and $2.81 million (₹13.13 crore) overseas, and Box Office India called it a "hit". *(Fact. same source; its lead gives US$5.4 million worldwide and its box-office section US$4.5 million)* Rani Mukerji played opposite him as Priya. By Khan's account she first declined for *Saathiya*; Aishwarya Rai was signed and then replaced, and Kajol declined because she was pregnant. *(Fact. same source)*

Jatin–Lalit and Aadesh Shrivastava wrote the songs, and the album sold about 1.8 million units, sixth for the year. Dreamz Unlimited designed the film's publicity itself. *(Fact. same source)*

When Dreamz became Red Chillies. The film's page says Dreamz Unlimited was rebranded as Red Chillies Entertainment in 2003. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chalte Chalte (2003 film))* The Red Chillies page, followed in Chapter 7, has the company registered in 2002 and Dreamz folded into it in 2004. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment; the sources differ)* **[Unverified: the dates of Red Chillies' incorporation and of the Dreamz merger, from the Registrar of Companies]**

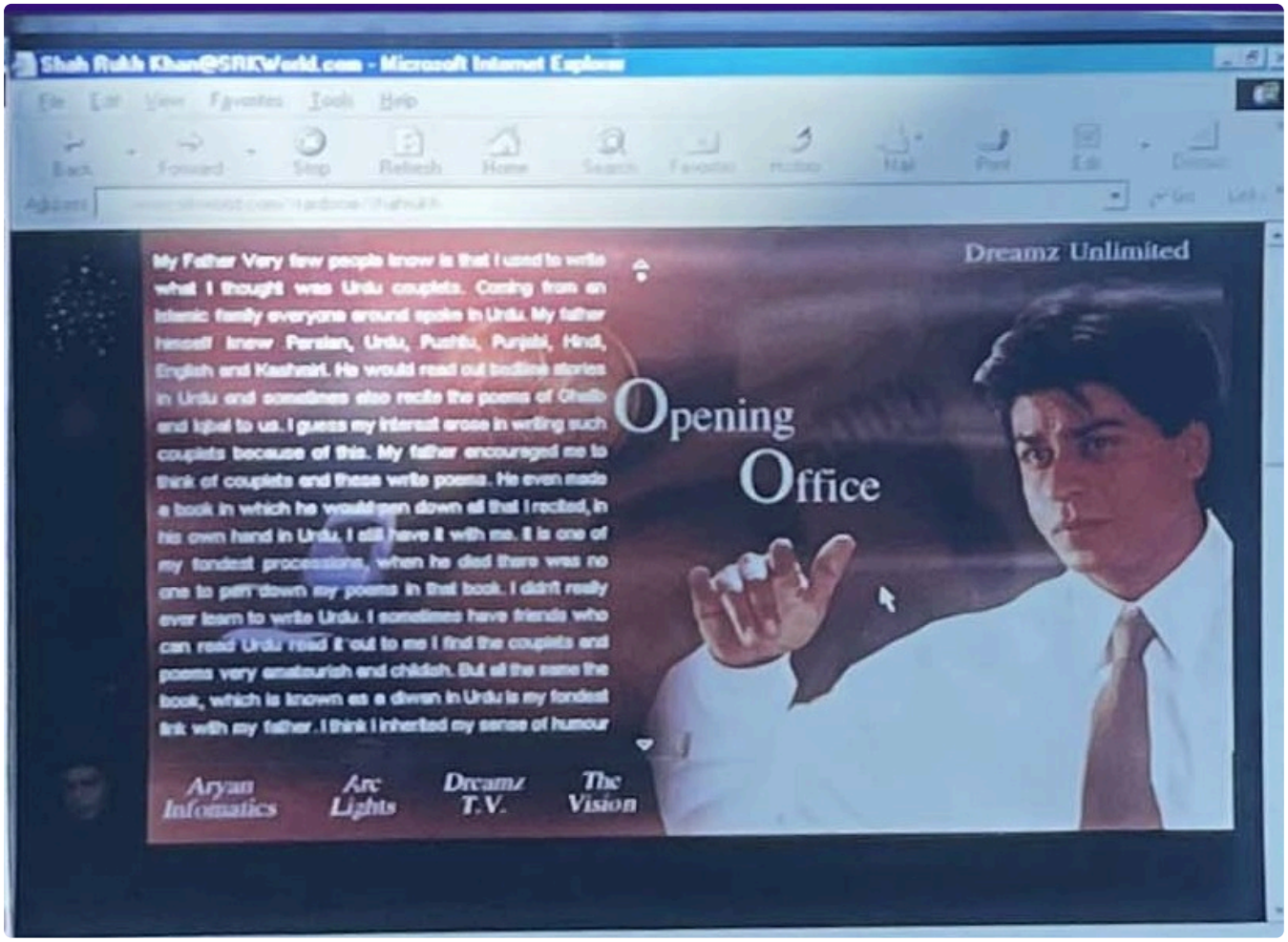
The year closed on a high. Karan Johar's production *Kal Ho Naa Ho*, written by Johar and directed by Nikhil Advani, opened on 28 November 2003. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kal Ho Naa Ho)* It grossed about ₹86.09 crore worldwide, by Box Office India's estimate, and was the highest-grossing Indian film of 2003; in India alone it was second, behind *Koi... Mil Gaya*. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kal Ho Naa Ho)* It won eight Filmfare Awards from eleven nominations, the most of any film that year. *(Fact. same source)*

For five years the pattern held: when he made something of his own, it lost money; when he played for others, it broke records. *(Interpretation)* *Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani*, *Asoka* and srkworld.com failed, *Chalte Chalte* succeeded and still ended the partnership, while *Mohabbatein*, *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham*, *Devdas* and *Kal Ho Naa Ho* made him the most bankable star of the decade abroad. *(Interpretation, on the facts above)*

The first direct line had been built too early. It needed fast connections, cheap phones and a habit of looking at a screen for a star, and India had none of the three. What it proved was that he wanted the line, and that a fan could build it with him. *(Interpretation)*

At the end of 2003 he had the year's biggest hit, a fused neck and no company of his own. What he built next, he would own outright. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 7 · Opening Office · The institution, 2004 to 2009



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Opening Office", with Dreamz Unlimited, Arc Lights, Dreamz TV and The Vision. (Archive: the author's collection)

He came out of 2003 with a repaired spine and without his first company. The partnership in Dreamz Unlimited had ended over *Chalte Chalte*, and he had been operated on in London to save his neck. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* SRKWorld, his first attempt at a direct line, was gone too (see Chapter 6). (Eyewitness account) What he did next was to stop being only a star and start building institutions around himself. *(Interpretation)*

2004: a studio of his own. Red Chillies Entertainment had been registered by him and Gauri Khan in 2002; in 2004 the old Dreamz Unlimited was folded into it, with Gauri Khan as producer. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment; Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; the two give different emphases on the founding)* Its first release was *Main Hoon Na*, Farah Khan's debut as a director. It was a hit, the second-highest earner of the year in India at about ₹68 crore. *(Fact)*

The highest earner of 2004 was also his: Yash Chopra's *Veer-Zaara*, at more than ₹94 crore in India, a love story across the India–Pakistan border that went on to screen at the 55th Berlin International Film Festival in February 2005. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The third film of the year, Ashutosh Gowariker's *Swades*, cast him as a NASA scientist who comes home to a

village without electricity; part of it was shot at NASA's Kennedy Space Center. It did not match the other two at the box office, but it won him the Filmfare Award for Best Actor, after nominations for all three of his 2004 films. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

Veer-Zaara in numbers. It opened at Diwali, on 12 November 2004, on 625 screens in India, with 60 prints in the UK and 88 in the US, on a budget of ₹23 crore. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Veer-Zaara)* Abroad it took about ₹35.7 crore, of which about ₹15.25 crore came from the UK and ₹14 crore from the US. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Veer-Zaara)* On 26 April 2006 it became the first Indian film to premiere at the Grand Rex in Paris. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Veer-Zaara)* The India figure conflicts: the paragraph above gives more than ₹94 crore, while the film's own page gives ₹58 crore in India at the end of its run and ₹97.64 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Veer-Zaara; Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2004)* **[Unverified: Veer-Zaara's India gross, from a trade record such as Box Office India]** The gap is probably gross against nett, or first run against lifetime; this book shows both. *(Interpretation)*

Three films, three different men: the army officer playing a student, the Indian Air Force pilot who waits twenty-two years in a Pakistani jail, the scientist who chooses his village over NASA. By 2004 he was no longer playing one kind of hero. He was playing the country's idea of itself. *(Interpretation)*

The same year he took the films on the road. *Temptations 2004*, his first stage tour, played 22 venues around the world; the Dubai show alone drew about 15,000 people. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The diaspora tours of the 1990s had become a product with his name on it. *(Interpretation)*

2005: the state honours him. In 2005 the Government of India awarded him the Padma Shri. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* *Paheli*, produced by Red Chillies with Amol Palekar directing, became India's submission for the Academy Award for Best Foreign Language Film. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* Red Chillies also co-produced *Kaal* with Dharma Productions, and released *The Outer World of Shah Rukh Khan*, a documentary by Nasreen Munni Kabir, directly on video. *(Fact)* A star who documented himself on video in 2005 was already thinking about the audience at home, not only the one in the cinema. *(Interpretation)*

2006: the overseas king, and a studio for effects. Karan Johar's *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna* became India's highest-grossing film overseas that year, at more than ₹113 crore abroad. In the same year he remade *Don*, and was compared, not always kindly, with Amitabh Bachchan's original. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Quietly, Red Chillies set up Red Chillies VFX in 2006, a visual-effects house that would work on *Chak De! India*, *Don* and, later, the effects of *Ra.One*. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* The company that would one day build a superhero had started building the tools first. *(Interpretation)*

2007: the year of everything. On 22 January 2007 he replaced Amitabh Bachchan as the host of *Kaun Banega Crorepati* on Star Plus, for one season of 53 episodes. It opened at 12.33 TVR, then settled lower; the season averaged about 6.8 TVR, against about 14.1 and 11.1 for Bachchan's first two seasons. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kaun Banega Crorepati)* It was a rare public defeat, and he took it on prime-time television. *(Interpretation)*

On 3 April 2007 Madame Tussauds in London unveiled his wax figure, the third Bollywood star in the museum after Amitabh Bachchan and Aishwarya Rai. *(Fact. The Tribune, 4 Apr 2007)* In June France made him an Officier of the Ordre des Arts et des Lettres, as "an actor of great talent and unmatched popularity". *(Fact. Filmibeat, 21 June 2007)*

Then came two films that showed both halves of him. *Chak De! India*, from Yash Raj Films, cast him as Kabir Khan, a disgraced hockey player who coaches the women's national team to a world title; it won him the Filmfare Award for Best Actor. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* In it a Muslim sportsman, branded a traitor, wins back his country by making others win. *(Interpretation)* Then, on 9 November 2007, came *Om Shanti Om*, Red Chillies' own production, directed by Farah Khan. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Om Shanti Om)*

Om Shanti Om was a launch as much as a film. It opened on about 2,000 prints worldwide, then the widest release for an Indian film, set a record of 18,000 pre-registered advance tickets across a chain of Delhi cinemas, and ran a tie-in with Amul. Made for about ₹40 crore, it grossed about ₹150 crore worldwide by one count and ₹152 crore by another, the highest-grossing Hindi film of 2007 and, at the time, of all time. Its soundtrack sold about two million units, the year's best-selling album. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Om Shanti Om, citing Box Office Mojo; the two gross figures differ slightly)* It also introduced Deepika Padukone, who won Best Female Debut. *(Fact)* Nineteen years later she would stand beside him again, in KING. *(Fact; see Part Five)*

The Diwali duel. Om Shanti Om opened on the same Friday as Saawariya, Sanjay Leela Bhansali's film backed by Sony Pictures. *(Fact. Celluloid Junkie, 11 Nov 2007)* On the opening day, The Economic Times counted about 90% occupancy for Om Shanti Om and about 60% for Saawariya; advance bookings for the Saturday at one Noida multiplex stood at about 50% against just over 20%. *(Fact. Celluloid Junkie, 11 Nov 2007, citing The Economic Times)* In the first figures, Om Shanti Om took about US$17 million in India; Saawariya reported about US$15.4 million from 900 screens in 13 markets, nearly all of it from India, where it played on 754 screens. *(Fact. Celluloid Junkie, citing Screen International and The Hollywood Reporter)* The first Hollywood studio to back a Hindi film had met him at Diwali and lost the home market. *(Interpretation)*

The year's ranking depends on the counter. Box Office Mojo's India chart for 2007, which notes that it does not track every film, puts Om Shanti Om fifth at US$13.70 million, behind Guru, Chak De! India, Bhool Bhulaiyaa and Spider-Man 3. *(Fact. Box Office Mojo: India, 2007)* Wikipedia's list of Hindi films of 2007 puts it first, at ₹152 crore worldwide, with

Chak De! India third at ₹109 crore. *(Fact. Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2007)* One counts India only and part of the market; the other counts the world. Both are shown. *(Interpretation)*

The star, the producer, the distributor's dream and the man who owned the effects studio were now the same person. *(Interpretation)*

2008: a team, and the world's attention. On 20 February 2008, at the first Indian Premier League auction in Mumbai, he bought the Kolkata franchise with Juhi Chawla and her husband Jay Mehta for US$75.09 million, about ₹298 crore at the time, and named it the Kolkata Knight Riders. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kolkata Knight Riders)* The team finished sixth of eight in the first season. *(Fact)* The partners of 2008 were familiar names: Juhi Chawla from the Dreamz Unlimited years, and Jay Mehta, one of the promoters of SRKWorld in 2000 (see Chapter 6). *(Fact; Chapter 6)*

The first night. The league opened with his team. On 18 April 2008, at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru, Brendon McCullum made 158 not out off 73 balls, with 13 sixes, and the Knight Riders beat Royal Challengers Bangalore by 140 runs. *(Fact. Wisden; Wikipedia: 2008 Kolkata Knight Riders season)* Under Sourav Ganguly as captain and John Buchanan as coach, the season ended with six wins, seven defeats and one no result. The franchise still reported a first-season profit of ₹13 crore (₹130 million). *(Fact. Wikipedia: 2008 Kolkata Knight Riders season)* A team that lost more than it won made money in its first year; the asset was the audience, not the table. *(Interpretation)*

In December 2008 *Newsweek* named him one of the fifty most powerful people in the world and called him "the world's biggest movie star". *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan; Filmibeat, 23 Dec 2008)* He hosted a second quiz show, *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hain?*, took a new tour, *Temptation Reloaded*, abroad, and closed the year with Aditya Chopra's *Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi*. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* A shoulder injury on a film set in December would put him into surgery in February 2009. *(Fact)*

Two launches, one week. Star Plus had planned to launch Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hain? on 18 April 2008, the night of the first IPL match, and moved it back a week to 25 April. *(Fact. exchange4media, 12 May 2008)* **[Unverified: the reason Star Plus gave for the one-week delay]** The show opened at a TRP of 4.6, fell to between 2.59 and 2.91 in its second week, and was moved to weekday nights. *(Fact. exchange4media, 12 May 2008)* The quiz show he hosted was competing with the cricket team he owned. *(Interpretation)*

The line someone else opened. On 17 April 2008, the day before the league began, Amitabh Bachchan started a blog, and was still writing it ten years later. *(Fact. Gulf News, 5 Nov 2018)* The man he had replaced on Kaun Banega Crorepati now had the kind of direct line to the audience that SRKWorld had been in 2000. He would not open one of his own until January 2010 (Chapter 8). *(Interpretation)*

2009: the year the line went wrong. The second IPL season was moved to South Africa. On 18 April 2009 an anonymous blog called *Fake IPL Player* began posting invented "inside stories" about his team. In four weeks it ran 43 posts and drew about 17,000 comments, with about 150,000 visitors on a single day; he called its author "obviously very sick, perverted". The team finished last, with three wins in fourteen matches. *(Fact. Wisden)* For the first time, the internet he had tried to build on in 2000 was talking about him without him. *(Interpretation)*

Several captains, one coach, last place. Before the 2009 season, coach John Buchanan floated a theory of several captains; Ganguly said in March 2009 that he had not been consulted, and Brendon McCullum replaced him as captain. *(Fact. Wisden, 3 July 2020; ESPNcricinfo)* Nine of the team's matches were decided in the final over, and it lost all nine, five of them on the last ball. *(Fact. ESPNcricinfo)* On 18 June 2009 the franchise released Buchanan with immediate effect; co-owner Jay Mehta said he "has not achieved everything that he set out to". *(Fact. The Daily Star, 18 June 2009)* Ganguly was captain again in 2010. *(Fact. Wisden, 3 July 2020)* A film can be recut before release; a team loses in public, every night, for six weeks. *(Interpretation)*

He made a special appearance in *Billu*, playing a version of himself, and as head of Red Chillies approved changing its title from *Billu Barber* after hairdressers objected. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

His films for other producers, 2004 to 2009. Red Chillies' own releases are in Room ArclightZ; these are the lead roles he played for other banners. Gross figures are in Indian rupees (1 crore = 10 million); where sources differ, both are shown. *(Fact; method note)*

Released	Film	Director	Worldwide gross	Rank among Hindi films that year	Source
12 Dec 2008	Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi	Aditya Chopra	₹157 crore (list); ₹180 crore (Yash Raj press note, 15 Jan 2009)	2, after Ghajini	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2008; Yash Raj Films
10 Aug 2007	Chak De! India	Shimit Amin	₹109 crore (list); US$19.13 million in India alone (Box Office Mojo)	3 (list); 2 in India (Box Office Mojo)	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2007; Box Office Mojo
20 Oct 2006	Don	Farhan Akhtar	₹106 crore	5	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2006
11 Aug 2006	Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna	Karan Johar	₹113 crore	4	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2006
17 Dec 2004	Swades	Ashutosh Gowariker	₹40.2 crore (list); ₹34.64 crore (film page)	7	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2004; Wikipedia: Swades

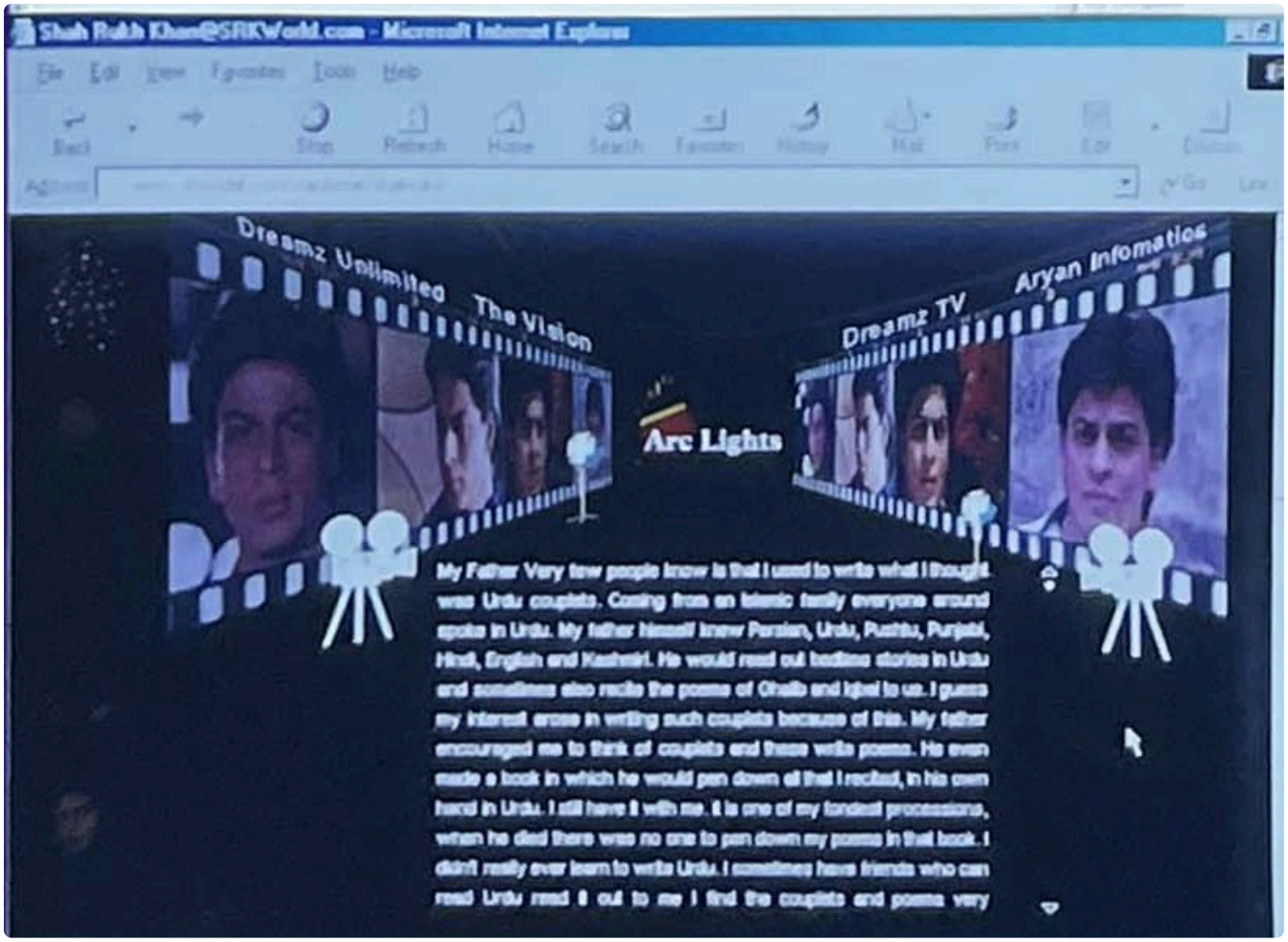
Released	Film	Director	Worldwide gross	Rank among Hindi films that year	Source
12 Nov 2004	Veer-Zaara	Yash Chopra	₹97.64 crore	1	Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2004

The Yash Raj note of January 2009 called Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi his highest-grossing film to that date, at ₹180 crore worldwide, with ₹83 crore nett in India over five weeks. *(Fact. Yash Raj Films press note, 15 Jan 2009)* The ₹113 crore for Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna is a worldwide figure in the 2006 list, where this chapter's paragraph on 2006 gives it as the overseas figure. *(Fact. Wikipedia: List of Hindi films of 2006)* Six films, six top-ten finishes, five of them in the top five: the other banners were hiring the most reliable name in the business while he built his own. *(Fact, from the table; Interpretation)*

By 2009 he was a star, a studio owner, a team owner, a television host, the face of the country's second-largest carmaker and a national honour holder. *(Interpretation)* He had built everything except the one thing he had tried first, in 2000: his own line to the audience, owned by him and open every day. *(Interpretation)*

Then, in August 2009, an airport in New Jersey held him for two hours because of his name. *(Fact. NBC News)* His next film was called *My Name Is Khan*. Ten years after SRKWorld, he was about to build a digital kingdom again, this time with the whole industry watching. *(Interpretation)*

Room · ArclightZ · The producer



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Arc Lights", the producer's page. (Archive: the author's collection)

A room for the producer. *Asoka* (2001) was credited to Dreamz Unlimited and Archlightz Films, with him and Juhi Chawla as producers. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)* From Dreamz Unlimited in 1999 to Red Chillies, its VFX house and its streaming series, the producer's record runs beside the actor's. *(Interpretation)*

Three companies. Dreamz Unlimited was founded in 1999 by Shah Rukh Khan, Juhi Chawla and the director Aziz Mirza, and co-produced three films between 2000 and 2003. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* Red Chillies Entertainment was founded in 2002 by Shah Rukh Khan and Gauri Khan as its successor. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment) Asoka* also carried a third banner, Arclightz & Films; the website's producer page of 2000 was called *Arc Lights*. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment; Archive: the author's collection)* Gauri Khan is co-chairperson of Red Chillies and the producer of record on nearly all its films. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Gauri Khan)*

How to read the tables. The budget and gross figures are those published on each film's Wikipedia page as of October 2026, in Indian rupees (1 crore = 10 million). Where the page gives two figures, both are shown. A gross is ticket sales, not the producer's profit. N/A means no figure was published on the page. *(Fact; method note)*

Dreamz Unlimited, 1999 to 2003

Year	Film	Director	Budget	Worldwide gross	Note
2000	Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani	Aziz Mirza	₹13 crore	₹25.46 crore	First production; a commercial failure
2001	Asoka	Santosh Sivan	₹12.5 crore	est. ₹28 crore (the page also gives ₹11.54 crore nett in India plus US$1.8 million overseas)	With Arclightz & Films; 1 Filmfare, 2 IIFA awards
2003	Chalte Chalte	Aziz Mirza	₹11 crore	₹43.28 crore	Dispute over casting Juhi Chawla; the partners parted

The first two films lost money, and the losses helped close SRKWorld (Chapter 6). *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

Red Chillies Entertainment: cinema releases, 2004 to 2026

Year	Film	Director	Budget	Worldwide gross	Note
2004	Main Hoon Na	Farah Khan	N/A	₹84 crore to ₹89.7 crore	First Red Chillies release
2005	Kaal	Soham Shah	N/A	N/A	With Dharma Productions
2005	Paheli	Amol Palekar	₹14 crore	₹32 crore	India's entry for the Academy Awards
2005	The Outer World of Shah Rukh Khan	Nasreen Munni Kabir	N/A	N/A (direct to video)	Documentary
2007	Om Shanti Om	Farah Khan	₹40 crore	₹150 crore to ₹152 crore	National Film Award, art direction
2009	Billu	Priyadarshan	N/A	N/A	Also listed as Billu Barber
2010	My Name Is Khan	Karan Johar	₹55 crore to ₹85 crore	₹223.44 crore	With Dharma and Fox Star
2011	Always Kabhi Kabhi	Roshan Abbas	N/A	N/A	Red Chillies production
2011	Ra.One	Anubhav Sinha	₹120 crore to ₹150 crore, with publicity	more than ₹207 crore	National Film Award, special effects
2011	Don 2	Farhan Akhtar	₹76 crore	est. ₹202.81 crore	With Excel Entertainment

Year	Film	Director	Budget	Worldwide gross	Note
2012	Student of the Year	Karan Johar	₹59 crore	₹97 crore to ₹109 crore	With Dharma
2013	Chennai Express	Rohit Shetty	₹70 crore to ₹115 crore	₹423 crore to ₹424 crore	With UTV
2014	Happy New Year	Farah Khan	₹140 crore to ₹150 crore	₹342 crore to ₹394 crore	Distributed by Yash Raj Films
2015	Dilwale	Rohit Shetty	₹165 crore	est. ₹376.85 crore	With Rohit Shetty Productions
2016	Dear Zindagi	Gauri Shinde	₹22 crore	₹138.91 crore	With Dharma and Hope
2017	Raees	Rahul Dholakia	₹87 crore to ₹91 crore	₹272.54 crore to ₹281 crore	With Excel
2017	Jab Harry Met Sejal	Imtiaz Ali	₹90 crore	est. ₹153.43 crore	Distributed by NH Studioz and Yash Raj Films
2017	Ittefaq	Abhay Chopra	N/A	N/A	With Dharma and B.R. Studios
2018	Zero	Aanand L. Rai	₹200 crore	₹191.43 crore	With Colour Yellow (Chapter 12)
2019	Badla	Sujoy Ghosh	₹10 crore to ₹37 crore	₹138.49 crore	With Azure
2020	Kaamyaab	Hardik Mehta	N/A	N/A	With Drishyam
2023	Jawan	Atlee	₹300 crore	₹1,148.32 crore	Chapter 14
2023	Dunki	Rajkumar Hirani	₹85 crore to ₹120 crore	est. ₹470.6 crore	With Rajkumar Hirani Films and Jio Studios
2026	KING	Siddharth Anand	N/A	N/A (release 24 December 2026)	With Marflix; Chapter 16

(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment and each linked film page, October 2026) *Pathaan* (2023) was a Yash Raj Films production, not Red Chillies, and is in Chapter 14. *(Fact)*

Red Chillies: streaming and television

Year	Title	Platform	Form
2002	Asoka (five episodes, 28 May to 25 June)	Star Plus	Miniseries cut of the film
2009 to 2012	Red Chillies Idiot Box: 10 shows, 2 television films and 1 cinema film (*Men Will Be Men*, 2011)	Television	Production arm, closed 2012

Year	Title	Platform	Form
2019	Bard of Blood (premiered 27 September)	Netflix	Series
2020	Class of '83	Netflix	Film
2020	Betaal (premiered 24 May)	Netflix	Miniseries
2021	Bob Biswas	ZEE5	Film
2022	Love Hostel	ZEE5	Film
2022	Darlings, with Alia Bhatt's Eternal Sunshine	Netflix	Film
2024	Bhakshak	Netflix	Film
2025	The Ba***ds of Bollywood, directed by Aryan Khan (18 September)	Netflix	Series, 7 episodes
2026	Kartavya	Netflix	Film

*(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment; Wikipedia: The Ba***ds of Bollywood)* Netflix and ZEE5 do not publish viewing revenue by title; no gross can be given. *(Fact)*

Red Chillies VFX. Founded in 2006 and led by Haresh Hingorani and Keitan Yadav, with more than 130 staff, the largest of the group's companies. Its work includes *Chak De! India*, *Krrish 3* and *Don* as well as Red Chillies' own films. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* *Ra.One* won the National Film Award and the Filmfare Award for special effects, and *Zero* and *Jawan* won Filmfare's visual-effects award. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* [Unverified: the page's further award claims for *Don* (2006), *Om Shanti Om* (2007) and *Fan* (2016) carry no citation.]

The cricket. In 2008 he, Juhi Chawla and Jay Mehta bought the Kolkata franchise of the Indian Premier League for US$75.09 million and named it Kolkata Knight Riders. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)* Red Chillies holds 55% of the owning Knight Riders Group, with the Mehta Group. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* The team won the IPL in 2012, 2014 and 2024; the group also owns the Trinbago Knight Riders in the Caribbean Premier League. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

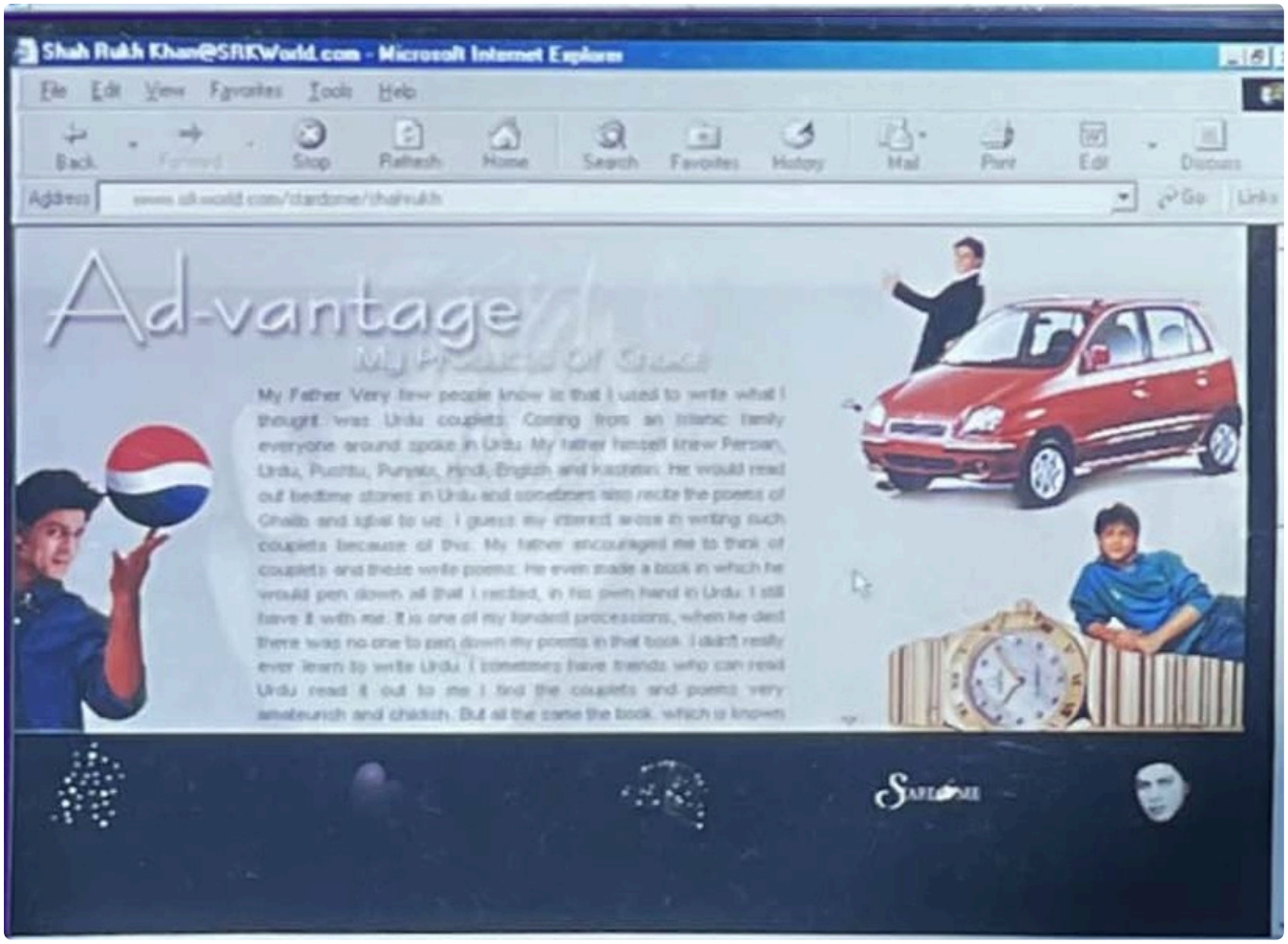
In 2015 the Knight Riders Group bought the majority of the Caribbean Premier League franchise in Trinidad and Tobago, renamed it the Trinbago Knight Riders in 2016 and handed its operations to Red Chillies. It has won five titles, the most in the league's history: 2015, 2017, 2018, 2020 (unbeaten, 12 wins from 12) and 2025. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Trinbago Knight Riders)* The Knight Riders Cricket Ground in Los Angeles followed in 2026 (Chapter 15). [Unverified: the dates the group entered Major League Cricket in the US and

the ILT20 in the UAE, from the leagues' records.] With the IPL titles of 2012, 2014 and 2024, his teams have won eight league titles, in India and the Caribbean. *(Fact, count; Interpretation)*

The money. Red Chillies does not publish annual accounts to the public in a form this book has found. A June 2024 Times Now report was headlined "Red Chillies Declares Rs 85 Crore Profit For FY23". *(Fact. cited on Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* [Unverified: revenue and profit by year, from the company's filings with the Registrar of Companies.]

What the record shows. The producer lost money first. Three Dreamz films grossed about ₹97 crore between them, and the company closed. *(Fact, from the table; Interpretation)* Twenty years later, a single Red Chillies film, *Jawan*, grossed more than ₹1,148 crore. *(Fact, from the table)* In between, the company built what the actor could not buy: its own effects house, a cricket team, and a streaming slate made for Netflix. *(Interpretation)* The actor's career has falls (Chapters 6 and 12); the producer's record shows a business that kept building through both. *(Interpretation)*

Room · Advantage · Advertising



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Advantage", his advertising page, with Pepsi and the Hyundai Santro. (Archive: the author's collection)

A room for the brands. From the Hyundai Santro in 1998, one of the longest partnerships in Indian advertising, to Visa in 2026, he has sold more than films. *(Fact. Storyboard18; Visa press release, 3 June 2026)*

The first deal he typed himself. Hyundai set up in India in 1996 and was almost unknown; it launched the Santro in 1998 with Saatchi & Saatchi as its agency, weighed Shah Rukh Khan against Jackie Shroff, and chose the star of *DDLJ* and *Dil To Pagal Hai*. *(Fact. Storyboard18)* He hesitated because nobody knew the brand. Hyundai's former president BVR Subbu has said that Khan typed the first agreement himself. *(Fact. Storyboard18)* In 2002 he shot a Santro Xing film with a back injury, asking only not to run or dance. He went on to front the Creta and the Alcazar, called the partnership a "long marriage" in 2017, and was given the 1,100th Ioniq 5 in December 2023. *(Fact. Storyboard18)* By 2025 the association had passed 25 years. *(Fact. afaqs, 3 November 2025)* An actor who reads his own contracts is a businessman before he is an endorser. *(Interpretation)*

Endorsements with a published start year

Year	Brand	Category	What happened	Source
1988	Liberty Shoes	Footwear	His first advertisement: India's first home-made sports shoes, to "Eye of the Tiger"	Storyboard18, 25 January 2023
1998	Hyundai	Cars	Santro launch; later Creta and Alcazar; more than 25 years	Storyboard18; afaqs
2005	Lux	Soap	He became the "Lux girl", in a bathtub ringed by the brand's actresses	Storyboard18, 25 January 2023
2013	Frooti	Drinks	Brand ambassador	afaqs, 3 November 2025
2021	Cadbury (Mondelez)	Chocolate	"Not Just A Cadbury Ad": AI-made ads for local shops at Diwali	Storyboard18; exchange4media
2024	Castrol India	Engine oil	Face of the brand on TV, print and digital	afaqs
June 2024	Myntra	Fashion e-commerce	"Trend IRL" campaign	afaqs

Year	Brand	Category	What happened	Source
May 2025	Candere (Kalyan Jewellers)	Jewellery	Label for younger buyers	afaqs
3 June 2026	Visa	Payments	Brand ambassador for India; "Infinitely More" campaign by Leo South Asia (Publicis)	Visa press release, 3 June 2026

Endorsements without a published start year. A 2019 survey of his advertising lists Nokia, Hero Puch, Mayur Suitings, Cinthol, Airtel, Linc, Sona Chandi, Pepsi, V-John, D'Decor, Fair and Handsome (Emami), Sunfeast, Mitsubishi, Compaq, Navratna Cool Talc, Videocon, Aqualite, Pepsodent, DHFL, Dish TV, Denver, ONN, BigBasket, BYJU'S, ICICI, Visit Dubai and Netflix, as well as the public campaigns of the National Rural Health Mission and Swachh Bharat Urban. *(Fact. Social Samosa, 2 November 2019)* Thums Up and Disney+ Hotstar followed. *(Fact. Storyboard18, 25 January 2023)* [Unverified: start and end year for each brand, from the advertisers or the agencies.] That is more than 35 brands in about 37 years. *(Fact, count from the sources above)*

Three ads that changed the category. *Pepsi:* the "Yeh Dil Maange More" films put him beside the *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* cast and Sachin Tendulkar, and his presence is credited with helping Pepsi regain trust during the pesticide controversy. *(Fact. Storyboard18, 25 January 2023)* [Unverified: the year the Pepsi association began and ended.] *Lux, 2005:* the first man to be a "Lux girl" made a joke of his own sex appeal and of the brand's history. *(Fact, as above; Interpretation) Fair and Handsome:* a line in one film drew criticism about fairness creams; it is part of the record. *(Fact. Storyboard18)*

2021: the ad that gave his face away. For Diwali 2021, Cadbury's owner Mondelez, with Ogilvy, Wavemaker and the AI company Rephrase.ai, used machine learning to recreate his face and voice so that small local shops hit by Covid could each have their own Shah Rukh Khan advertisement naming their store. *(Fact. exchange4media, 25 June 2022; Wavemaker, 27 June 2022)* At Cannes Lions 2022 it won two Gold, one Silver and one Bronze Lion. *(Fact. exchange4media)* Wavemaker also lists a Titanium Lion. [Unverified: the Titanium Lion, from the Cannes Lions archive.] It did not win a Grand Prix. *(Fact. Wavemaker)* [Unverified: the number of shops, ads and postcodes, from Mondelez or Ogilvy.]

This is the most important ad in this book. *(Interpretation)* Five years before fans began making him with AI tools (Chapter 18), a brand did it with his consent and paid for it; the face was licensed, the use was named and the beneficiaries were small traders. It is the model Inquilab argues for (Chapter 21). *(Interpretation)*

What his name is worth: celebrity brand valuations

Year valued	Rank in India	Brand value (US$)	Valuer	Source
2017	2	N/A (not published in the source)	Duff & Phelps	Kroll release, 10 January 2019
2018	5	60.7 million	Duff & Phelps	Business Today, 11 January 2019
2019	5	66.1 million	Duff & Phelps	Gulf News, 7 February 2020
2020	N/A (not retrieved)	N/A (not retrieved)	Duff & Phelps	[Unverified]
2021	N/A (not retrieved)	N/A (not retrieved)	Kroll	[Unverified]
2022	10	55.7 million	Kroll	exchange4media, 21 March 2023
2023	3	120.7 million	Kroll	afaqs, 19 June 2024
2024	3	145.7 million	Kroll	Storyboard18, 25 September 2025
2025	1	177.9 million	Kroll	Manifest, 5 August 2026

Duff & Phelps' valuation business became Kroll; its annual report ranks the 25 most valuable celebrity brands in India. *(Fact. sources above)* Separately, Forbes India's Celebrity 100 ranked him first in 2012, 2013 and 2015. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan)*

What the curve shows. The valuation follows the films, not the fame. It fell to 10th in 2022, at the end of the four years without a release (Chapter 13). It more than doubled, to US$120.7 million, in 2023, the year of *Pathaan*, *Jawan* and *Dunki* (Chapter 14). In 2025, at 60 and with no release that year, he was valued first in India, ahead of Ranveer Singh at US$162.9 million and Virat Kohli at US$158.4 million. *(Fact. sources above; Interpretation)* The fans stayed through the silence; the market came back with the box office. *(Interpretation)*

Advantage. The 2000 website called this room *Advantage* and showed Pepsi and the Santro. *(Archive: the author's collection, the screen above)* The joke was a tennis score. *(Interpretation)* Twenty-six years later the advantage is the same: an audience that trusts the face, and a face that, since 2021, can be licensed even when the man is not on set. *(Interpretation)*

Part Two · One Before Zero · The Marketing Express, 2010 to 2013

By 2009 he was an institution. In the next four years he turned the direct line into a system, and sold three films in three new ways: with a stock exchange, a superhero universe and a train. (Interpretation)

Chapter 8 · The Wall II · My Name Is Khan, 2010: the star becomes the platform

January 2010: the line reopens. Ten years after SRKWorld, he opened a direct line to his audience again, and this time he did not have to build it. He joined Twitter as @iamsrk at the start of January 2010; his first tweet, on 2 or 3 January by different accounts, began: "Being extremely shy I never thought I would be here." Karan Johar had talked him into it. *(Fact. IBTimes; Siasat)* Five years later the account had 10.7 million followers. *(Fact. IBTimes)* The shy man who had built a website in 2000 now had a microphone in every fan's pocket, and he used it himself. *(Interpretation)*

The first film he sold through it was the most personal of his career. *My Name Is Khan*, directed by Karan Johar, was the story of Rizwan Khan, a Muslim man with Asperger's syndrome who crosses post-9/11 America to tell its president one sentence: "My name is Khan, and I am not a terrorist." It was the kind of film that could have stayed a festival title. Its campaign made it an international release. *(Interpretation)*

The deal. On 7 August 2009 he signed a worldwide distribution deal with Fox Star Studios, reported at ₹100 crore; unconfirmed estimates ran from ₹81 crore to ₹100 crore, and Fox did not disclose the figure. Fox Star distributed in India, Fox Searchlight in the United States and 20th Century Fox elsewhere; Abu Dhabi's Image Nation joined in February 2010. *(Fact. Wikipedia: My Name Is Khan; Filmibeat, 2 Sept 2009)* A Hollywood studio was buying a Hindi film for the world. *(Interpretation)*

The launch, on every front at once. The first look was unveiled in Mumbai and broadcast across 70 countries on the Star TV network. The trailer debuted with *Avatar*, then became the first in India to run as a roadblock: three minutes on all the leading channels at the same moment. *(Fact. Wikipedia: My Name Is Khan; this confirms what the earlier draft marked unverified)* On 1 February 2010 he and Kajol became the first Indian film stars to ring the NASDAQ opening bell in New York. They were there to launch a film, not to list a company. *(Fact. Deccan Herald; Wikipedia)* The image said what the campaign was built to say: this film was a global event, and its star was a global property. *(Interpretation)*

Brands carried the story into shops. Reebok launched an MNIK range on 10 February 2010, led by the "Winning Stride" shoe his character wears in the film, priced from ₹999 to ₹5,999. *(Fact. FashionUnited)* Reebok and Samsonite made co-branded commercials, beside tie-ups with Century Ply, DishTV, Bharti Airtel, MakeMyTrip and Kyazoonga. *(Fact.*

exchange4media, 3 Feb 2010) The DishTV tie-up let fans win a meeting with the star at Mannat. *(Fact. exchange4media)* In London he sat on *Friday Night with Jonathan Ross*. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

On 10 February the film premiered in the UAE. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* In Berlin it opened out of competition at the 60th International Film Festival; screening tickets auctioned on eBay at £1,000 each sold out in five seconds. *(Fact. Wikipedia; Filmibeat, 2 Feb 2010)*

The year a city stood behind him. At home, Shiv Sena called for a boycott until he apologised for saying Pakistani cricketers should have been picked for the IPL. Police in Mumbai arrested 1,023 Shiv Sena activists in 24 hours and guarded 63 theatres; the state deployed five battalions of its reserve police. *(Fact. Governance Now, 10 Feb 2010; Wikipedia)* He did not apologise. On 12 February the city answered: the first multiplex shows sold out within hours, and the film opened to full houses across India. *(Fact. Al Jazeera, 12 Feb 2010; Wikipedia)*

What it earned. The film opened to about ₹29.5 crore net in India over its first weekend, then a February record. Abroad it broke records: the biggest overseas opening for an Indian film, the first to gross more than ₹100 crore overseas, about US$23.5 million in all, the highest-grossing Bollywood film in the UK and the Middle East, and about £2.6 million in Britain alone, the year's highest-grossing foreign-language film there. In the United States it opened in 120 theatres, a record for an Indian film, and took US$1.99 million in its first weekend. Its final worldwide gross was about ₹223 crore. *(Fact. Wikipedia: My Name Is Khan; budget estimates differ, ₹55 crore by Mint and ₹85 crore in other listings)* It won three Filmfare Awards, including his eighth for Best Actor. *(Fact. Wikipedia; the category count is to be confirmed: [Unverified: Filmfare 2011 list])*

Newark, 14 August 2009. A week after the Fox deal, he flew into Newark airport, New Jersey, to promote the film. Immigration officers took him aside and questioned him for over an hour; he said it was at least two. He was released after officials of the Indian consulate intervened, and a US Customs and Border Protection spokesperson called the questioning routine. *(Fact. Wikipedia: My Name Is Khan, citing the BBC)* Six months before the release of a film whose hero is stopped and questioned because of his name, its star was stopped and questioned at an American airport. *(Interpretation)* The incident gave the campaign a real-world story that no marketing budget could have bought; this book records it as an event, not as a plan. *(Interpretation)*

Playing Rizwan. Karan Johar and the writer Shibani Bathija researched Asperger's syndrome for about two years and met couples who had written about it. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* He read *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* and spent ten days in a bathroom practising a fixed, expressionless gaze. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Critics divided on

the result: Taran Adarsh called it his career-best performance, The Hindu praised how unlaboured it looked, and NPR's Mark Jenkins found the portrayal of the condition dubious. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The verdicts. The New York Times' Rachel Saltz wrote that it taught lessons about Islam and tolerance while drawing tears; The Hollywood Reporter's Kirk Honeycutt said it examined anti-Muslim hysteria in America compellingly; Variety's Jay Weissberg called it overstuffed but enjoyable. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Rotten Tomatoes recorded 86% positive from 29 reviews; Metacritic 50 out of 100 from seven. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* At the 56th Filmfare Awards, on 29 January 2011, it won three: Best Actor for him, Best Actress for Kajol and Best Director for Karan Johar. *(Fact. Wikipedia: 56th Filmfare Awards)* Best Film went to *Dabangg*. *(Fact. as above)* The Western reviews matter for this book: the leading American papers reviewed one of his films as a statement about America itself. *(Interpretation)*

The diaspora that DDLJ had discovered in 1995 had become, fifteen years later, the market that decided whether a Hindi film was a global hit. *(Interpretation)*

In 2010 a city queued around the block to stand behind him. Eleven years later, at his own gate, by the author's own account, nobody came. That contrast is the question at the heart of this thesis. *(Interpretation)*

What changed in 2010. Until then, the star was the face of a campaign. With My Name Is Khan he became its platform, an actor, cultural ambassador, commercial partner and media property at the same time. A film has a release date. A platform keeps producing experiences, products and stories long after the opening weekend. *(Interpretation)*

That difference became the engine of the next three years. The next film would not use a platform. It would try to build one.

Chapter 9 · The Wall II · Ra.One, 2011: building a digital kingdom

Ra.One premiered in Dubai on 24 October 2011 and opened in India on 26 October, the Diwali weekend. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* On screen it was a superhero film: a game designer builds a villain for his son, the villain escapes the game, and a hero called G.One steps out of the code to stop him. Off screen it was the most ambitious attempt Indian cinema had made to build an intellectual property rather than a film. The campaign ran for nine months on a reported marketing budget of ₹52 crore, about ₹15 crore of it on the internet. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The figures were reported differently at the time. A month before release, Business Today put the marketing budget at about ₹40 crore, ₹15 crore of it online, against a production cost of about ₹160 crore. It also reported ₹77 crore for distribution rights, ₹35 crore for satellite rights and ₹5 crore for the game, with industry sources expecting about 80% of the cost to be recovered before release. *(Fact. Business Today, 27 Sept 2011; the 80% is an industry estimate)*

The brief was not to sell tickets for a weekend. It was to build a universe that would outlive the weekend: a character with its own visual identity, products, games and stories, able to travel from screen to shelf to phone.

What was built. The campaign combined:

- **A character system**: G.One got a style guide with rules for colour, pose and proportion, so any partner could reproduce the hero correctly. The author created the illustrated G.One art, the style guide, Little G.One and the G.One comic. *(Eyewitness account; the style guide and comic are in the author's archive)*
- **Merchandise and licensing**: toys, PC tablets and apparel *(Fact. Wikipedia)*. The FICCI-KPMG media report of 2012 called it "one of the longest and the most elaborate marketing campaigns in the history of Indian cinema", a 360-degree campaign that "leveraged digital and merchandising platforms", and noted that the first look was unveiled on a social network *(Fact. KPMG-FICCI Report 2012)*. The report gives no count of products. The earlier draft's figure of 64 merchandise items comes from the author's own licensing work: [Unverified: licensing records to be supplied by the author]
- **Games**: *Ra.One – The Game* for PlayStation 2 and 3, made with Sony Computer Entertainment Europe and released on 5 October 2011, and a social game, *Ra.One Genesis*, with UTV Indiagames *(Fact. Wikipedia)*
- **Website and live events**: the official site launched on 31 May 2011, with a YouTube channel and a gaming tournament in Mumbai streamed on YouTube *(Fact. Wikipedia)*
- **Brand partners**: tie-ins across categories, including a Horlicks special-edition Ra.One pack with a G.One mug and a draw to meet the cast *(Fact. afaqs)*
- **Digital first**: a hero who lived online before he lived on screen, built by a team that ran digital as part of the product, not as its advertising *(Eyewitness account)*

A month before release the campaign had six brand partners: Western Union, which ran a million-dollar global campaign, Linc pens, Horlicks, McDonald's, Sony Computer Entertainment Europe and YouTube. McDonald's Happy Meals carried a G.One robot toy. An official G.One store sold everything from piggy banks to limited-edition toys, with a loyalty programme. A custom YouTube channel carried behind-the-scenes footage, a 40-page digital comic sat on the official site, and the star video-chatted with fans on Google+. *(Fact. exchange4media, 27 Sept 2011)*

In 2011 that was unheard of for a Hindi film: a star talking to fans by live video, a hero sold in fast-food boxes, a comic and a game released before the film. *(Interpretation)*

The digital launch was a stage event of its own. In Mumbai the star launched the film's YouTube channel and Google+ presence together with Google, saying he "wanted to leverage the full potential of digital media". The launch included a contest in which fans

competed for the most views. *(Fact. Business Today, 27 Sept 2011; Campaign India: a dedicated channel with social games, a digital comic and contests)* The author was on that stage, introduced by the star himself. *(Eyewitness account; archive video)*

Eleven years after SRKWorld he said it himself, on stage (see Chapter 6). At the Mumbai launch, in September 2011, of Ra.One's partnership with Google and YouTube, seated beside Rajan Anandan, then head of Google India, he introduced the author to the audience: a young woman who used to work with him, with whom, years earlier, he had started a company, and lost everything. She had gone on to film-making and digital work, he said, and had left her job to make the Ra.One digital campaign happen. *(Archive: video of the event, uploaded by the author at Khan's request. Paraphrase from an automatic transcript; his exact words to be confirmed)*



On 20 October 2011 he held a live chat with fans on Google+, the first Indian film personality to do so. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The social game *Ra.One Genesis* ran on Facebook, Twitter, iPhone, iPad, Android, Nokia's Ovi Store and DTH, and the film's Facebook page passed three lakh likes. *(Fact. Social Samosa, Nov 2011)* Akon sang "Chammak Challo", the song that carried the campaign. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The brand list kept growing: Ducati, Tommy Hilfiger, Videocon, TAG Heuer and Volkswagen were signed a month out *(Fact. Business Today)*, more than 25 brands in all by release, subsidising much of the marketing spend *(Fact. Moneylife)*. Outdoors, 1,700 billboards were planned. *(Fact. Business Today)*

It grossed more than ₹207 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Box Office India, via Wikipedia)*

Its visual effects won the National Film Award and the Filmfare Award for Best Special Effects. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Its marketing won too: Best Marketed Movie of the Year at the ETC Bollywood Business Awards on 9 January 2012, and Best Marketed Film and Best Use of New Media at the Zee Cine Awards on 21 January 2012. *(Fact. Wikipedia: accolades of Ra.One; the Zee wins are stated in the article text)*

What it proved, and what it left unfinished. A franchise needs more than a launch. It needs continuity, rights management, investment and, above all, a reason for the audience to keep playing after the credits. Ra.One delivered the launch. The universe never got its second chapter. *(Interpretation)*

In 2011, most Indian film campaigns treated the internet as a place to upload a trailer. Ra.One treated it as part of the product. The industry would take more than a decade to catch up, and when it did, the tools would be AI and the builders would be the fans. *(Interpretation)*

Two years later, the same team asked a harder question: what if the audience was not only the market for the campaign, but its engine?

Chapter 10 · The Wall II · Chennai Express, 2013: the audience moves the train

2012: a cup, a ban and a farewell. Between the superhero and the train came a year that showed every side of the institution at once. In May 2012, after his Kolkata Knight Riders beat the Mumbai Indians at the Wankhede Stadium, he was stopped from walking onto the ground and argued with officials and security guards. The Mumbai Cricket Association banned him from the stadium for five years; he said the guards had misbehaved with children, his daughter among them. *(Fact. Daily FT, 19 May 2012)* Eleven days later, on 27 May 2012, the same team won its first IPL title, beating the Chennai Super Kings in the final in Chennai. *(Fact. ESPNcricinfo)* The ban in Mumbai was lifted in August 2015. *(Fact. Deccan Chronicle, 2 Aug 2015)*

On 21 October 2012 Yash Chopra died, before the release of the film he had made with him, *Jab Tak Hai Jaan*. It opened on 13 November 2012, grossed about ₹236 crore worldwide, and was the year's highest-grossing Hindi film overseas. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Jab Tak Hai Jaan)* The director who had cast him as the stalker of *Darr* in 1993 and the lover of *Dil To Pagal Hai* in 1997 closed his career with him. *(Interpretation)*

He had won a cup in Chennai and lost a stadium in Mumbai in the same month. His next film would take a train to Chennai, and this time the audience would drive. *(Interpretation)*

Every film campaign asks its audience to watch. Chennai Express asked its audience to drive.

The campaign ran for about 90 days before release in August 2013. Its central device was a train. Fans moved it along its journey with their tweets and collective activity, and as it reached each station it unlocked new content: a song, a scene, a reveal. *(Eyewitness account; the author was the campaign's Chief Digital Strategist)* A poster can only be looked at. A train you move together is a story you are part of.

The campaign's Shorty Awards entry lists a Twitter-driven train app and seven browser-based games. It also reports that the film was the first to stay in Twitter's top trends for more than 10 consecutive days, and that its opening-day Twitter activity ran more than 500% above Elysium and Planes, the Hollywood films released the same weekend. *(Fact. Shorty Awards)*

On launch, fans who tweeted #ChennaiExpressArrives were linked to a virtual train heading to Chennai, where the trailer was revealed early, and interactive train bogies stood at the Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore and Hyderabad airports. A mobile game, *Chennai Express: Escape from Rameshwaram*, built by Disney UTV's digital arm, put players in Rahul's shoes, and Best Rice and Asus integrated with the film. *(Fact. exchange4media, 8 Aug 2013)*

The film itself was a Rohit Shetty action comedy, produced by Red Chillies with UTV, starring Deepika Padukone opposite him. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chennai Express)* The public timeline ran like a rail schedule: the first look on 1 January 2013; a 31-second title teaser sung by S. P. Balasubrahmanyam on 23 May; the trailer in Mumbai on 13 June, which passed four million YouTube views in two days; "Lungi Dance", Honey Singh's tribute to Rajinikanth, on 19 July; the Android game on 24 July; the karaoke app on 2 August. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chennai Express)* He took it onto television too, on *Comedy Nights with Kapil* and *Indian Idol Junior*, and auctioned the costumes for charity. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Even the satellite deal was new: Zee paid ₹48 crore plus a share tied to the box office, which the trade called the first deal of its kind in Indian cinema. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The system around the train:

- an official website and social channels run as one operation
- browser and mobile games, including "Rahul meets Meena", which used YouTube clips, ran on Facebook and took its input from Twitter *(Fact. Social Samosa)*
- a virtual karaoke machine for recording and sharing the film's songs, and an interactive video in which viewers chose how the story unfolded *(Fact. Gamification Nation)*
- social listening and live sentiment tracking, built with Persistent Systems: 65% positive, 31% neutral, 4% negative across social channels *(Fact. Gamification Nation; the campaign's own reported figures)*
- more than 25 fan clubs working together on the promotion *(Fact. Social Samosa)*
- and after release, a missed-call line: on 20 August 2013 Twitter India and ZipDial let anyone follow @iamsrk by giving a missed call, with or without a smartphone, with a stated target of reaching 50 million people in a year *(Fact. Business Standard / IANS, 20 Aug 2013, which quotes the author as chief digital strategist)*

What it delivered. The case study's own reported figures, not independently audited *(Fact. Social Samosa, 27 Nov 2013)*:

Measure	Reported figure
Tweets across campaign hashtags	over 750,000 in 90 days
Cumulative tweet impressions	over 1 billion
Days in top trends	more than 10 in a row
Worldwide trending	#1, for #ChennaiExpress and #ChennaiExpressWeekend
Fan clubs working together	more than 25
Brand associations	30, through social media, per Persistent Systems (Sept 2014); an earlier draft said 18

It opened on 8 August 2013 with, by Persistent Systems' account, the highest opening weekend in India and the highest for a Bollywood film in the USA and Canada (Fact. PR Newswire, 18 Sept 2014). The film grossed ₹422 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Sacnilk)*

Box-office trackers agree on the scale if not the last crore. Wikipedia gives a worldwide range of ₹396 crore to ₹425 crore, with ₹424 crore as the final figure in one cited source; Box Office India puts the domestic net at ₹208 crore, other trade analysts at about ₹227 crore. It became the highest-grossing Bollywood film in India and worldwide at the time, ahead of *3 Idiots*, the fastest to ₹100 crore net, and his biggest film in India. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chennai Express; figures differ by source)* The train had arrived. *(Interpretation)*

The opening, in numbers. It opened on 3,550 screens in 2,550 cinemas in India and about 700 abroad: 196 in North America, 175 in Britain, 55 in the Middle East and 30 in Australia. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Chennai Express; the records table gives 3,700 Indian screens)* Paid previews took ₹6.75 crore, a record ahead of *3 Idiots*; day one took ₹29.25 crore, second only to *Ek Tha Tiger*; the Indian opening weekend reached ₹93.83 crore with the previews. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Abroad it opened to US$7.1 million, then a record for an Indian film: about US$2.22 million in the US and £934,118 in Britain. *(Fact. as above)* In Pakistan, where it was first pulled because four local films opened the same day, it went on to break the box-office records in Karachi. *(Fact. as above)*

The television deal. Zee bought the satellite rights for ₹48 crore, with a box-office bonus: ₹2 crore more for every ₹10 crore of net collections above ₹130 crore. It premiered on television on 20 October 2013. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The rights were priced partly on the audience the campaign would build. *(Interpretation)*

What the critics said, and what the audience did. Reviews were mixed: Taran Adarsh and Filmfare's Rachit Gupta gave four stars out of five; Anupama Chopra and Rajeev Masand two; Mayank Shekhar and Raja Sen one. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* It received seven nominations at the 59th Filmfare Awards, including Best Film, Best Director, Best Actor and Best Actress. *(Fact. as above)* [Unverified: whether it won any Filmfare award; the Red Chillies record lists one.] The gap between the reviews and the receipts is the chapter's point: this was a film the audience had been given a part in before it opened. *(Interpretation)*

The recognition. The campaign was a finalist in the Film category of the 6th Shorty Awards *(Shorty Awards)*, and its technology partner Persistent Systems won a Computerworld Data+ Editors' Choice award for it in September 2014. That release credits the author as the film's Creative and Digital Strategist *(PR Newswire)*. The film won Best Marketed Film at the Screen Awards on 14 January 2014 and at the ETC Bollywood Business Awards (Fact. Wikipedia). The author's team also received the Wharton Social Media Leadership Award and an IO Awards Best Marketed Film: **[Unverified]**

Why it still matters. The difference between a social-media campaign and a participatory system is the difference between distributing content and giving people a role. In Chennai Express a fan's action was not a number on a dashboard. It moved the story everyone could see. That was the high point of a model the industry then walked away from for a decade. *(Interpretation)*

The question for Part Three is what happened next. Why did the man who wrote this playbook stop reading from it?

Room · Tall Tales · His interviews

A room for his words to the press: the interviews that made him the most quoted star in India, and the years from 2018 when he almost stopped giving them. *(Interpretation)*

No SRKWorld screen for this room survives in the archive photographs. *(Archive: the author's collection)* The interviews below are paraphrased; his own words, kept short, are in Room · Just Like That. *(Method note)*

The landmark conversations, 1992 to 2025

Date	Stage or outlet	Subject	In one line	Source
1992	*India Today*	The television actor arriving in film	His first major magazine interview, quoted in Chapter 4	See Chapter 4

Date	Stage or outlet	Subject	In one line	Source
2005	*The Outer World of Shah Rukh Khan*, documentary by Nasreen Munni Kabir	His life on tour and at home	A Red Chillies production; the first long-form portrait of him on film	Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment
July 2007	Wire interview, outlet not named	Satellite television and multiplexes changing stardom	He said he believed he was the last superstar of India	The Himalayan Times, 29 July 2007
12 April 2012	Yale University, Chubb Fellowship lecture, Shubert Theater	Public life and fame	A fellowship whose earlier visitors include Ronald Reagan, Jimmy Carter and Toni Morrison; tickets ran out quickly	Yale News, 2 April 2012
April 2017	TED2017, Vancouver	"Thoughts on humanity, fame and love"	A 17-minute talk on ageing, fame and love; 14,094,295 plays on ted.com by October 2026	TED; The News Minute, 28 April 2017
January 2018	World Economic Forum, Davos, Crystal Award	Acid-attack survivors and the Meer Foundation	Honoured with Elton John and Cate Blanchett; told the powerful to get out of the way	Business Today, 23 January 2018

Date	Stage or outlet	Subject	In one line	Source
October 2019	Netflix, *My Next Guest Needs No Introduction with David Letterman*	From Delhi to Mumbai; his productions	A stand-alone special shot in May 2019; Letterman came to India for Eid in June	Gulf News, 26 September 2019
4 February 2023	#AskSRK on Twitter	*Pathaan*'s success	Short public answers to fans in place of press interviews	EastMojo, 4 February 2023
10 and 11 August 2024	Locarno Film Festival: Pardo alla Carriera on the Piazza Grande; public talk at Spazio Cinema	Art and cinema	A career award from a European festival, with *Devdas* screened	British Cinematographer, 2 July 2024; Gulf Today, 11 August 2024
May 2025	Met Gala, New York	His first Met Gala	A reporter did not recognise him; his two-word reply went viral	The Hollywood Reporter India
1 August 2025	Video message on social media	His first National Film Award, for *Jawan*	Recorded with an injured arm; called the award a reminder	IANS, 1 August 2025
23 September 2025	National Film Awards, Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi	Best Actor, shared with Vikrant Massey	Received from President Droupadi Murmu, 33 years after his debut	The Statesman
2 November 2025	Post on X	His 60th birthday	Did not appear at Mannat on police advice; apologised to fans	Deccan Herald, 2 November 2025

[Unverified: the claim that he was the first Indian actor to speak at TED; The News Minute's headline says so for TED in Canada, without evidence.] [Unverified: the Netflix release date of the Letterman special.] [Unverified: dates and outlets for other long interviews, including *Koffee with Karan*, NDTV and *The Anupam Kher Show*, to be added from broadcasters' archives.]

What the list shows. Until 2017 he spoke everywhere: magazines, chat shows, universities. From 2018, after *Zero*, he gave almost no film interviews; when he came back in 2023, he answered fans directly on social media and let the films speak. *(Interpretation; see Chapters 13 and 14)* The stages also changed. In the 1990s it was Indian magazines; after 2012 it was Yale, TED, Davos, Netflix and Locarno. He went from the most quoted star in India to an Indian voice in global forums. *(Interpretation)*

Tall Tales. The 2000 website's name for this room promised exaggeration, and he has always played with it: the jokes about his looks, his money and his own legend are part of how he talks. *(Interpretation)* This book quotes him only where a source records the words. *(Method note)*

Part Three · Asoka to Boo-Da · Mute Button, 2014 to 2022

In 2001 he played Asoka, the emperor who conquered everything, saw the cost at Kalinga, and gave up his sword for the Buddha's path. This thesis bends that story. Between Asoka and the Buddha sits the "boo": the jeers after Zero, the trolling, the October the whole country watched. Boo-Da is the man on the other side of the boos, someone the noise no longer reaches. *(Interpretation)*

This Part follows that passage in order: the back-off from 2014, the fall of Zero in 2018, and the four years of silence that ended with an empty road outside Mannat in October 2021. (Interpretation)

Chapter 11 · 2014 to 2018: the great digital back-off

The train reached Chennai in August 2013. Then, film by film, the man who had driven it began to step off. *(Interpretation)*

The films kept coming. The star kept smiling. But something changed in the way they reached people. The man who had led every campaign from the front began, film by film, to step back from it. *(Interpretation; from the author's essay* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act I)*

2014: a tour and a trophy. The first film after the train was Farah Khan's *Happy New Year*, a heist comedy, and its campaign went back to the stage. Before release the cast toured North America and Britain as *SLAM! The Tour*, opening at Houston's Toyota Center in September 2014, his first visit to the city in a decade. *(Fact. ABC13 Houston, Sept 2014)* It

grossed ₹397 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Sacnilk)* On the cricket field his Kolkata Knight Riders won their second IPL title on 1 June 2014. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Kolkata Knight Riders)* The money and the trophies held up. *(Interpretation)*

2015: fifty, and a sentence. On 2 November 2015, his fiftieth birthday, he told an interviewer there was "extreme intolerance" in the country. Politicians attacked him, and his next film, *Dilwale*, met protests in parts of India; in Mangaluru, Bajrang Dal activists stopped screenings. *(Fact. The News Minute, 1 Mar 2016; The News Minute) Dilwale*, his reunion with Kajol, still grossed about ₹408 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Filmibeat, 2023)*

Four months later, launching the trailer of *Fan*, he said he had never called India intolerant and had been misunderstood. Asked about the fallout, he made a joke about cricket and then said: "Freedom of speech means the right to keep silent also." *(Fact. The News Minute, 1 Mar 2016)* The showman who had answered every question for twenty-five years had found a new position: silence as a right. *(Interpretation)*

2016: a film about a fan. *Fan*, released on 15 April 2016, was about the thing he knew best: an obsessive young man from Delhi, Gaurav, who looks exactly like his idol, a film star named Aryan Khanna, and turns on him when the star rejects him. He played both. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Fan)* The campaign was built around real fans. The teaser came out on his birthday, 2 November 2015. The anthem "Jabra Fan" was released on 1 February 2016 and recorded in several languages, including Arabic. The logo was made from photographs of real fans, and graffiti was painted on his house. The trailer drew four million views in 24 hours. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Fan; Gulf News)* Made for about ₹85 crore, it grossed about ₹182 crore to ₹188 crore worldwide, below expectations for a star of his scale. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Fan; figures differ by source)*

How he became his own fan. Fan was directed by Maneesh Sharma for Yash Raj Films. The prosthetic make-up that turned him into the young Gaurav was designed by the Hollywood make-up artist Greg Cannom; he was 3D-scanned for the younger face, changed his voice for the part, and Red Chillies VFX did the effects. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Fan (2016 film))* [Unverified: Gaurav's stated age in the film.] It cost about ₹105 crore with publicity, opened to ₹19.20 crore in India and grossed about ₹182 crore to ₹188 crore worldwide; Rotten Tomatoes recorded 81% positive from 26 reviews. *(Fact. Wikipedia; figures differ within the page)* It won the Filmfare Award for special effects and the IIFA awards for make-up and special effects. *(Fact. as above)* It grossed about half of what Dilwale had grossed four months earlier. (Fact, arithmetic from Room · ArclightZ)

It is the most revealing film of the decade for this book. A star made a film about the danger of a fan who believes he owns the star, in the same years he was pulling back from his fans. *(Interpretation)* Later that year *Dear Zindagi*, in which he played a supporting role as a therapist, became the first Hindi film to market itself on Tinder. *(Fact. exchange4media, 14 Nov 2016)*

2017: the train again, and a death. For *Raees* he went back to the idea that had worked in 2013, a train, but in person. On 23 and 24 January 2017 he rode the August Kranti Rajdhani from Mumbai to Delhi, stopping at Vadodara, Ratlam, Kota and Mathura to meet fans on the platforms. At Vadodara the crowd pushed against the windows; police used lathis, one man died and two were injured. He called it "really unfortunate". *(Fact. Business Standard / IANS, 24 Jan 2017; The Tribune) Raees* grossed about ₹272 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Filmibeat, 2023)*

In 2013 the train had been virtual, and the fans had moved it with their thumbs. In 2017 it was real, and a fan died on the platform. The direct line had become dangerous. *(Interpretation)* Later that year *Jab Harry Met Sejal* replaced the single big trailer with a series of short "mini trails". *(Fact.* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act II; Millennium Post, 16 June 2017)*

Year	Film	Worldwide gross	What the campaign did
2014	Happy New Year	₹397 cr	SLAM! The Tour, a live world tour that opened at Houston's Toyota Center in September 2014 (ABC13)
2015	Dilwale	₹408 cr	The SRK and Kajol reunion carried the campaign
2016	Fan	₹182.30 cr	"Jabra Fan", one anthem in several Indian languages
2016	Dear Zindagi	₹139 cr	Tinder tie-in, "Swipe Right for Zindagi" *(exchange4media)*
2017	Raees	₹272 cr	The star took a train from Mumbai to Delhi to meet fans
2017	Jab Harry Met Sejal	₹152 cr	A series of 30-second "mini-trails" instead of one trailer, from June 2017 (Millennium Post)
2018	Zero	₹178 cr	India's first Snapchat lens for a film, WhatsApp stickers *(Social Samosa)*

Gross: Happy New Year and Fan from Sacnilk; the rest from Filmibeat (2023). Trade sources differ by a few crore.

Read the column on the right and a pattern appears. The money held up: *Happy New Year* and *Dilwale* each crossed ₹390 crore, and even the films called disappointments earned more than most stars' hits. What thinned out was the story around the films. Each campaign was a clever stunt, but no longer a movement led by the man himself. *(Interpretation; the author's essay, Act II)*

Every campaign had a clever idea: a tour, a dating app, a train, an AR lens. None was a system. Chennai Express gave the audience a role that carried across every channel for 90 days. Its successors gave the audience a moment, then moved on. *(Interpretation)* The innovation never stopped; Zero alone would launch an AR first. What stopped was the founder leading the story himself, and the architecture that turned fans into participants. *(Interpretation)*

Why did the man who wrote the playbook stop reading from it? Was it fatigue? Was it a strategy? Or was it something nobody outside the room could see? Who was running the campaigns now, and did they know what they were holding? *(The author's questions, Act I)* The record shows three things that happened in these years: a sentence on his fiftieth birthday that turned a film into a target, a film about a fan who turned on his star, and a real train where a fan died. This book does not claim to know which of them mattered most. It leaves the questions where they belong: in the reader's hands. *(Interpretation)*

Then came Zero.

Chapter 12 · Zero: the pause before the pivot

Five years after the train, he made the most ambitious film of the run, and the story around it was the most inventive since 2013. *(Interpretation)*

A title on New Year's Day. The title was revealed on 1 January 2018 in a teaser set to a Mohammed Rafi song; it passed three million YouTube views in under 24 hours. An Eid teaser on 13 June 2018 paired him with Salman Khan. The trailer, launched in November, reached 100 million YouTube views faster than any Indian film before it. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Zero)* Directed by Aanand L. Rai and produced by Gauri Khan with Rai's Colour Yellow, the film cast him as a man about three feet tall, made possible by Red Chillies VFX, which won the Filmfare Award for Best Special Effects for it. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Zero)* The effects house founded in 2006 (Chapter 7) had made its most difficult hero yet. *(Interpretation)*

Zero, in December 2018, was the most ambitious film of the run: a star playing Bauua Singh, a short man from Meerut with an outsized ego, in a story that went from small-town romance to space. The campaign gave Bauua his own digital life, with a WhatsApp sticker pack, a Snapchat story, an Amazon Alexa skill billed as a first for a Bollywood film, a Twitter handle written by the film's writer, and Bauua Ki Toli, a points game whose top fans met the cast. (Fact. exchange4media, 19 December 2018)

Six years in the making. Aanand L. Rai conceived the film in 2012 and began pre-production in 2016. It went through several working titles, among them *Katrina Meri Jaan*, before *Zero* was announced in January 2018. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Zero)* Shooting began in Mumbai in May 2017 and ended in Orlando in June 2018: about 200 shooting days against a plan of 140. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

How to shrink a star. To make him about three feet tall, the film used forced perspective, pits in the floor that were removed in post-production, and ramps in place of stairs, and its makers cited the methods of *The Lord of the Rings*. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* Room · ArclightZ records the result: Red Chillies VFX's Filmfare award. *(Fact)* No Indian star of his rank had made himself physically small for a whole film. *(Interpretation)* [Unverified: a survey of Indian leading men in comparable roles would confirm or correct this.]

The cast. Anushka Sharma played Aafia, a space scientist with cerebral palsy; Katrina Kaif played Babita, a film star with a drinking problem; Abhay Deol and R. Madhavan had supporting roles. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* The cameos amounted to a roll call of his career: Salman Khan, Kajol, Rani Mukerji, Juhi Chawla, Karisma Kapoor, Deepika Padukone, Alia Bhatt and Jaya Bachchan. Sridevi, who had died in February 2018, appeared posthumously. *(Fact. Wikipedia; Sridevi's death is public record)* A film about a small man surrounded by stars was itself surrounded by them. *(Interpretation)*

The music. Ajay–Atul composed the songs, with lyrics by Irshad Kamil and Kumaar; the singles included "Mere Naam Tu", "Issaqbaazi" and "Husn Parcham", with "Heer Badnaam" by Tanishk Bagchi added the day before release. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

The opening. It opened on about 4,380 screens in India and 1,585 abroad, 5,965 in all, the third-widest Hindi release of 2018 after *Thugs of Hindostan* and *Race 3*. *(Fact. Taran Adarsh, via Wikipedia)* Day one in India took ₹18.78 crore; the three-day weekend about ₹53 crore. *(Fact. Box Office India, via Wikipedia)*

The reviews. Mixed to negative. Rotten Tomatoes recorded 31% positive from 16 reviews. Critics praised the effects and Katrina Kaif, and faulted the plot and the second half. Baradwaj Rangan and Raja Sen gave it 3.5 out of 5; Saibal Chatterjee of NDTV gave it 2 and called it a mess; Anna MM Vetticad of Firstpost gave it 1.5. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* At the 64th Filmfare Awards it had seven nominations, including Best Actor, and won one, for special effects. *(Fact. Wikipedia)*

It opened on 21 December 2018. Its budget was given as ₹200 crore after post-production, against earlier reports of ₹150 crore. Its worldwide gross is given as ₹178 crore by one tracker and about ₹191 crore by another, with about ₹87 crore in India and US$14 million abroad. Either way it was one of the biggest failures of his career. *(Fact. Filmibeat, 2023; Wikipedia: Zero, citing Box Office India; figures differ by source)*

The numbers side by side

Measure	Zero (2018)	Chennai Express (2013)	Jawan (2023)
Reported budget	₹200 crore	₹70 crore to ₹115 crore	₹300 crore

Measure	Zero (2018)	Chennai Express (2013)	Jawan (2023)
Worldwide gross	about ₹191 crore	₹423 crore to ₹424 crore	₹1,148.32 crore
Gross divided by budget	about 0.96	about 3.7 to 6.0	about 3.8
Filmfare wins	1 (special effects)	N/A (not counted here)	N/A (not counted here)

(Fact. figures from Room · ArclightZ and each film's Wikipedia page; the ratio is this book's arithmetic, gross against reported budget, and is not profit) Zero is the only film in the table that grossed less than its reported budget. *(Fact, from the table)*

Why it failed: what the record supports. The record shows a long, expensive shoot; reviews that liked the effects and disliked the story; and an opening weekend of about ₹53 crore in India for a ₹200 crore film. *(Fact. as above)* It does not show one single cause. The common explanations, that audiences did not want to see the star diminished, or that the space-scientist second half lost the small-town audience the first half had won, are opinions. *(Interpretation)* [Unverified: audience research or exit polling from the distributors.]

What it cost, and what it bought. It cost the most visible years of his career. It also bought him the one thing a star at the top rarely gets: a reason to stop. *(Interpretation)* In 2019 he said in Beijing that he might have made the wrong film; four years later he came back with three films in a year (Chapter 14). *(Fact, as above; Interpretation)* Room · Advantage shows the same curve in the market: his brand valuation fell to 10th in 2022 and rose to 1st by 2025. *(Fact. Room · Advantage)*

China. *Zero* closed the Beijing International Film Festival in April 2019 and was released in China in March 2019. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* [Unverified: the Chinese release date, which the source places before the festival, and its Chinese gross, from Maoyan or another Chinese ticketing source.]

Four months later, in Beijing, where *Zero* closed the 2019 Beijing International Film Festival, he told CGTN: "Maybe I made the wrong film." He had not decided what to do next, he said, and "if it doesn't excite you in the morning, you should not wake up". *(Fact. Gulf News / IANS, 19 Apr 2019)* Then he did something no one expected: he stopped. No new lead role in a released film for more than four years. *(Fact; the next release was Pathaan, January 2023)*

In the language of this thesis, Zero is the 0 in Zero to One: the lowest point, and the start of the climb. *(Interpretation)*

And then, nothing. *(The author's essay, Act II)* What follows is four years of silence.

Chapter 13 · 2018 to 2022: the silence

Four years without a lead release. Almost no interviews. A star who had built an empire on talking let the silence talk for him.

2019: the year without a film. He worked, but off screen. Red Chillies produced *Bard of Blood* for Netflix, and in October 2019 he sat with David Letterman for Netflix's *My Next Guest Needs No Introduction*. *(Fact. American Bazaar, 10 Oct 2019)* On his 54th birthday, 2 November 2019, the crowd at his gate waited for an announcement that did not come. He told them: "The day it will be announced will be our birthday." *(Fact. India TV)* The only stage he kept was the balcony. *(Interpretation)*

But silence is not absence. The fan clubs kept the birthday at the gate, trended the old films and built their own campaigns. The brand was held by the people who loved it. *(Interpretation)*

Nor was the man idle. When the pandemic reached Mumbai in April 2020, he and Gauri Khan offered their four-storey personal office to the city corporation as a quarantine facility for women, children and the elderly. His Meer Foundation committed daily food for more than 5,500 families, and his companies gave to the PM-CARES Fund and the Maharashtra relief fund. *(Fact. The Tribune, 4 Apr 2020)* He did it without a campaign. (Interpretation)

Red Chillies kept producing for streaming, including the Netflix horror series *Betaal*. *(Fact. India.com)* The studio, the team and the foundation kept working. Only the star stayed off screen. *(Interpretation)*

What the company made while the star was away. Between *Zero* and *Pathaan*, Red Chillies released *Badla* (2019, ₹138.49 crore worldwide), *Bard of Blood* (Netflix, 27 September 2019), *Kaamyaab* (2020), *Betaal* and *Class of '83* (Netflix, 2020), *Bob Biswas* (ZEE5, 2021), and *Love Hostel* (ZEE5) and *Darlings* (Netflix) in 2022. *(Fact. Room · ArclightZ, from Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment)* Eight titles in four years, none of them starring him. *(Fact, count)* The silence was the actor's, not the company's. *(Interpretation)*

The cricket kept winning. In the Caribbean, the Trinbago Knight Riders, which his Knight Riders Group bought in 2015, won the 2020 Caribbean Premier League without losing a match: twelve played, twelve won. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Trinbago Knight Riders)* It was the club's fourth title, after 2015, 2017 and 2018; a fifth followed in 2025. *(Fact. as above)* In the year of the pandemic and no film, a team he owned had a perfect season. *(Interpretation)*

On 2 October 2021, Gandhi Jayanti, a raid on a cruise ship bound for Goa ended with Shah Rukh Khan's son taken into custody. He was arrested the next day. On 4 October he was produced before a magistrate and remanded. *(Fact. Free Press Journal timeline)*

That day, 4 October, there was not a single fan outside Mannat standing in silence to speak for him. *(Eyewitness account)*

Not one, at the gate of the most celebrated house in India. Every year on 2 November, crowds fill that same road for one wave from the balcony. That day the road was quiet.

The young man spent about four weeks in custody. He was granted bail on 28 October and came home on 30 October. On 27 May 2022, the investigating agency's chargesheet did not name him, citing a lack of evidence. *(Fact. Same source.)*

In order: bail was refused by a magistrate's court on 8 October and by the Special NDPS Court on 20 October. The Bombay High Court granted it on 28 October, and he came home on 30 October. *(Fact. Free Press Journal timeline; the author's essay, Act III)* Through all of it, the most quoted man in India said almost nothing in public. *(Interpretation)* What does it say about due process when a young man spends four weeks in custody in a case that later finds no evidence against him? *(Interpretation; the author's question, Act III)*

What came after matters as much as what happened. On 27 May 2022 the Narcotics Control Bureau filed its complaint against 14 people. It did not file against six others, his son among them, "due to lack of sufficient evidence", after a Special Investigation Team review. *(Fact. The News Minute, 27 May 2022)*

2022: the line held by others. Through the four years, the fan clubs did not wait for permission. They kept the birthday at the gate of his home in Mumbai, they trended his old films, they built their own campaigns. The brand was being held by the people who loved it. *(Interpretation; the author's essay, Act IV)* When he finally returned to the screen in 2022, it was in small parts in other people's films, a guest in *Rocketry* and *Brahmastra*, before his own film was ready. *(Fact. Gulf News)* Was the silence a wound, or a weapon? What did he see from the balcony, every birthday, that the industry did not? *(The author's questions, Act IV)*

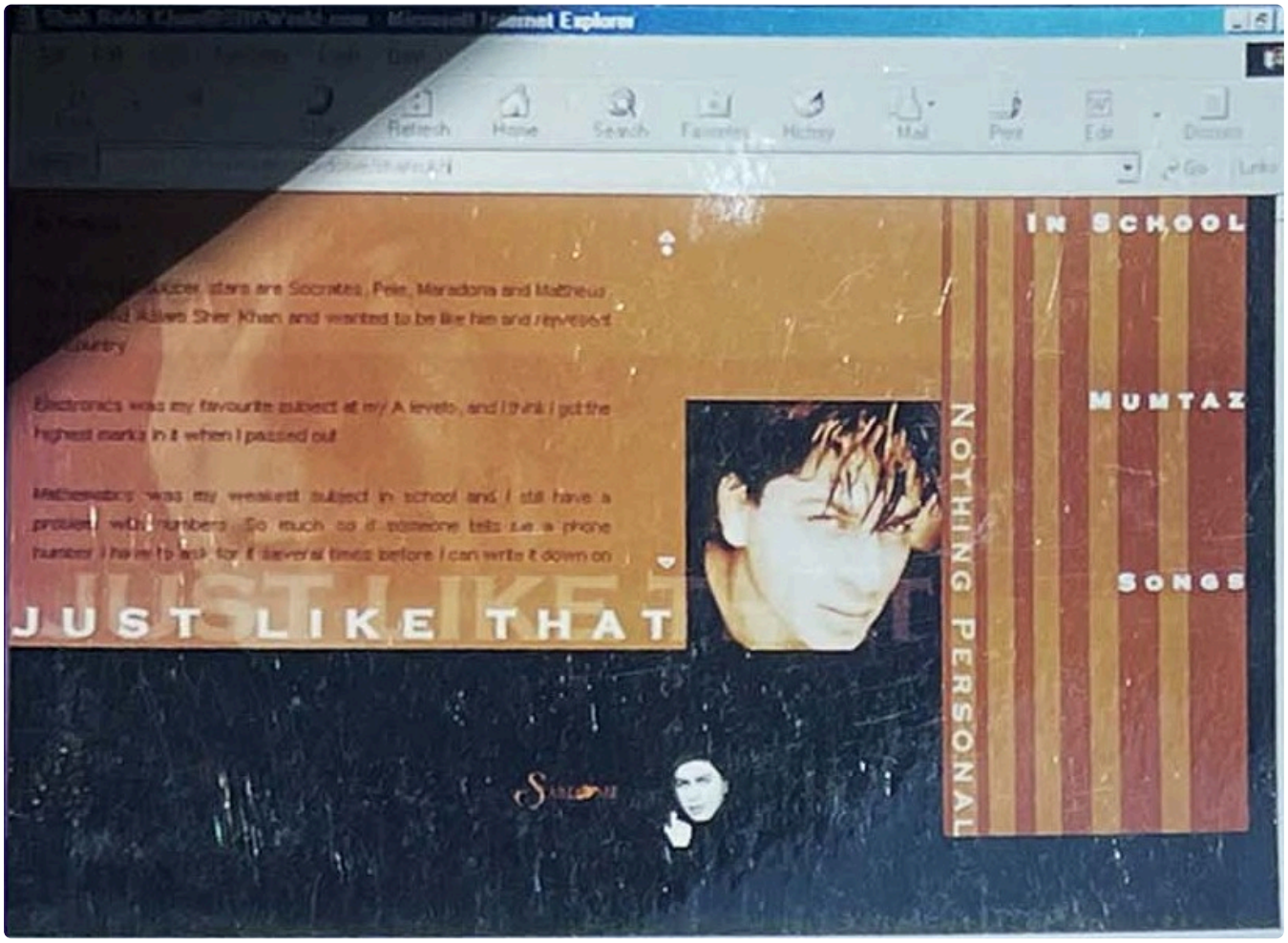
A year later, after his return, the story turned. On 12 May 2023 the Central Bureau of Investigation registered a case against Sameer Wankhede, who had headed the bureau's Mumbai office during the arrest, and four others. It alleged that they sought a ₹25 crore bribe for not framing Aryan Khan, and searched 29 locations. *(Fact. The Week, 12 May 2023)* These are allegations, not findings. Wankhede responded: "I am getting rewarded for being a patriot", and said the assets found were acquired before he joined the service. *(Fact. The Week, 14 May 2023)*

Through all of it, from the arrest to the bribery case, Shah Rukh Khan made no public statement on the case. **[Unverified: to confirm against the record]**

What does a father do with that kind of humiliation? And what does a showman do when he decides not to perform?

He waits. And when he comes back, he does not ask to be seen.

Room · Just Like That · His musings



SRKWorld.com, 2000: "Just Like That", his musings, under the tabs In School, Mumtaz, Nothing Personal and Songs. (Archive: the author's collection)

A room for the man thinking aloud: the lines he has said in public, short, dated and sourced, from 1992 to 2026. *(Interpretation)*

Rules for this room: each line is his own, under fifteen words, with a date and a source. Where the original occasion is not known, it says so. *(Method note)*

Lines with a date

Date	His words	Occasion	Source
July 2007	"I would like to believe that I am the last superstar of India"	Interview reported by wire services	The Himalayan Times, 29 July 2007

Date	His words	Occasion	Source
April 2017	"I sell dreams, and I peddle love to millions of people"	TED2017, Vancouver	TED
January 2018	"We, the powerful, need to get out of the way."	Crystal Award, Davos	Business Today, 23 January 2018
4 February 2023	"The journey is important… the end is not"	#AskSRK, on advice to his children	EastMojo, 4 February 2023
4 February 2023	"Still feeling it bro"	#AskSRK, on *Pathaan*'s success	EastMojo
11 August 2024	"Art is the act of affirming life above all."	Locarno, accepting the Pardo alla Carriera	Gulf Today, 11 August 2024
11 August 2024	"It's just like being home in India."	Locarno, on the crowd	Gulf Today
May 2025	"I'm Shah Rukh."	Met Gala, to a reporter who did not know him	The Hollywood Reporter India
1 August 2025	"acting is not just work, it's a responsibility."	Message after the National Award	IANS, 1 August 2025
1 August 2025	"just keep the popcorn ready."	The same message, to his fans	IANS
23 September 2025	"a moment I will cherish for a lifetime"	Receiving the National Award	The Statesman
2 November 2025	"I will miss seeing you more than you will."	His 60th birthday, on X	Deccan Herald, 2 November 2025

Lines without a known occasion. These are widely attributed to him and were collected by Gulf News for his 25 years in film; the original dates and occasions are not given. [Unverified: the original occasion and date of each.]

- "Success is not a good teacher. Failure is."
- "There's only one religion in the world — hard work."
- "I don't wear my stardom like a tuxedo, I wear it like a T-shirt."
- "Don't become a philosopher before you become rich."

(Source: Gulf News, 1 November 2018) He has also said "I am the last of the stars" on *The Anupam Kher Show*. *(Fact. Morung Express, 8 October 2025)* [Unverified: the broadcast date.]

What he keeps saying. Read in order, the lines return to three ideas: he is the last of a kind of star (2007 and on Anupam Kher's show), failure teaches more than success, and the audience is home. *(Interpretation)* The man who said in 2007 that he might be the last superstar was valued first in India in 2025 (Room · Advantage). *(Interpretation)*

The 2000 page. On his website this room was his own column: *Just Like That*, with tabs called *In School*, *Mumtaz*, *Nothing Personal* and *Songs*. *(Archive: the author's collection, the screen above)* [Unverified: the text of those pages, to be transcribed from the author's archive with his permission.] The lines in this room are the public version of that column. *(Interpretation)*

Part Four · Encore · The return, 2023 to 2026

He came back on his own terms: no media tour, no explaining, only the films, the fans and the balcony. The silence had turned into scarcity, and scarcity into an event. (Interpretation)

Chapter 14 · 2023: three films, one year

He waited four years. When he came back, he did not ask to be seen. *(Interpretation)*

The comeback began on his birthday. On 2 November 2022 the Pathaan teaser arrived *(Sacnilk)*, and the campaign that followed broke every rule of the playbook he had written: almost no interviews, no media tour, no explaining. The film, the music, the fans and one man on a balcony.

December 2022: one more boycott. The first song, "Besharam Rang", drew protests over a saffron-coloured bikini; a Madhya Pradesh minister called it objectionable, effigies were burned, and on 4 January 2023 Bajrang Dal members tore down posters at an Ahmedabad multiplex. The censor board asked for changes, but the scene stayed, and Gujarat's home minister promised cinemas police protection. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Pathaan)* It was the third boycott of the book, after *My Name Is Khan* in 2010 and *Dilwale* in 2015. This time he did not answer at all. *(Interpretation)*

The trade noticed. On 17 January 2023, eight days before release, the analyst Taran Adarsh pointed out that the film had given "NO interviews to media persons during pre-release promotions", relying on songs and trailers instead. *(Fact. Social Samosa, Jan 2023)*

But the star did talk, only not to the press. From the day he announced the film, 2 March 2022, he ran #AskSRK: short question-and-answer sessions of about 15 minutes on his own Twitter account, where more than 43 million followers could ask him anything. *(Fact. The Quint)* Fans filled the gap the press left: blood donation camps, life-size cutouts, house-full first shows. On 25 January 2023 Pathaan crossed ₹100 crore worldwide on its first day. *(Fact. Social Samosa)*

25 January 2023: Pathaan. The trailer, released on 10 January, was projected on the Burj Khalifa on 14 January. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Pathaan)* The film, directed by Siddharth Anand for Yash Raj Films on a budget of about ₹250 crore, opened on 25 January on about 8,000 screens, 5,500 of them in India. It took ₹106 crore worldwide on its first day, the first Hindi film to cross ₹100 crore in a day, and became the first Hindi film to earn ₹500 crore net in India. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Pathaan, citing Bollywood Hungama)* Its final worldwide gross is given as ₹1,050 crore by Bollywood Hungama and ₹1,055 crore by The Sentinel. *(Fact; figures differ by source)*

This was not silence. It was the founder returning as the medium, in a new form: no intermediaries, no media tour, only the star and his fans, face to face, at scale. It was the Chennai Express lesson, rewritten for 2023. *(Interpretation)*

What Pathaan broke. It opened on about 8,000 screens worldwide, 5,500 of them in India, and took ₹106 crore worldwide on its first day: ₹70 crore in India and ₹36.69 crore abroad. It was the first Hindi film to gross ₹100 crore worldwide in a day. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Pathaan)* It went on to become the fastest Hindi film to ₹200, ₹300 and ₹400 crore in India; the first original Hindi film to net more than ₹400 crore at home, then the first to net ₹500 crore; and, on its 37th day, the highest-grossing Hindi film in India, passing *Baahubali 2*. *(Fact. Wikipedia)* It was a Yash Raj Films production, directed by Siddharth Anand, on a reported budget of ₹250 crore, and grossed ₹1,050.30 crore worldwide. *(Fact. Wikipedia; the page also gives ₹1,050.50 crore)* Every one of those records was set by a man who had given no interview about the film. *(Interpretation; see Room · Tall Tales)*

7 September 2023: Jawan. The second film of the year was his own. *Jawan*, directed by Atlee in his Hindi debut and produced by Gauri Khan for Red Chillies on a budget of about ₹300 crore, opened on 7 September 2023 with ₹75.4 crore net in India, a record for a Hindi film. Its pre-release event was held in Chennai on 30 August, at a college, not a press hall. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Jawan)* It grossed ₹1,138 crore worldwide by its sixth week by one count and more than ₹1,148 crore by November by another, the highest-grossing Indian film of 2023 and the highest-grossing Hindi film in India. *(Fact. Madhyamam; Wikipedia: Jawan, citing Bollywood Hungama)* Two years later, on 1 August 2025, it won him his first National Film Award for Best Actor. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Jawan)*

21 December 2023: Dunki. The third was Rajkumar Hirani's *Dunki*, a story of migrants taking the illegal "donkey route" abroad. Its first teaser, "Drop 1", came out on 2 November 2023, his 58th birthday. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Dunki; The Quint, 2 Nov 2023)* It grossed about ₹410 crore worldwide in 13 days, and finished at about ₹454 crore by Sacnilk's count and ₹470.6 crore by Bollywood Hungama's. *(Fact. The Sentinel; Wikipedia: Dunki; figures differ by source)*

Film	Release	Worldwide gross	Second count	Sources
Pathaan	25 Jan 2023	₹1,055 cr	₹1,050 cr	The Sentinel; Bollywood Hungama
Jawan	7 Sept 2023	₹1,138 cr (by week six)	₹1,148 cr (by 10 Nov 2023)	Madhyamam; Bollywood Hungama
Dunki	21 Dec 2023	₹454 cr	₹470.6 cr	Sacnilk; Bollywood Hungama
Total, three films	2023	₹2,647 cr	₹2,669 cr	sum of each column

Two films past ₹1,000 crore in one year, and a third past ₹400 crore. Dunki even kept the birthday ritual: its first "drop", the teaser, came out on 2 November 2023. *(Fact. The Quint, 2 Nov 2023)*

The man everyone had written off had not lost his audience. He had stopped asking for it, and it came anyway. Silence had become scarcity, and scarcity had become an event. *(Interpretation)*

Was this a comeback, or had he simply never left? If silence can sell a ₹1,000-crore film, what can the showman do when he speaks again? *(The author's questions; the essay* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act V)*

The answer came in the next three years, not in films but in everything around them. *(Interpretation)*

2023 in one sum. *Pathaan* ₹1,050.30 crore, *Jawan* ₹1,148.32 crore and *Dunki* about ₹470.6 crore: about ₹2,669 crore worldwide from three films in eleven months. *(Fact, this book's arithmetic from the Wikipedia figures cited above and in Room · ArclightZ)* The five years before (2018 to 2022) produced one lead release, *Zero*, at about ₹191 crore. *(Fact. Chapter 12)* [Unverified: whether any Indian actor has had a higher combined worldwide gross in a single calendar year, from a trade database such as Box Office India.] He was 57 when the year began. *(Fact, from his date of birth)*

Chapter 15 · 2024 to 2026: the empire

After 2023 he did not rush into the next film. For almost three years there was no new release. Instead, the institution he had built in Part One came back into view, piece by piece, and the world started asking to see him. *(Interpretation)*

2024: a title and a career award. On 26 May 2024 his Kolkata Knight Riders won their third IPL title. *(Fact. Sky Sports, 26 May 2024)* On 10 August the Locarno Film Festival gave him its Pardo alla Carriera, a career award. *(Fact. bluewin / Keystone-SDA, 2 July 2024)* The Hurun India Rich List took him in for the first time in August 2024, and its 2025 list named him a billionaire, a fortune driven by Red Chillies (table below). *(Fact. Outlook Business)* The company Gauri Khan and he had set up in 2002 had become the asset. *(Interpretation)*

The final in Chennai. On 26 May 2024 at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, Kolkata bowled Sunrisers Hyderabad out for 114, the lowest total in an IPL final, and won by eight wickets in 10.3 overs, with Shreyas Iyer as captain and Gautam Gambhir as mentor. It was the club's third title and its first in ten years. *(Fact. The Telegraph t2, 26 May 2024)* The cricket business he bought in 2008 for US$75.09 million (Room · ArclightZ) won its third title the year after his films won back the box office. *(Interpretation)*

The money, by the lists that measure it

Date	Measure	Figure	Source
August 2024	Hurun India Rich List 2024, first entry	₹7,300 crore	Deccan Chronicle, 30 August 2024
1 October 2025	Hurun India Rich List 2025, billionaire	about ₹12,490 crore (US$1.4 billion), mainly from his stake in Red Chillies	The Hollywood Reporter India, 6 October 2025
2025 valuation, published August 2026	Kroll celebrity brand value, rank 1 in India	US$177.9 million	Manifest, 5 August 2026

In one year the Hurun figure rose by about 71%. *(Fact, this book's arithmetic from the table: 12,490 ÷ 7,300)* Hurun's 2025 list put Juhi Chawla and her family, his partners since 1999, at ₹7,790 crore. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* The same report ranked him above Taylor Swift (US$1.3 billion) and Arnold Schwarzenegger (US$1.2 billion). *(Fact. as above)* [Unverified: Hurun's method; it is an estimate, not an audited figure.]

What the money is made of. Not acting fees. Hurun attributes the fortune to Red Chillies, the company that lost money on its first films (Room · ArclightZ). *(Fact. as above; Interpretation)* The actor of Part One became the owner of Part Four. *(Interpretation)*

2025: the carpet and the National Award. In May 2025 he made his Met Gala debut, dressed by Sabyasachi. *(Fact. The National, 6 May 2025)* On 1 August 2025, 33 years after *Deewana*, he won his first National Film Award for Best Actor, for *Jawan*. *(Fact. Filmibeat;*

Wikipedia: Jawan)

2026: the King's year. In January 2026, on *Pathaan*'s third anniversary, came the KING teaser and its release date, 24 December 2026, with the line "It's time to roar and end the year with fear." *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India; the author's essay, Act VI)* On 3 June he joined Team Visa as its India brand ambassador. *(Fact. Visa press release, 3 June 2026)* On 1 July he welcomed fans to the Knight Riders Cricket Ground at Fairplex in Pomona, Los Angeles, the home of his Major League Cricket team: "Welcoming you all to the Knight Riders Cricket Ground, LA." *(Fact. Khaleej Times, 2 July 2026)*

On 15 September 2026 he was named among the investors in a US$40 million Series B round, led by QED Investors, for Flam, a company that builds AI-powered interactive content. One of its products, Flicks, makes interactive videos that can swap a person, a product or a scene during playback. *(Fact. YourStory, 15 Sept 2026)*

The showman is back on stage. Not as a man asking to be seen, but as one the world asks to see. *(Interpretation; the author's essay, Act VI)* The court around the King, year by year:

When	What	Source
2024	Kolkata Knight Riders win the IPL	**Sky Sports, 26 May 2024 (their third title)**
2024	Pardo alla Carriera, the Locarno Film Festival's career award, presented on 10 August	**bluewin (Keystone-SDA), 2 July 2024**
2024	Hurun India Rich List: a billionaire, driven by Red Chillies	Outlook Business
2025	Met Gala debut, in Sabyasachi	The National
2025	First National Film Award for Best Actor, for Jawan, 33 years into his career	Filmibeat
Jan 2026	KING teaser and release date, on Pathaan's third anniversary	The Hollywood Reporter India
Jun 2026	Joins Team Visa as India brand ambassador	**Visa press release, 3 June 2026**
Jul 2026	Unveils the Knight Riders Cricket Ground at Fairplex, Pomona, Los Angeles, on 2 July	Khaleej Times
Sep 2026	Invests in Flam, an AI interactive-content company, in its $40 million Series B led by QED Investors	YourStory

The same institutions once shut a door on him. In 2012 the Mumbai Cricket Association banned him from the Wankhede Stadium for five years, and lifted the ban in 2015. *(Fact. Deccan Chronicle)* Fourteen years later he opened a cricket ground of his own, in America.

The last line of the table matters most for this thesis. The man who built a digital kingdom in 2011 is now putting money into AI content. The question of who owns a face in the AI era is no longer abstract for him. *(Interpretation)*

A man who has invested in a company that can swap a face in a video is about to release a film in a year when fans are already making him with AI, without asking. That is where Part Five begins. *(Interpretation)*

Part Five · KING Size · 2026

The last movement belongs to the fans. In 2026, before the studio shows a frame, the audience he spent thirty-five years reaching starts building the King itself. (Interpretation)

Chapter 16 · KING: the hype before a frame

Every road in this book leads to one film. *(Interpretation)*

How KING became his. It did not begin as his film. It was first planned with Sujoy Ghosh directing, Suhana Khan in the lead and her father in a cameo. Over time it grew into a Shah Rukh Khan film, and Siddharth Anand, the director of *Pathaan*, took over. *(Fact. The Week, 18 Jan 2026)* A film made to launch the daughter became the father's return. *(Interpretation)*

2 November 2025: sixty, and the title. On his sixtieth birthday the title was revealed in a one-minute video: silver hair, a deep voice, a prisoner fighting his way out of a maximum-security jail. His line was "Darr nahi, dehshat hoon": I am not fear, I am terror. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India, 2 Nov 2025)* Thirty-two years after *Darr* made a stalker a star (Chapter 5), the man who played him named the next film by stepping past it. *(Interpretation)* The cast named that day ran from Deepika Padukone and Suhana Khan to Abhishek Bachchan, Anil Kapoor, Jackie Shroff, Arshad Warsi, Jaideep Ahlawat and Abhay Varma. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)*

In January 2026 trade reports put the release at Christmas, with no Hindi film set against it. *(Fact. The Week, 18 Jan 2026)* The date was then fixed for 24 December 2026, announced with a teaser on *Pathaan*'s third anniversary (Chapter 15). *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)*

KING opens on 24 December 2026, directed by Siddharth Anand, the director of Pathaan. It brings back Deepika Padukone, casts Abhishek Bachchan as the antagonist, and gives his daughter Suhana Khan her big-screen debut. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)*

The making of KING, as the public record shows it

Date	What happened	Source
27 June 2023	First reports: an action thriller with Sujoy Ghosh directing and Suhana Khan's feature debut	India Today, via Wikipedia: King (2026 film)
10 January 2024	Sajid Nadiadwala, who held the title KING for a shelved Hrithik Roshan film, transfers it to Red Chillies	Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia
26 to 28 February 2024	Father and daughter confirmed; reports say the story is inspired by *Léon: The Professional*	Pinkvilla; Times of India, via Wikipedia
15 July 2024	Abhishek Bachchan joins as the main antagonist	Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia
11 August 2024	He confirms the film in public at Locarno (Room · Tall Tales)	The Hindu, via Wikipedia
23 December 2024	Siddharth Anand replaces Sujoy Ghosh as director; Ghosh keeps the story credit	Hindustan Times, via Wikipedia
April to June 2025	Deepika Padukone, Arshad Warsi, Anil Kapoor, Jackie Shroff, Rani Mukerji (as Suhana's mother), Jaideep Ahlawat, Raghav Juyal and Saurabh Shukla join	India Today; Times Now; Hindustan Times, via Wikipedia
May 2025	Shooting starts at Mehboob Studios, Mumbai	Times of India, via Wikipedia
June 2025	A prison action sequence with about 200 stunt performers is shot in Mumbai	India Today, 18 June 2025, via Wikipedia
19 July 2025	He is injured on set at the Golden Tobacco Factory, Vile Parle, and travels to the US for treatment	India Today; Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia

Date	What happened	Source
1 August 2025	He records his National Award message with his arm in a sling	IANS, 1 August 2025
September 2025	Second schedule in Warsaw, Poland	Times of India, 3 September 2025, via Wikipedia
2 November 2025	Title and first look on his 60th birthday	The Hollywood Reporter India (above)
December 2025	Shooting resumes after a six-week break for his recovery	Bollywood Hungama, 19 December 2025, via Wikipedia
January 2026	A reported ₹50 crore action sequence with Abhishek Bachchan is shot in Gdańsk, Poland	Bollywood Hungama, 29 January 2026, via Wikipedia
24 January 2026	Release date confirmed by a teaser on *Pathaan*'s third anniversary	Indian Express; Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia
3 February 2026	Yash Raj Films takes the overseas release	Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia
March 2026	An eight-night Vijayadashami action sequence with Suhana at Ellora Studios, Mumbai; a Dubai desert schedule is moved to Mumbai because of tension in the Middle East	News18; Cinema Express, via Wikipedia
20 April 2026	Pen Marudhar reported to have taken India distribution in a ₹250 crore theatrical deal	Bollywood Hungama, via Wikipedia
May 2026	A song with Deepika Padukone is shot in Cape Town	Bollywood Hungama, 1 May 2026, via Wikipedia
July 2026	Social media claims a ₹450 crore budget; Siddharth Anand posts "False" on X, without naming the film	India TV

The film on paper. Story by Sujoy Ghosh; screenplay by Ghosh, Siddharth Anand, Suresh Nair and Sagar Pandya; dialogue by Abbas Tyrewala; cinematography by Satchith Paulose; editing by Ruben; songs by Sachin–Jigar, working with him for the first time, and

background score by Anirudh Ravichander. It is produced by Gauri Khan, Siddharth Anand and Mamta Anand for Red Chillies and Marflix Pictures, and will release in Hindi with Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam and English versions. *(Fact. Wikipedia: King (2026 film), October 2026)* He is reported to play an assassin, and Suhana his apprentice. *(Fact, as reported; Bollywood Hungama and Hindustan Times, via Wikipedia)* Ranveer Singh is listed in an extended cameo. [Unverified: the cameo list, until the makers confirm it.]

The money on paper. The budget most often reported is ₹350 crore; Bollywood Hungama called it India's costliest action film. *(Fact, as reported. Wikipedia, citing Bollywood Hungama, 8 November 2025)* A ₹450 crore figure has been denied. *(Fact. India TV)* [Unverified: the budget, until the producers publish one.] For scale: *Jawan*'s budget was reported at ₹300 crore and it grossed ₹1,148.32 crore (Room · ArclightZ). *(Fact)*

What the record says about the man. He turned sixty during the shoot, was injured, took six weeks off and went back to action sequences in Poland. *(Fact, from the table)* The film was first built to launch his daughter; by reported budget it became the most expensive film of his career, with his daughter still in it. *(Interpretation)* At the start of the book, a father lost his homeland at Partition (Chapter 1). At the end, a father hands his craft to his daughter on screen. *(Interpretation)*

The official campaign has barely started. The fans are already running it.

Measure (KING Intelligence tracker)	4 Oct 2026	5 Oct 2026
Observable KING posts	699,000	742,400
Views across tracked KING videos	31.18M	38.72M
Views on the top KING video	12.97M	16.21M

In one day: 43,400 new posts and about 7.5 million new views, with no official campaign behind them. *(Fact: this campaign's own tracker, against the locked 4 October baseline)*

One day. Forty-three thousand new posts. Seven million new views. What happens when the showman walks back on stage himself? *(The author's question; the essay* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act VII)*

He will not walk on alone. Six days before KING, Marvel's biggest villain arrives. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 17 · DOOM to KING: one Christmas, two crowns

Avengers: Doomsday opens on 18 December 2026 with Robert Downey Jr. as Doctor Doom. KING follows six days later. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India)* The trade wants a clash. This thesis reads a relay. Two men born in 1965, one red suit and one blue, both

written off and both back, walking to the dark side of the screen in the same week. Final score: Cinema 2, Boredom 0. *(Interpretation)*

The other King of Christmas. *Avengers: Doomsday*, directed by Anthony and Joe Russo, brings Robert Downey Jr. back to Marvel as its villain, Doctor Doom. The casting was revealed on stage at San Diego Comic-Con in July 2024 and confirmed with a first look at CinemaCon in 2026; the film is dated 18 December 2026 in the United States. *(Fact. Central Jersey, 16 July 2026; t2)*

The two films on paper, October 2026

Measure	Avengers: Doomsday	KING
Release	18 December 2026 (US)	24 December 2026
Directors	Anthony and Joe Russo	Siddharth Anand
The star's role	Robert Downey Jr. as Doctor Doom, the villain	Shah Rukh Khan, reported as an assassin
Announced	San Diego Comic-Con, July 2024	Title on his 60th birthday, 2 November 2025
Shooting	28 April to 19 September 2025, Pinewood and Shinfield Studios, Windsor Great Park, Bahrain	May 2025 to mid-2026: Mumbai, Warsaw, Gdańsk, Cape Town
Runtime	about 165 minutes	N/A (not announced)
Reported budget	N/A (not published)	₹350 crore, as reported
Advance sales so far	US$50 million in presales by early September 2026	N/A (bookings not open)
Premium screens	Locked out of US IMAX for at least three weeks by *Dune: Part Three*; other premium formats	N/A (not announced)
Distribution	Disney / Marvel Studios	Pen Marudhar (India); Yash Raj Films (overseas)

(Fact. Wikipedia: Avengers: Doomsday and Wikipedia: King (2026 film), October 2026; KING details as in Chapter 16) [Unverified: Doomsday's India release date, from Disney India.]

What the table shows. Marvel has sold the film in public since July 2024, with trailers, livestreams, a podcast and presale figures. KING had released a title video, a date teaser and almost nothing else by October 2026. *(Fact, as above; Interpretation)* One campaign spends money to build expectation; the other spends silence, and lets the fans do the building (Chapter 18). *(Interpretation)* Both stars are 61 at Christmas 2026, and both play the man you fear. *(Fact, from public dates of birth; Interpretation)*

The class of '65. Robert Downey Jr. was born on 4 April 1965. Shah Rukh Khan was born on 2 November 1965. *(Fact. Public record)* Same year, two hemispheres, two careers that went from boy wonder to written off to the biggest comeback in their industries. Both once saved the world in a superhero suit, one red, one blue: Iron Man in 2008, built in a cave from a box of scraps; G.One in 2011, stepping out of a video game his creator built for his son (Chapter 9). This Christmas, at 61, both walk to the dark side of the screen: one as the villain of the Marvel universe, one as the man they call KING. Retirement plans: not found. *(Interpretation; the author's essay* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act VIII)*

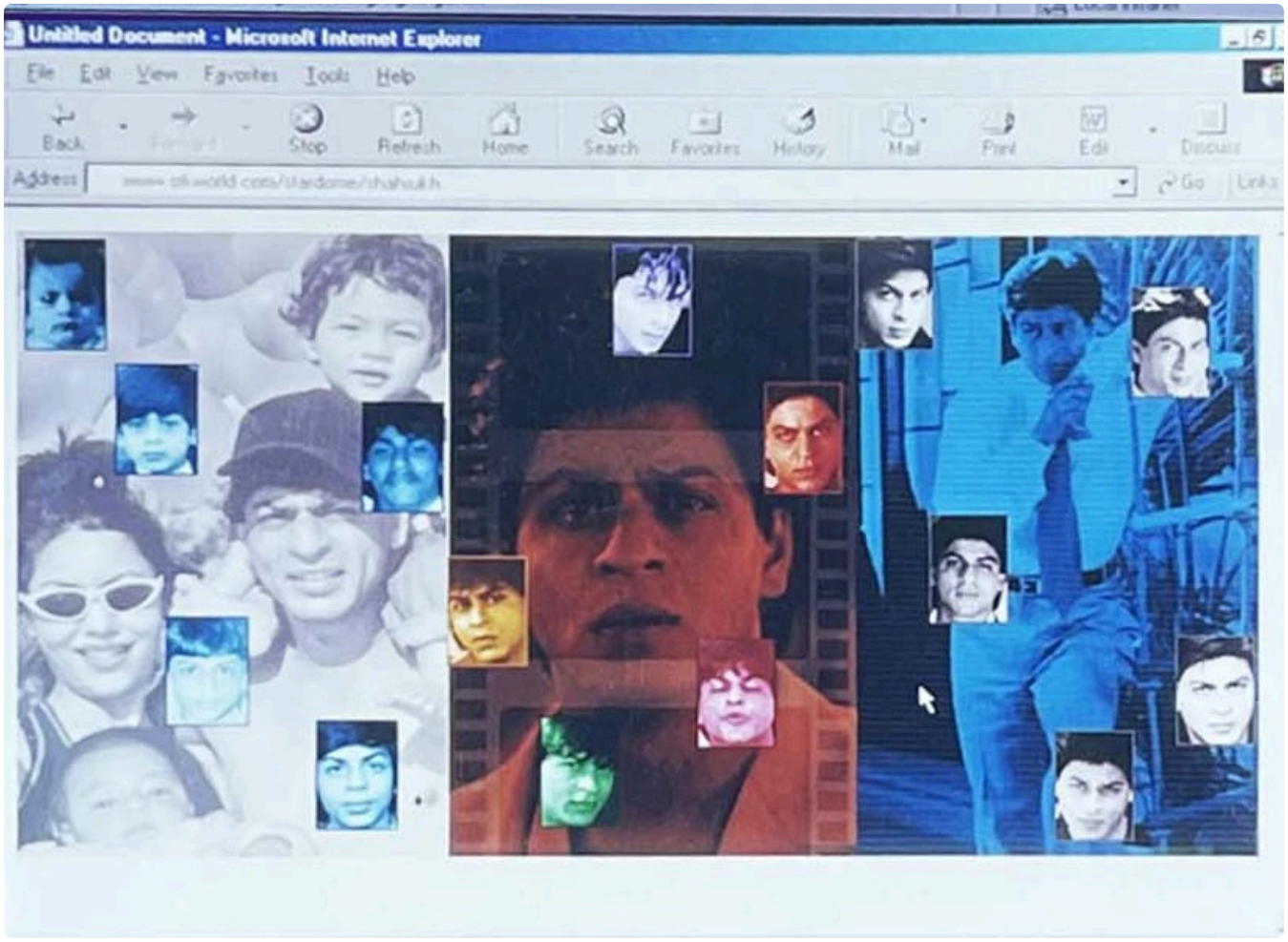
Six rounds, no losers. The author scores it as a friendly fixture, not a fight. *(Interpretation; Act VIII)*

- **Star power.** The man who built the Marvel Cinematic Universe against the last of the stars. Point to both, and to the audience.
- **Home crowd.** DOOM owns the global multiplex; KING owns Indian screens and the diaspora at Christmas. Two home games in one week.
- **The character.** A villain fans have waited decades to see, against a new KING nobody has seen yet. Curiosity wins either way.
- **The campaign.** A studio machine with a hundred-film head start, against a fan army that makes its own posters. Both are worth studying.
- **The scheduling.** Six days apart is not a clash. It is enough time to watch one, argue about it, and queue for the other.
- **The street.** The real result is decided at the box office, in the reviews and over family dinners. This book will report the numbers when they exist, and not before.

The tale of the tape, played for laughs and with respect to both corners: one villain puts on a metal mask; the other does not need one, and raises an eyebrow. One snaps his fingers and half the universe goes quiet; the other opens his arms and the other half comes running. One's fans stay for the post-credits scene; the other's stand outside his gate in Mumbai every 2 November. *(Interpretation; Act VIII)*

Final score: Cinema 2, Boredom 0. *(Interpretation)* The real contest of that Christmas is not between two studios. It is between a studio campaign and a fan campaign, and in India the fans have already started. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 18 · Fan Mail · The fans take the wheel



SRKWorld.com, 2000: a page of fans' faces around his. Twenty-six years before the fans began making him with AI, his website put them in the frame. (Archive: the author's collection)

The line he opened on Doordarshan in 1989, rebuilt in 2000 and turned into a system in 2013, the fans now build themselves. *(Interpretation)*

Before the studio showed more than a teaser, fans began making their own KING with AI: concept trailers, first looks, songs and scenes. A daily log found 39 such public works on YouTube by 10 October 2026, with 2,883,120 combined views. Several name the tools that made them: Kling, Seedance, Grok. *(Fact: this campaign's AI creator log; treat it as a floor, not a census)*

From 12 October 2026 the same log scans Instagram, X and Facebook every morning. It counts only what it has found and checked, so it is a floor, not a census. *(Fact: the campaign's AI creator log; the author's essay, Act IX)*

The balcony goes quiet. His birthday had a fixed venue for years: the wall of Mannat, where he greeted the crowd below as an annual ritual. *(Fact. Deccan Herald, 2 Nov 2025)* On 2 November 2025, his 60th birthday, fans from several countries waited outside the house through rain, some up in the trees, while it stood under renovation and police held

the street. *(Fact. Deccan Herald, 2 Nov 2025)* He did not come out. He posted that authorities had advised against it, "for the overall safety of everyone due to crowd control issues", and added: "I will miss seeing you more than you will." *(Fact. Deccan Herald, 2 Nov 2025)*

Instead he met fans at "SRK Day", a closed event in a Bandra auditorium, and watched the KING title reveal with them. *(Fact. The Hollywood Reporter India, 3 Nov 2025)* When he stepped outside the venue afterwards, the crowd pushed in to touch him and security walked him away. *(Fact. Siasat, 3 Nov 2025)* No report gives a head count. [Unverified: the number of fans outside Mannat and at SRK Day on 2 November 2025; needs a police or organiser figure] A ritual that once needed only a street now needed a room with a guest list. Within a year the fans had found a venue no advisory can close: their own screens. *(Interpretation)*

A new oil, and nobody holds the licence. When oil was found, the car followed, then the road, the mechanic, the driver and the whole economy around them. A star's face is the oil of the AI era. Today fans drill it without a licence, AI companies refine it without paying for it, and the people who own it have not yet built a pipeline. The opportunity is an official reserve: the star's likeness, voice and worlds, opened to storytellers on fair terms. The star earns from the fans' creativity instead of fighting it, and fans create without fear. *(Interpretation; Act IX)*

The courts and the fans. By 2026 Indian courts were acting on AI likeness for individual stars: the Delhi High Court ordered AI deepfakes taken down for, among others, Ajay Devgn in November 2025, R. Madhavan in December 2025 and Kajol in February 2026. *(Fact. OECD AI incidents: Ajay Devgn; R. Madhavan; Storyboard18: Kajol)* Fans had defended stars before: in January 2024 Taylor Swift's fans flooded X with #ProtectTaylorSwift to bury explicit AI fakes of her. *(Fact. KTVU / AP, Jan 2024)* Those were defences. What the KING fans began in 2026 was a demand. *(Interpretation)*

The rulebook, 2022 to 2026. Those three orders were the newest in a line that runs back at least to Amitabh Bachchan in November 2022. In four years Indian courts, an Indian ministry and lawmakers abroad wrote the first working rules for a famous face. *(Interpretation; dated entries below are Fact, each with its source)*

Date	Where	Who or what	What it covers	Source
31 Mar 2026 (expected)	Denmark	Amendment to copyright law on voice and appearance	A new right in one's own voice and physical appearance, modelled on copyright. [Unverified: that it entered force on this date]	Verfassungsblog, 26 Mar 2026
20 Feb 2026 (notified 10 Feb)	India, Ministry of Electronics and IT	IT Rules amendment on "synthetically generated information"	Realistic AI audio and video must be prominently labelled and carry permanent metadata; platforms act on court or government orders within 3 hours, down from 36	Hogan Lovells
8 to 24 Feb 2026	Delhi and Bombay High Courts	Vivek Oberoi (8 Feb), Shatrughan Sinha (16 Feb, Bombay), Jubin Nautiyal (19 Feb), Baba Ramdev (24 Feb)	Personality-rights orders	Storyboard18
Oct 2025	Bombay High Court	Akshay Kumar	Personality-rights order	Storyboard18
Oct 2025	Delhi High Court, Justice Manmeet Pritam Arora	Hrithik Roshan (petition filed)	Personality-rights petition, days after other stars	DNA, 14 Oct 2025

Date	Where	Who or what	What it covers	Source
9 Sep 2025	Delhi High Court, Justice Tejas Karia	Aishwarya Rai Bachchan	Name, image, voice; AI-morphed images; Google to remove URLs in 72 hours, the ministry to block them within a week	The Hollywood Reporter India, 16 Sep 2025
Sep 2025	Delhi High Court	Abhishek Bachchan	Personality-rights order	Storyboard18
19 May 2025	United States	TAKE IT DOWN Act, signed into federal law	Platforms remove non-consensual intimate images within 48 hours of a victim's request	Akin Gump
15 May 2024	Delhi High Court, Justice Sanjeev Narula	Jackie Shroff	Name, "Jaggu Dada", voice and image for commercial use; a fan "Thug Life" compilation was left up	Mondaq, 27 May 2024; S.S. Rana
21 Mar 2024 (in force 1 Jul)	Tennessee, United States	ELVIS Act, signed by Governor Bill Lee	Adds voice to the state's likeness right; a civil action against unauthorised copies of voice or likeness	AP via News4JAX, 21 Mar 2024
20 Sep 2023	Delhi High Court, Justice Prathiba M. Singh	Anil Kapoor	Name, likeness, voice; AI tools used to morph his image; GIFs for gain; the domain anilkapoor.com blocked	Business Today, 20 Sep 2023

Date	Where	Who or what	What it covers	Source
25 Nov 2022	Delhi High Court, Justice Navin Chawla	Amitabh Bachchan	Name, voice, image; telecom firms and the ministry told to take down links and block numbers	The Week, 25 Nov 2022

The name not on the list. Three of his KING co-stars, Abhishek Bachchan, Anil Kapoor and Jackie Shroff, hold court orders over their own likeness. *(Fact: the table above; cast from The Hollywood Reporter India, 3 Nov 2025)* This book found no public record that Shah Rukh Khan has sought one. [Unverified: whether he has filed for personality-rights protection in any court, as of 17 October 2026; needs a search of Delhi and Bombay High Court records] On the public record, much of the cast of KING is protected from AI copies by a court; its lead is protected mainly by his fans. *(Interpretation)*

The fan exception. The Jackie Shroff order drew a line fans can use. It barred commercial use of his name, voice and image, but declined to act against a fan's "Thug Life" compilation video, which it read as a compliment and creative expression. *(Fact. S.S. Rana)* Tribute was protected; trade was not. That is the line INQUILAB asks a law to write down. *(Interpretation)*

The fans have a word for how AI tools use a famous face without consent: face theft. Their answer is INQUILAB, a movement under #FreeTheFace that asks for an AI law for fans in five words: consent, share, labels, limits, credit. It is not a lawsuit, and it does not speak for the star or any studio. *(Interpretation)*

INQUILAB has a chant instead of a lawyer: "Inquilab King ke saath, aao aao leke apna haath." *(Fact: the INQUILAB page at agarmainkinghota.com; the author's essay, Act IX)* Its five demands spell out the AI law the fans want: consent, the star decides what is in the reserve; share, every licensed use pays the star and the owner of the work; labels, official and fan-made work clearly marked; limits, no deceptive deepfakes and no harmful or explicit use; credit, fan creators named and able to earn. *(Fact: the INQUILAB manifesto)*

The campaign applies the rule to itself. Its poster studio sends the film poster to the AI blurred, so no star's face reaches the model, tells the model to depict no real actor or public figure, and labels every finished poster "AI-made fan poster". *(Fact: the Make Your Poster studio at agarmainkinghota.com, 12 Oct 2026)* Its slogan is three words: "Your face. Not his." *(Fact)*

Ahead of the rule. India's February 2026 rules ask two things of realistic AI media: a prominent label and permanent provenance metadata. *(Fact. Hogan Lovells)* The fan studio does both: every finished poster carries the visible label and an AI provenance note written into the image file itself. *(Fact: the Make Your Poster studio at agarmainkinghota.com, 12 Oct 2026)* The rules are written for platforms, not fan sites; the studio follows them anyway. *(Interpretation)*

A working model: Lairs Cinema. The campaign's story game, King's Lairs, publishes its set designs: a glass dome on a frozen lake, a casino carved under a prison, a dance pit, an aquarium den. Fans animate them on their own AI accounts, star in them with their own faces, post the result and are credited and rewarded for it. The world is licensed and no face is stolen. If it works for a fan site, it can work for a studio. *(Interpretation; Act IX)*

The circle closes here. In 2011 the author's team built a hero who lived online before he lived on screen. In 2026 the audience builds the hero itself. The question is no longer whether fans will make the work. It is who owns the face when they do. *(Interpretation)*

Who owns a face when a million fans can render it? Will the first AI law for fans be written in a courtroom, or in a comment section? *(The author's questions; Act IX)*

The story ends here, in October 2026, two months before the film. What it means is the subject of the last Part. *(Interpretation)*

Room · The Galleria · SRKWorld, 2000

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: The Galleria

SRKWorld.com, 2000: "The Galleria", with Frozen Frames, Photo Finish, Face Off and Framed and Frozen. (Archive: the author's collection)

The rest of the website, as it looked in 2000, photographed on Internet Explorer screens. Every page was designed by the author with Shah Rukh Khan. *(Archive: the author's collection)*

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Stardome

"Stardome", the stars' section.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Johny Lever in Stardome

"Stardome": Johny Lever.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Anil Kapoor in Stardome

"Stardome": Anil Kapoor.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Juhi Chawla

Juhi Chawla's page.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Right Here Right Now

"Right Here Right Now".

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: College Daze

"College Daze".

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: The Third Eye

"The Third Eye", the news page, dated 11 November 2000.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Stark Exchange

"Stark Exchange", with its Millionaire of the Month.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Karma Cola

"Karma Cola", horoscopes and the Love-o-Meter.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Celebrations

"Celebrations", the festival calendar.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Travel Bug

"Travel Bug": Destinations, Red Book, Travelogue, Sightings, Travel Bytes.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Filmi Style

"Filmi Style" e-greetings.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Wishful Thinking

"Wishful Thinking" e-greetings.

Image — SRKWorld.com, 2000: Mithai Mail

"Mithai Mail" e-greetings.

Part Six · Log Out · What the arc means

Five Parts told the story in order. This one asks what it adds up to: for him, for Indian cinema, and for every brand that has a face, a story and a community. (Interpretation)

Chapter 19 · Zero to One: the codes of a career

Part Five ended in October 2026, two months before KING. This chapter steps back from the calendar and reads the whole career as a code. The author offers four keys to it. *(Interpretation; the author's essay* Asoka to Boo-Da*, Act X)*

1 · Alam Ara: the first oil strike. On 14 March 1931 *Alam Ara*, directed by Ardeshir Irani, opened at the Majestic Cinema in Bombay and ran for eight weeks: the first Indian film to speak. No print survives; in 2017 the British Film Institute called it the most important lost film of India. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Alam Ara)* If Indian cinema is an economy, that was its first oil strike: the day the screen found its voice, and a whole industry found the fuel it would run on for the next century. Every star since has been a well drilled into that same reserve. *(Interpretation; Act X)*

Ninety-five years later the reserve is being drilled again, by machines. The face of the most famous star in the country can be rendered by anyone with an AI account (Chapter 18). The campaign this book belongs to names its fan points STARKS for that reason: they

are the fans' share of the oil, earned by making posters, playing the lairs and spreading the word, and counted on a public Billboard. *(Interpretation; Act X)*

2 · Zero to One. Every machine on Earth speaks in two digits, 0 and 1. His filmography happens to spell the same code. *Zero* (2018) was the low point: an ambitious film, a hard fall and four years of silence (Chapter 12). *Ra.One* (2011) had already given him the "One": the superhero who lived online before he lived on screen (Chapter 9). KING is what you get when you go from zero to one again, this time with the whole audience watching. *(Interpretation; Act X)* Read the order the other way and it is the arc of this book: the One came first, built by a team on the internet; the Zero came after, when the founder stepped back; KING is the attempt to write the One again, in a world where the audience holds the keyboard. *(Interpretation)*

3 · A sur to an asur. For thirty years he was the sur: the note everyone hummed, the lover with open arms, Raj and Rahul (Chapter 5). KING asks him to play the other half of the word. An asur is the force that walks into the room and changes its temperature. Add one letter, and the hero becomes a whole new character. *(Interpretation; Act X)* He has played that half before: the killer of *Baazigar*, the stalker of *Darr*, the obsessive of *Anjaam*, all before he turned thirty (Chapter 5). The title line of 2025, "Darr nahi, dehshat hoon" (Chapter 16), announces the return of that half. *(Interpretation)* The marketing question is whether the audience that loved the sur will follow the asur. *Pathaan* and *Jawan* suggest they already have. *(Interpretation; Act X)*

4 · Asoka to Boo-Da. On 26 October 2001 he released *Asoka*, directed by Santosh Sivan and produced by him and Juhi Chawla under Dreamz Unlimited. It was selected for the Venice and Toronto film festivals, earned about ₹11.5 crore net in India and about US$1.8 million abroad, the fourth-highest-grossing Indian film overseas that year. *(Fact. Wikipedia: Asoka)* He played the emperor who conquered everything, saw the cost at Kalinga, and gave up his sword for the Buddha's path. The title of Part Three bends that story. Between Asoka and the Buddha sits the "boo": the jeers after *Zero*, the trolling, the October the whole country watched. Boo-Da is the man on the other side of the boos, someone the noise no longer reaches. *(Interpretation; Act X)*

Asoka renounced his throne. The question this book keeps open is whether this King will do the same. *(Interpretation; Act X)* The next chapter turns the four codes into six working lessons.

The arc in numbers, decade by decade

Decade	Credited film roles released	Made by his own company	Filmfare Best Actor wins	Brand rank in India (Duff & Phelps / Kroll)
1990s (1992 to 1999)	27	0	4	N/A (rankings began later)
2000s	23	7	3	N/A (rankings began later)
2010s	12	10	1	2nd (2017), 5th (2018 and 2019)
2020s to October 2026	3, with KING due	2, with KING due	0; first National Award (2025)	10th (2022), 3rd (2023 and 2024), 1st (2025)

(Fact, counts from Appendix B, Appendix C and Room · Advantage) Read down the columns and the arc of this book appears as numbers. The actor works constantly, then less; the producer owns more of each film; the awards come early; the market value comes last, and highest, after the silence. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 20 · Six lessons from one career

Every lesson below comes from a chapter of this thesis. *(Interpretation)*

1. **The founder is the medium.** Ra.One and Chennai Express worked because the star led the campaign himself. When the founder stepped back after 2013, the films still sold, but the story stopped travelling. *(Parts Two and Three)*
2. **Silence is a form of scarcity.** Four years with almost no interviews turned every appearance into an event. Pathaan crossed ₹1,000 crore with almost no promotion from its star. *(Part Four)*
3. **Communities outlast campaigns.** The fan clubs kept the birthday, the trends and the celebrations alive with no budget and no brief. A brand that owns a community never really goes off air. *(Parts Three and Five)*
4. **Turn one day into a ritual.** 2 November at the gate in Mumbai is free, annual, global and owned by the fans. Pathaan and Dunki both launched on it. *(Part Four)*
5. **Let people make the work.** The next campaign is not a billboard. It is a million fan-made posters, games and scenes. *(Part Five)*
6. **License the face before someone takes it.** Fans already make the work with AI. A brand that offers a licensed world, with sets, characters, rules and rewards, keeps the creativity and keeps control of its face. *(Part Five)*

The evidence, lesson by lesson. Each lesson rests on numbers in the chapters before it. *(Interpretation)*

The founder is the medium. When he led the story himself, the campaigns became systems: a NASDAQ bell and a trailer on every channel at once in 2010 (Chapter 8); a superhero sold through games, comics, fast food and a Google+ chat in 2011 (Chapter 9); a train moved by 750,000 tweets in 90 days in 2013 (Chapter 10). *(Fact; figures as cited in those chapters)* After 2013 every campaign still had a clever idea, but none became a system (Chapter 11). *(Interpretation)*

Silence is a form of scarcity. Between *Zero* in December 2018 and *Pathaan* in January 2023 there was no lead release. *Pathaan* then opened without media interviews and took ₹106 crore worldwide on its first day (Chapter 14). *(Fact)* Scarcity worked because there was a community to feel it. *(Interpretation)*

Communities outlast campaigns. In 2015 *Dilwale* passed ₹400 crore despite boycott calls, and the same year fans kept *DDLJ* running at Maratha Mandir when the cinema tried to end it (Chapters 5 and 11). *(Fact)* No budget bought either. *(Interpretation)*

Turn one day into a ritual. 2 November has carried the *Fan* teaser (2015), the *Pathaan* teaser (2022), *Dunki*'s Drop 1 (2023) and the KING title (2025). *(Fact; Chapters 11, 14 and 16)* Most brands spend millions trying to create one such day. *(Interpretation; Act XI)*

Let people make the work. The fan-made AI works about KING logged by October 2026 had nearly 2.9 million views before the studio showed more than a teaser (Chapter 18). *(Fact: the campaign's log)* The next campaign is not a billboard; it is a million fan-made posters. *(Interpretation; Act XI)*

License the face before someone takes it. Courts are already ordering AI fakes of stars taken down one case at a time (Chapter 18). *(Fact)* A brand that offers a licensed world, with sets, characters, rules and rewards, keeps the creativity and keeps control of its face. A brand that offers nothing gets the same work, with no credit, no labels and no share. *(Interpretation; Act XI)*

What the lessons cost. The same record shows the price. A direct line can be dangerous: a fan died on a railway platform in 2017 (Chapter 11). Speaking can turn a film into a target, as in 2010 and 2015, and silence can leave a man alone at his own gate, as in 2021 (Chapters 8, 11 and 13). *(Fact)* None of the six lessons is free. *(Interpretation)*

The lessons tested outside the book. The chapters above prove each lesson inside one career. The pages below test them against the wider record, with numbers this book has not used before. *(Method note)*

The founder's own channel, 2026. On 2 October 2026 his Instagram account, @iamsrk, had 48,386,086 followers and an engagement rate of 5.58%, which the analytics firm HypeAuditor rated "Good" for accounts of its size. *(Fact. HypeAuditor: @iamsrk, 2 Oct*

2026) A campaign led by the founder now starts on a channel he owns, not one he rents. *(Interpretation)*

Silence spends itself. The three releases of 2023 show what scarcity buys and how fast it is used up. *(Interpretation)*

Film	Release	Day-one India net	Day-one worldwide gross	Source
Pathaan	25 Jan 2023	₹57.00 crore	₹106 crore (Chapter 14)	Sacnilk
Jawan	7 Sept 2023	₹75 crore (early estimate)	₹129.6 crore (early estimate)	The Quint, 8 Sept 2023
Dunki	21 Dec 2023	₹29.20 crore	₹58.24 crore	Sacnilk, 22 Dec 2023

(Fact. as cited in each row; The Quint credits the India figure to Sacnilk) [Unverified: whether ₹129.6 crore is the producer's own published figure; The Quint does not name its source for the worldwide number] The second film after the silence opened higher than the first; the third, a smaller drama in the same year, opened at less than half of either. *(Fact, from the table)* Scarcity worked twice in eight months, then the absence was over. *(Interpretation)*

The community books the cinema. On 30 November 2022, eight weeks before Pathaan opened, the fan club SRK Universe announced first-day first shows in more than 200 cities. *(Fact. Koimoi, 1 Dec 2022)* Its co-founder, Yash Paryani, expected more than 50,000 fans, with seven or eight such shows in Mumbai and about six in Delhi. *(Fact. Odisha Bytes, 14 Jan 2023, citing Pinkvilla)* [Unverified: how many fans attended; 50,000 was a forecast] The fans had organised the opening before the studio had sold it. *(Interpretation)*

Let people make the work, and give them the tools. Other industries ran the last two lessons as products between 2023 and 2025. *(Interpretation)*

Case	Date	What it offered	Number	Source
Barbie AI selfie filter (Warner Bros., PhotoRoom, agency Bond)	Launched 3 Apr 2023	An AI filter that put fans' own selfies into the film's look	Used more than 13 million times by 27 July 2023	Marketing Dive, 27 July 2023

Case	Date	What it offered	Number	Source
Grimes, Elf.Tech	Announced 30 Apr 2023	Anyone may release songs in her AI voice	50% of master recording royalties to her	Mixmag, 5 May 2023
YouTube likeness detection	Rolled out to Partner Program creators, Oct 2025	Finds AI videos that copy a creator's face or voice; removal request from a dashboard, after an ID and selfie-video check	First wave of a global rollout	Business Today, 22 Oct 2025
ElevenLabs Iconic Marketplace	Unveiled at its first Summit, Nov 2025	Brands license famous AI voices with the rights holder's consent; Michael Caine joined; Matthew McConaughey is an investor	28 voices at launch, or "over 25"	eWeek, 12 Nov 2025; AlternativeTo

(Fact. as cited in each row; the two ElevenLabs sources give different counts, and both are shown) By 2026 the licensed face existed as a product in voice and in detection, in Hollywood and in music. *(Interpretation)* This book found no Indian film star who has opened a licensed AI-likeness programme to fans. [Unverified: whether any Indian film star has launched one, as of October 2026] The KING fans asked first (Chapter 18). *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 21 · The 360 fan franchise

Ra.One and Chennai Express were early versions of one model: a star's world run across five disciplines at once, Storytelling, Technology, Entertainment, Arts and Merchandising. The author calls it S.T.E.A.M. *(Eyewitness account; the author's framework)* A film uses one of them for a release. A franchise runs all five, all year, with the fans inside it. *(Interpretation)*

Read the career through those five disciplines and each one has a record. *(Interpretation)*

- **Storytelling.** Eighty film and television titles from 1988 to 2018, the archive this campaign's poster studio uses, then three films in 2023, each sold with its own story, from the NRI lover of 1995 to the migrant of *Dunki*. *(Fact; Chapters 4 to 14)*
- **Technology.** SRKWorld and Aryan Infomatics in 2000; Red Chillies VFX in 2006; Twitter in January 2010; Google+ in 2011; a Twitter-driven train and a missed-call line in 2013; a stake in an AI content company in 2026. *(Fact and Eyewitness account; Chapters 6 to 10 and 15)*
- **Entertainment.** *Temptations* tours from 2004, *Kaun Banega Crorepati* in 2007, the Knight Riders from 2008, the *SLAM!* tour in 2014, and a cricket ground in Los Angeles in 2026. *(Fact; Chapters 7, 11 and 15)*
- **Arts.** The illustrated G.One, its style guide and comic, and Shah Rock Jaan, the character created with the author in 2000. *(Eyewitness account; Chapters 6 and 9)*
- **Merchandising.** The Hyundai Santro in 1998, the Reebok range for *My Name Is Khan* in 2010, and the *Ra.One* licensing programme in 2011. *(Fact; Chapters 5, 8 and 9)*

What no campaign ever did was run all five at once, all year, with the fans inside it. *(Interpretation)*

Agar Main King Hota, the campaign this thesis belongs to, is a working test of that model for KING. Fans make posters (arts), play story games (entertainment), earn STARKS on a public Billboard (technology), write the myth (storytelling), and animate the lairs (all of it). *(Fact: the platform at agarmainkinghota.com)*

As of 18 October 2026 the platform runs nine sections and a merchandise shop. *(Fact: agarmainkinghota.com, checked by the site's live release check, 18 Oct 2026)*

- **Make Your Poster:** the Kingmaker studio. Fans pick one of 83 film posters (his 80 originals plus *Pathaan*, *Jawan* and *Dunki*) or KING itself, cast themselves and up to two friends into its characters, and receive a new AI-painted poster in which no star's face appears. Style editions of every poster, in 3D Pop and Anime, are being added; *Be King*, a second poster game by the fan developer Ganesh Vulidra, is coming.
- **King's Lairs:** a story game set in six invented lairs, with Lairs Cinema, where fans animate the published set designs with their own AI accounts and their own faces.
- **Chess81:** an original 9-by-9 chess variant built for the campaign, with *Rapid Fire*, a timed version by Ganesh Vulidra, coming.
- **Billboard:** the public table of STARKS, the fans' points, and the Fan-made AI Universe.
- **KING Buzz:** the daily intelligence dashboard, measured against the locked 4 October 2026 baseline.
- **Asoka to Boo-Da:** the author's essay, now Part Three of this book, and the book itself, published online section by section.
- **DOOM to KING:** the friendly Christmas fixture of Chapter 17.

- **Inquilaab:** the #FreeMyFace movement of Chapter 18. It was renamed on 18 October 2026 from Inquilab and #FreeTheFace, in a nod to Amitabh Bachchan's film *Inquilaab* (1984).
- **KING Fever:** seven original songs for KING, music produced by Ssubhro Ganguly, released one at a time.
- **Merch:** fifteen T-shirt designs by Shah Rock Jaan, printed on demand by store partners.

S.T.E.A.M., discipline by discipline. Each discipline that the career used one film at a time now has a permanent home on the platform. *(Interpretation)*

Discipline	In the career (chapters)	On the platform, October 2026
Storytelling	80 film and television titles to 2018; three films in 2023 (Chapters 4 to 14)	Asoka to Boo-Da and this book; the six story chapters of King's Lairs
Technology	SRKWorld 2000; Twitter 2010; Google+ 2011; a Twitter-driven train 2013 (Chapters 6 to 10)	The AI poster studio, the STARKS ledger, the KING Buzz dashboard
Entertainment	*Temptations* tours, *Kaun Banega Crorepati*, the Knight Riders, *SLAM!* (Chapters 7, 11 and 15)	King's Lairs, Chess81, the DOOM to KING fixture
Arts	The illustrated G.One; Shah Rock Jaan (Chapters 6 and 9)	Poster style editions; the KING Fever songs
Merchandising	Hyundai Santro 1998; Reebok 2010; *Ra.One* licensing 2011 (Chapters 5, 8 and 9)	The merch shop, 15 designs

(Fact for the career column, as cited in those chapters; Fact for the platform column: agarmainkinghota.com, 18 Oct 2026)

The first logged week. The platform counts its own activity in its database. Between 11 and 18 October 2026 it logged 54 unique visitors, 153 page views, 17 posters made in the studio, 98 daily-visit rewards and 2,121 STARKS earned. *(Fact: the platform's database, read on 18 Oct 2026; counts exclude automated test browsers)* These numbers are a starting line, recorded before any promotion, not a result. *(Interpretation)* Chapter 22 lists them as an open item: the test of the model begins when fans arrive in numbers, and this book will print the counts as they grow. *(Method note)*

Every page carries a Fan Wall where fans comment in up to 555 characters. *(Fact)* Each part is a working test of one of the six lessons. Whether the model works at scale is a question for the box office and the fans after 24 December 2026, and this book will report it when the numbers exist. *(Interpretation)*

Chapter 22 · What the evidence does not yet answer

The research agenda this thesis leaves open:

- What exactly happened outside Mannat on 4 October 2021, hour by hour? Photographs, news footage and police records would settle it.
- Did the events of 2021 change how he approaches public appearances, marketing and business? Only he can answer that.
- What did Ra.One's merchandise and licensing programme actually sell? The FICCI-KPMG 2012 report, read in full, gives no count; the licensees' records and the author's own files hold the numbers.
- How many fan-made AI works about KING exist across all platforms, and how many views do they hold? The daily log is a floor; a full census needs platform data.
- Who owns a star's face in the AI era, and who should be paid when it is used? The courts have not answered. The fans have started to.

And four questions only the next months can answer:

- How does KING open on 24 December 2026, and how does it play beside *Avengers: Doomsday*?
- Will the star speak before release, or let the silence sell a fourth film?
- Will any studio, his own included, license a star's face to fans on fair terms, as the Inquilab demands ask?
- What will the investigating agencies and courts finally record in the cases that followed October 2021?

Where each question stands, October 2026. For every open question, here is what the record holds today and what would close it. *(Method note)*

4 October 2021 at Mannat. The record today is one eyewitness account, the author's, that the gate stood almost empty on the day his son was remanded (Chapter 13). Later reports describe fans gathering on other days. *(Eyewitness account; Fact, as cited in Chapter 13)* What would close it: dated photographs or news footage of the gate on that day, and police deployment records for Bandstand. Until then the book keeps the account, labelled. *(Method note)*

What the events of 2021 changed. The pattern is on the record: no lead release between December 2018 and January 2023, and almost no interviews around *Pathaan*, *Jawan* and *Dunki* (Chapters 13 and 14). *(Fact)* Whether the silence was a choice, a strategy or a wound, only he can say. This book will not guess. *(Method note)*

Ra.One's licensing numbers. The record today: an online store, a style guide, a graphic novel and a game, reported by FICCI-KPMG in 2012; the figure of 64 merchandise items remains unconfirmed (Chapter 9 and Appendix D). *(Fact; Unverified, as listed)* What would close it: the licensees' sales reports and the campaign's own licensing files.

The census of fan-made AI work. The campaign's daily scan had found and linked 40 fan-made AI works about KING by 18 October 2026; the 21 that show public view counts had 2,883,120 views between them. *(Fact: the campaign's log, data/ai-creator-log.json, 18 Oct 2026)* This is a floor: the scan reads public posts on four platforms and cannot see private shares or platforms it does not search. A full census needs the platforms' own data. *(Method note)*

Who owns a star's face. The record today is a run of court orders protecting named actors one by one, from Amitabh Bachchan in November 2022 to the orders of February 2026, and amended IT Rules in force from 20 February 2026 that require AI content to be labelled and taken down within three hours on notice (Chapter 18). *(Fact, as cited in Chapter 18)* This book found no public record of Shah Rukh Khan seeking such an order. [Unverified: as of October 2026; Appendix D] This book found no Indian film star with a licensed AI-likeness programme open to fans (Chapter 20). *(Interpretation, from a search result)*

Does the fan franchise work at scale? The platform's first logged week, 11 to 18 October 2026, counted 54 unique visitors, 153 page views, 17 posters and 2,121 STARKS (Chapter 21). *(Fact: the platform's database)* The question is what those numbers become between his birthday on 2 November and the release on 24 December. *(Method note)*

This book will add the answers as they arrive, labelled Fact, and leave the rest open. *(Interpretation)*

Epilogue · What is Mr. Khan cooking?

Look at the last four years as a list. A comeback that broke every promotional rule. A National Award, 33 years in. A cricket ground in Los Angeles. A stake in an AI content company. And a film called KING, arriving at Christmas, six days after Marvel's biggest villain. *(Fact: Part Four)*

A man who tried to build a digital kingdom in 2000, built a superhero universe in 2011 and taught a train to run on tweets in 2013 does not invest in AI by accident. *(Interpretation)*

This thesis does not claim to know what comes next. It only notes that the boy from Delhi has always arrived a decade before the industry: online before the internet, a universe before the franchises, a fan movement before the platforms.

The posts are climbing. The views are climbing. The fans are already in the theatre in their heads. This is the hype of KING. *(Interpretation; the author's essay, Act XII)*

The campaign this book belongs to keeps running in public while the book is written: from his birthday on 2 November 2026 to the release on 24 December, every poster, every lair, every comment and every count is logged where anyone can read it. *(Fact: agarmainkinghota.com)* The last chapter of this story will not be written by the author, or by him. It will be written by the people at the gate. *(Interpretation)*

Asoka renounced his throne. This time, the KING is going in for the Royal Flush.

What is Mr. Khan cooking? The answer, as always, will come on his own terms.

Appendix A · The chronology, 1946 to 2026

Every line below is sourced in the chapter or room named in the last column. This is the book's spine on one page. *(Method note)*

Year	Event	Where in this book
1946	Mir Taj Mohammed Khan comes from Peshawar to Delhi to study law	Ch 1
1947	Partition; he stays in Delhi	Ch 1
1959	His parents marry	Ch 1
1960	His sister, Shahnaz Lalarukh, is born	Ch 1
1965	Born in New Delhi, 2 November; first five years in Mangalore	Ch 1
mid-1970s	A boy of about ten serves at the National School of Drama in Delhi	Ch 1
1970s to 1985	St. Columba's School; Brother Eric D'Souza; Sword of Honour	Ch 2
1981	His father dies of cancer	Ch 2
1984	Meets Gauri Chhibber in Delhi	Ch 2
1985 to 1988	Hansraj College; Theatre Action Group under Barry John	Ch 3

Year	Event	Where in this book
1988	First advertisement, Liberty Shoes; *Dil Dariya* begins shooting	Advantage; Ch 4
1989	*Fauji* premieres on Doordarshan, 18 January; *Circus* follows	Ch 4
1991	His mother dies; moves to Mumbai in April; marries Gauri, 25 October	Ch 4; Ram To Krishna
1992	*Deewana*, his film debut, in June	Ch 5
1993	*Baazigar* and *Darr*: the villain years	Ch 5
1995	*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*	Ch 5
1997	Son Aryan born; *Dil To Pagal Hai*	Ram To Krishna; Ch 5
1998	Hyundai Santro; *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*	Advantage; Ch 5
1999	Dreamz Unlimited founded with Juhi Chawla and Aziz Mirza	Ch 6; ArclightZ
2000	SRKWorld.com; daughter Suhana born; *Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani*	Ch 6; Blueprint
2001	*Asoka*; buys the house that becomes Mannat	Ch 6; Ram To Krishna
2002	Red Chillies Entertainment founded with Gauri Khan	ArclightZ
2003	*Chalte Chalte*; Dreamz partners part; spine surgery in London	Ch 7
2004	*Main Hoon Na*, *Veer-Zaara*, *Swades*; Temptations tour	Ch 7
2005	Padma Shri; *Paheli* is India's Academy Award entry; first "Lux girl"	Ch 7; Advantage
2006	Red Chillies VFX founded; *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna*; *Don*	Ch 7; ArclightZ
2007	*Kaun Banega Crorepati*; *Chak De! India*; *Om Shanti Om*	Ch 7
2008	Buys the Kolkata IPL franchise for US$75.09 million	Ch 7; ArclightZ
2009	Held at Newark airport, 14 August	Ch 7; Ch 8
2010	Joins Twitter; *My Name Is Khan*, 12 February	Ch 8

Year	Event	Where in this book
2011	*Ra.One*: the digital kingdom	Ch 9
2012	Yale Chubb Fellowship; KKR's first IPL title; Wankhede ban	Tall Tales; Ch 10
2013	*Chennai Express*: the audience moves the train; son AbRam born	Ch 10; Ram To Krishna
2014	*Happy New Year*; KKR's second title	Ch 11
2015	The "intolerance" remark on his 50th birthday; *Dilwale*	Ch 11
2016	*Fan*; *Dear Zindagi*	Ch 11
2017	TED talk; *Raees*; the Vadodara train	Tall Tales; Ch 11
2018	Crystal Award at Davos; *Zero*, 21 December	Tall Tales; Ch 12
2019	Letterman on Netflix; no film release	Ch 13; Tall Tales
2020	Covid relief; *Betaal* and *Class of '83* for Netflix	Ch 13; ArclightZ
2021	Cadbury's AI ad; his son's arrest in October and release on bail	Advantage; Ch 13
2022	Brand value falls to 10th; cameos in *Rocketry* and *Brahmastra*	Advantage; Ch 13
2023	*Pathaan*, *Jawan* and *Dunki*: about ₹2,669 crore worldwide; Suhana's debut in *The Archies*	Ch 14; Ram To Krishna
2024	KKR's third title; Locarno career award; enters the Hurun rich list	Ch 15
2025	Met Gala; first National Award, for *Jawan*; Aryan's series on Netflix; billionaire on the Hurun list; 60th birthday and the KING title	Ch 15; Ch 16
2026	Visa ambassador; KING release date set; fans begin making him with AI; *Avengers: Doomsday* (18 December) and KING (24 December)	Ch 15 to 18

(Fact. each line as sourced in the chapter or room named)

Appendix B · The films, 1992 to 2026

His credited roles in feature films, cameos and narrations listed separately below. "His own company" means Dreamz Unlimited (2000 to 2003) or Red Chillies Entertainment (from 2004). *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography and Wikipedia: Red Chillies Entertainment, October 2026)*

#	Year	Film	Role	His own company produced
1	1992	Deewana	Raja Sahai	No
2	1992	Chamatkar	Sundar Shrivastav	No
3	1992	Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman	Raj Mathur	No
4	1992	Dil Aashna Hai	Karan Singh	No
5	1993	Kabhi Haan Kabhi Naa	Sunil	No
6	1993	King Uncle	Anil Bansal	No
7	1993	Maya Memsaab	Lalit Kumar	No
8	1993	Baazigar	Ajay Sharma / Vicky Malhotra	No
9	1993	Darr	Rahul Mehra	No
10	1994	Anjaam	Vijay Agnihotri	No
11	1995	Karan Arjun	Arjun Singh / Vijay Singh Sharma	No
12	1995	Zamaana Deewana	Rahul Malhotra	No
13	1995	Guddu	Guddu Bahadur	No
14	1995	Oh Darling! Yeh Hai India!	Hero	No
15	1995	Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge	Raj Malhotra	No
16	1995	Ram Jaane	Ram Jaane	No
17	1995	Trimurti	Romi Singh	No
18	1996	English Babu Desi Mem	Gopal, Hari and Vikram Mayur	No

#	Year	Film	Role	His own company produced
19	1996	Chaahat	Roop Rathore	No
20	1997	Koyla	Shankar Thakur	No
21	1997	Yes Boss	Rahul Joshi	No
22	1997	Pardes	Arjun Sagar	No
23	1997	Dil To Pagal Hai	Rahul	No
24	1998	Duplicate	Bablu Chaudhry / Manu Dada	No
25	1998	Dil Se..	Amarkant Verma	No
26	1998	Kuch Kuch Hota Hai	Rahul Khanna	No
27	1999	Baadshah	Raj (Baadshah)	No
28	2000	Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani	Ajay Bakshi	Yes
29	2000	Hey Ram	Amjad Khan	No
30	2000	Josh	Max Dias	No
31	2000	Mohabbatein	Raj Aryan Malhotra	No
32	2001	One 2 Ka 4	Arun Verma	No
33	2001	Asoka	Ashoka Maurya	Yes
34	2001	Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham	Rahul Raichand	No
35	2002	Hum Tumhare Hain Sanam	Gopal	No
36	2002	Devdas	Devdas Mukherjee	No
37	2002	Shakti: The Power	Jai Singh	No
38	2003	Chalte Chalte	Raj Mathur	Yes
39	2003	Kal Ho Naa Ho	Aman Mathur	No
40	2004	Yeh Lamhe Judaai Ke	Dushant	No
41	2004	Main Hoon Na	Ram Prasad Sharma	Yes
42	2004	Veer-Zaara	Veer Pratap Singh	No

#	Year	Film	Role	His own company produced
43	2004	Swades	Mohan Bhargav	No
44	2005	Paheli	Kishanlal / the ghost	Yes
45	2006	Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna	Dev Saran	No
46	2006	Don	Don / Vijay Pal	No
47	2007	Chak De! India	Kabir Khan	No
48	2007	Om Shanti Om	Om Kapoor / Om Prakash Makhija	Yes
49	2008	Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi	Surinder Sahni / Raj Kapoor	No
50	2009	Billu	Sahir Khan	Yes
51	2010	My Name Is Khan	Rizwan Khan	Yes
52	2011	Ra.One	G.One / Shekhar Subramaniam	Yes
53	2011	Don 2	Don	Yes
54	2012	Jab Tak Hai Jaan	Samar Anand	No
55	2013	Chennai Express	Rahul Mithaiwala	Yes
56	2014	Happy New Year	Charlie Sharma	Yes
57	2015	Dilwale	Raj / Kaali	Yes
58	2016	Fan	Aryan Khanna / Gaurav Chandna	No
59	2016	Dear Zindagi	Dr. Jehangir Khan	Yes
60	2017	Raees	Raees Aalam	Yes
61	2017	Jab Harry Met Sejal	Harry Nehra	Yes
62	2018	Zero	Bauua Singh	Yes
63	2023	Pathaan	Pathaan	No
64	2023	Jawan	Vikram and Azad Rathore	Yes
65	2023	Dunki	Hardy Singh Dhillon	Yes

#	Year	Film	Role	His own company produced
66	2026	KING	N/A (not announced)	Yes

Cameos, special appearances and narrations (33): Pehla Nasha (1993); Army (1996); Dushman Duniya Ka (1996); Gudgudee (1997); Achanak (1998); Har Dil Jo Pyar Karega (2000); Gaja Gamini (2000); Saathiya (2002); Kuchh Meetha Ho Jaye (2005); Kaal (2005); Silsiilay (2005); Alag (2006); I See You (2006); Heyy Babyy (2007); Krazzy 4 (2008); Bhoothnath (2008); Shaurya (2008); Kismat Konnection (2008); Luck by Chance (2009); Dulha Mil Gaya (2010); Shahrukh Bola "Khoobsurat Hai Tu" (2010); Always Kabhi Kabhi (2011); Love Breakups Zindagi (2011); Bombay Talkies (2013); Bhoothnath Returns (2014); Bhaag Jeetu Bhaag (2016); Ae Dil Hai Mushkil (2016); Tubelight (2017); The Zoya Factor (2019); Rocketry: The Nambi Effect (2022); Laal Singh Chaddha (2022); Brahmastra: Part One (2022); Tiger 3 (2023). *(Fact. Wikipedia: Shah Rukh Khan filmography)*

What the list shows. 65 credited roles were released between 1992 and 2023. *(Fact, count from the table)* 27 of them came in his first eight years, 1992 to 1999, and none was made by his own company. Of the 16 released from 2009 to 2023, 13 were made by his own company; the three exceptions are *Jab Tak Hai Jaan*, *Fan* and *Pathaan*. *(Fact, count from the table)* The actor who worked for others became the producer who hired himself. *(Interpretation)* [Unverified: the classification of *Billu* and *Dear Zindagi*, which some sources call a special appearance and a supporting role.]

Appendix C · Honours

(Fact. all rows: Wikipedia: List of awards and nominations received by Shah Rukh Khan, October 2026, unless another source is named)

Filmfare Best Actor (8 wins; 16 Filmfare Awards in all)

Ceremony	Film	Chapter
1994	Baazigar	Ch 5
1996	Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge	Ch 5
1998	Dil To Pagal Hai	Ch 5
1999	Kuch Kuch Hota Hai	Ch 5
2003	Devdas	Ch 6
2005	Swades	Ch 7

Ceremony	Film	Chapter
2008	Chak De! India	Ch 7
2011	My Name Is Khan	Ch 8

He also won Filmfare's Best Actor (Critics) for *Kabhi Haan Kabhi Naa* (1994) and *Mohabbatein* (2001).

State and international honours

Year	Honour	Given by
2005	Padma Shri	Government of India
2007	Ordre des Arts et des Lettres (Officier)	France (Filmibeat, 21 June 2007)
2011	Pyramide con Marni	UNESCO
2014	Légion d'honneur	France
2017	Yash Chopra National Memorial Award	Indian Television Academy
2018	Crystal Award	World Economic Forum, Davos
2024	Pardo alla Carriera	Locarno Film Festival
2025	National Film Award, Best Actor in a Leading Role, for *Jawan* (shared with Vikrant Massey)	Government of India

Honorary doctorates

Year	Institution
2009	University of Bedfordshire
2015	University of Edinburgh
2016	Maulana Azad National Urdu University
2019	La Trobe University
2019	University of Law

[Unverified: the grade of the Légion d'honneur, from the French government's record.] Of the eight Filmfare Best Actor awards, five came at the ceremonies of 1994 to 2003, his first eleven years in film. The first National Award came 33 years after his debut. *(Fact,*

count from the tables; Interpretation of the gap is left to the reader)

Appendix D · Open items: what is still to be proved

Every claim this book could not yet verify stays in the text, marked [Unverified]. This register lists them in one place, so that an editor, a fact-checker or the author can close them one by one. Eleven need the author's own archive or memory; the rest need a public record. *(Method note; generated from the manuscript, 12 October 2026)*

#	Section	What is needed	Who can supply it
1	Chapter 1 · Diaper Days	The restaurant's name and the NSD contract need a primary source, such as an NSD record or a family statement	Public record
2	Chapter 1 · Diaper Days	His father's election: the constituency, the year and the result, from an Election Commission record	Public record
3	Chapter 1 · Diaper Days	Which family member held the NSD canteen	Public record
4	Chapter 1 · Diaper Days	Whether any other Indian star put his childhood online in his own words in 2000	Public record
5	Chapter 2 · From School To Cool	The year of the Sword of Honour, from the school's records	Public record
6	Chapter 2 · From School To Cool	What his mother ran after 1981 and for how long	Public record
7	Chapter 3 · Campus Cackle	The Theatre Action Group plays he acted in, with years and roles	The author
8	Chapter 3 · Campus Cackle	The year and the name of the IIT entrance exam	Public record
9	Chapter 3 · Campus Cackle	In what capacity he attended the National School of Drama	Public record
10	Chapter 4 · TV Cereal	Whether *Idiot* was broadcast on Doordarshan, from the channel's records	Public record

#	Section	What is needed	Who can supply it
11	Chapter 4 · TV Cereal	The number of television households in India in 1989	Public record
12	Room · Ram To Krishna	The year of Lateef Fatima's death, 1990 or 1991, from a primary record	Public record
13	Room · Ram To Krishna	The date Mannat was renamed	Public record
14	Room · Ram To Krishna	A valuation of Mannat by a named valuer	Public record
15	Room · Ram To Krishna	A measurement behind the claim that Mannat is the third most photographed place in India	Public record
16	Room · Ram To Krishna	His own explanation of the title; the author's recollection	The author
17	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	TechShastra's registration papers or incorporation date	The author
18	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	Whether "Arc Lights" on the site is the same company as Arclightz Films	The author
19	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	The press clippings of 2000	The author
20	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	The year ShahRocK & Bubbles was first drawn, and its first appearance	The author
21	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	Box-office figure for *One 2 Ka 4*	Public record
22	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	The month SRKWorld.com went offline	The author
23	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	Source and exact words of his "turning point" remark	The author
24	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	The brands he endorsed from 2000 to 2003, with years	The author
25	Room · ArclightZ	Effects awards claimed for *Don* (2006), *Om Shanti Om* (2007) and *Fan* (2016)	Public record

#	Section	What is needed	Who can supply it
26	Room · ArclightZ	When the Knight Riders Group entered Major League Cricket and the ILT20	Public record
27	Room · ArclightZ	Red Chillies' revenue and profit by year, from the Registrar of Companies	Public record
28	Room · Advantage	Start and end year for each brand	Public record
29	Room · Advantage	The years of the Pepsi association	Public record
30	Room · Advantage	Whether the Cadbury ad won a Titanium Lion, from the Cannes Lions archive	Public record
31	Room · Advantage	The number of shops, ads and postcodes in the Cadbury campaign	Public record
32	Chapter 9 · The Wall II	Ra.One's licensing records	The author
33	Chapter 10 · The Wall II	Whether *Chennai Express* won a Filmfare award	Public record
34	Room · Tall Tales	Whether he was the first Indian actor to speak at TED	Public record
35	Room · Tall Tales	The Netflix release date of the Letterman special	Public record
36	Room · Tall Tales	Dates and outlets of other long interviews: *Koffee with Karan*, NDTV, *The Anupam Kher Show*	Public record
37	Chapter 12 · Zero	Whether any Indian star of his rank had played a physically diminished lead before *Zero*	Public record
38	Chapter 12 · Zero	Audience research or exit polling on why it failed	Public record
39	Chapter 12 · Zero	Its Chinese release date and Chinese gross	Public record
40	Chapter 13 · The silence	Whether he has made any public statement on the 2021 case	Public record

#	Section	What is needed	Who can supply it
41	Room · Just Like That	The original occasion and date of each undated line	Public record
42	Room · Just Like That	The broadcast date of "the last of the stars"	Public record
43	Room · Just Like That	The text of his 2000 website column, with his permission	The author
44	Chapter 14 · 2023	Whether any Indian actor has had a higher combined worldwide gross in one calendar year	Public record
45	Chapter 15 · The empire	Hurun's method; its figure is an estimate	Public record
46	Chapter 16 · KING	The cameo list, when the makers confirm it	Public record
47	Chapter 16 · KING	The budget, when the producers publish one	Public record
48	Chapter 17 · DOOM to KING	*Avengers: Doomsday*'s India release date	Public record
49	Appendix B · The films	How to classify *Billu* and *Dear Zindagi*	Public record
50	Appendix C · Honours	The grade of his Légion d'honneur	Public record
51	Chapter 7 · Opening Office	Veer-Zaara's India gross (₹58 crore or more than ₹94 crore), from a trade record such as Box Office India	Public record
52	Chapter 7 · Opening Office	The reason Star Plus gave for moving the Paanchvi Pass launch from 18 to 25 April 2008	Public record
53	Chapter 18 · Fan Mail	The number of fans outside Mannat and at SRK Day on 2 November 2025, from a police or organiser figure	Public record
54	Chapter 18 · Fan Mail	Whether Shah Rukh Khan has filed for personality-rights protection in any court, as of 17 October 2026	Public record

#	Section	What is needed	Who can supply it
55	Chapter 18 · Fan Mail	Whether Denmark's voice-and-appearance amendment entered force on 31 March 2026	Public record
56	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	Whether Venus Films and the Venus music label named at the SRKWorld launch are the same Jain family business	Public record
57	Chapter 6 · Going Digital	Dates of Red Chillies' incorporation and of the Dreamz Unlimited merger (2002, 2003 or 2004), from the Registrar of Companies	Public record
58	Chapter 20 · Six lessons	Whether ₹129.6 crore, Jawan's day-one worldwide gross, is the producer's own published figure, and its original source	Public record
59	Chapter 20 · Six lessons	How many fans attended SRK Universe's Pathaan first-day shows in January 2023 (50,000 was the club's forecast)	Public record or the fan club
60	Chapter 20 · Six lessons	Whether any Indian film star has launched a licensed AI-likeness programme for fans, as of October 2026	Public record

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Added for Chapter 18 (pass of 17 Oct 2026): Deccan Herald, 2 Nov 2025 (Mannat appearance cancelled) · The Hollywood Reporter India, 3 Nov 2025 (SRK Day, Bandra) · Siasat, 3 Nov 2025 (fan meet crowd) · Hogan Lovells (IT Rules amendment, 2026) · Verfassungsblog, 26 Mar 2026 (Denmark) · Storyboard18 (personality-rights orders) · DNA, 14 Oct 2025 (Hrithik Roshan) · The Hollywood Reporter India, 16 Sep 2025 (Aishwarya Rai Bachchan) · Akin Gump (TAKE IT DOWN Act) · Mondaq, 27 May 2024 and S.S. Rana (Jackie Shroff) · AP via News4JAX, 21 Mar 2024 (ELVIS Act) · Business Today, 20 Sep 2023 (Anil Kapoor) · The Week, 25 Nov 2022 (Amitabh Bachchan).

Added for Chapter 20 (pass of 18 Oct 2026): HypeAuditor (Instagram followers, 2 Oct 2026) · Sacnilk (Pathaan day one) · The Quint, 8 Sept 2023 (Jawan day one) · Sacnilk, 22 Dec 2023 (Dunki day one) · Koimoi, 1 Dec 2022 and Odisha Bytes, 14 Jan 2023 (SRK Universe shows) · Marketing Dive, 27 July 2023 (Barbie filter) · Mixmag, 5 May 2023 (Elf.Tech) · Business Today, 22 Oct 2025 (YouTube likeness detection) · eWeek, 12 Nov 2025 and AlternativeTo (ElevenLabs Iconic Marketplace).